

Govt drafts semiconductor policy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is framing a semiconductor policy aimed at positioning the capital as a key hub for semiconductor design, advanced research and development, assembly and allied activities.

The policy aligned with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat will develop a semiconductor ecosystem in Delhi, with a focus on design, research and industry development in the state capital, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said in a statement.

The Chief Minister noted that the semiconductor sector has emerged as a critical pillar of the global economy, and the Delhi government is working on the comprehensive policy framework to ensure its balanced and structured development.

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— REKHA GUPTA, CHIEF MINISTER

driven ecosystem, she said.

The proposed policy will be structured around five key pillars — semiconductor design and intellectual property development; research, development and innovation; manufacturing-enabling activities such as assembly, testing, marking and packaging (ATMP) and outsourced semiconductor assembly and testing (OSAT),

along with the development of ancillary industries; talent development and skilling; and strengthening of the startup and industrial ecosystem, it said.

The Chief Minister said the policy is expected to strengthen Delhi's position in high-value segments of the semiconductor value chain, particularly in design, research and development,

and advanced packaging. It is likely to attract investments from fabless semiconductor companies and startups, as well as ATMP and OSAT units. The policy will also support the growth of ancillary industries linked to testing, packaging, and semiconductor inputs.

Highlighting the employment potential, the Chief Minister said the policy will generate high-quality job opportunities in areas such as chip design, semiconductor research, and advanced packaging. It also aims to promote skill development through targeted training programmes, internships, and industry-academia partnerships. The initiative is expected to help attract and retain skilled professionals, further strengthening Delhi's position as a hub of knowledge and innovation.

"The policy places emphasis on targeted incentives, reduction in operational costs, and the creation of a conducive business environment to boost private investment. Measures such as

capital subsidies, infrastructure development, and alignment with national initiatives, particularly the India Semiconductor Mission, are expected to enhance investor confidence and encourage participation from both domestic and global players," it said.

She expressed confidence that its effective implementation will lead to the development of a robust, innovation-driven, and sustainable semiconductor ecosystem in the capital.

The Chief Minister further noted that the Prime Minister has consistently emphasised that in the digital economy of the 21st century, semiconductors are not merely industrial products but form the foundation of technological sovereignty, national security, and economic strength. In line with this forward-looking vision, states are being encouraged to undertake policy initiatives to build a strong, coordinated and globally competitive semiconductor ecosystem across India.

Govt to set up Karmik Sewa Kendras

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will set up "Karmik Sewa Kendras" across the city, based on the Passport Seva Kendra model, for registration of construction workers and delivery of services and welfare schemes to them.

According to officials on Sunday, the Delhi Building and Other Construction Workers Welfare Board (DBOCWWB) has begun the process of engaging an agency to design and develop 13 static and 13 mobile KSKs to cater to the migrant and local labour population in the city.

The initiative is aiming to support nearly 30 lakh people, especially those belonging to vulnerable sections such as migrant workers and those employed in unorganised sectors, they added.

The selected agency will also develop 39 Labour Chowks, three each in Delhi's 13 districts, to facilitate various schemes of the welfare board throughout the national capital, they said.

The need for establishing



the KSKs has been identified due to the persistent challenges faced by workers in accessing critical worker-related services, said an official document.

"By creating a network of service centres modelled on the Passport Seva Kendra (PSK) framework, the project aims to mitigate these issues significantly," it said.

The plan behind the setting up of Karmika Seva Kendra has drawn inspiration from the "highly successful" Passport Seva Kendra (PSK) model, which transformed passport services in the country, said a senior Delhi government officer.

By enhancing accessibility, efficiency, and worker satis-

faction through time-bound registrations and maintaining proper records of the eligible workers to whom the benefits of welfare schemes are to be delivered, the KSK project seeks to replicate similar success as achieved by the PSKs, he said.

The initiative aims to reduce wait times, improve service delivery standards, and ensure a high degree of worker satisfaction by providing streamlined, efficient, and user-friendly services related to workers, officials said.

In addition, the establishment of Labour Chowks under the project will provide a structured and organised platform for workers to access employment opportunities, basic amenities, and welfare-related services at designated locations, they said.

According to the documents, the KSK facilitation centres will be technologically equipped and house completely artificial intelligence-based digital Seva Kendras, with minimal manual interface, so that the process can operate autonomously, it said.

Police bust LPG racket, 125 cylinders seized

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have uncovered two illegal LPG storage and refilling operations in the city, seizing 125 cylinders and arresting three men involved in the racket. All three accused were authorised delivery agents who allegedly diverted domestic gas supplies for illegal resale, officials said on Sunday.

The two separate operations were carried out in Rohini and Sangam Vihar, where police found evidence of large-scale hoarding and unauthorised gas transfer.

In the first case, a raid in the Rama Vihar area of Rohini led to the recovery of 57 cylinders, including 50 that were filled. Police also seized a pickup vehicle, a weighing scale, and equipment used for transferring gas. A 55-year-old man identified as Lokpal was arrested at the spot.

In the second operation in Sangam Vihar, police seized 68 cylinders. This included 36 filled cylinders, 29 empty ones, and three with broken seals. Two men, Deepak, 37,



and Shyam, 45, were taken into custody in connection with the case.

According to police, the accused were part of a network that misused their role as delivery personnel. Instead of supplying LPG cylinders to consumers, they allegedly diverted them and stored them illegally. Small quantities of gas were then extracted from filled cylinders and used to refill empty ones.

A senior police officer said the accused used both machines and manual methods to transfer gas. Typically, they removed one to two kilograms of LPG from each cylinder. The refilled cylinders were then sold in the open market at higher prices.

Investigators said this practice not only led to illegal profits but also created artificial shortages in the supply chain. By withholding cylinders meant for customers, the accused disrupted normal distribution and increased demand in the grey market.

Police added that such unauthorised refilling poses serious safety risks. The use of unregulated equipment and improper handling of gas cylinders can lead to accidents, including leaks and explosions.

During the raids, officers recovered tools commonly used in illegal gas transfer. These included refuelling motors and other devices that allowed the accused to

carry out the operation without detection.

Authorities said the involvement of authorised delivery agents made the racket more concerning. Their access to LPG supplies enabled them to divert stock without raising immediate suspicion.

A case has been registered against all three accused. Police are now trying to identify others who may be part of the network. Officials said the investigation will focus on tracing the supply chain and identifying buyers who purchased the illegally refilled cylinders.

The arrests have brought attention to the misuse of domestic LPG distribution systems. Police said strict action will be taken against those involved in similar activities. Officials also urged residents to remain alert and report any suspicious sale of gas cylinders. They advised consumers to purchase LPG only through authorised channels to avoid safety risks and ensure proper supply. The investigation is ongoing, and further arrests have not been ruled out.

Congress demands implementation of women's reservation on current Lok Sabha strength

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Sunday demanded immediate implementation of women's reservation on the existing Lok Sabha strength as it staged a protest against the Modi government, accusing it of deliberately delaying the women's quota for political reasons.

The protest by the Delhi Pradesh Congress Committee comes two days after the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill to implement 33 per cent reservation for women in legislatures in 2029 and increase the number of Lok Sabha seats to 816 was defeated in the Lok Sabha.

Congress general secretary in charge of communications Jairam Ramesh, who participated in the protest, said, "When the bill was passed, we (the Congress) demanded that the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam' be implemented from the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. That demand was ignored,



Congress workers burn an effigy during a protest march towards the BJP headquarters over the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill on women's reservation in New Delhi

and we were told the date when it would be enforced would be notified later. They kept silent for nearly 30 months. Suddenly, on the night of April 16, the bill was notified."

The protest, led by Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav, saw party workers march towards the BJP headquarters, raising slogans as part of their demonstration. Among those present were senior leaders, including All

India Mahila Congress president Alka Lamba, Delhi Women's Congress chief Pushpa Singh and AICC spokesperson Ragini Nayak. Addressing the gathering, Yadav said the protest was aimed at pressing for the immediate implementation of women's reservation on the existing 543 Lok Sabha seats.

"Our protest today is for the demand for women's reservation, which has been

ongoing for many years. The bill was introduced in Parliament in 2023 and passed unanimously. Today, once again, the BJP is trying to push the delimitation exercise under the garb of women's reservation. If you are truly well-wishers of women, then implement reservation within the 543 seats of the current Lok Sabha," he said.

AICC spokesperson Ragini Nayak alleged that the Centre had deliberately linked the quota with delimitation to delay its rollout.

"In 2023, the entire opposition supported the women's reservation law, but the Modi government attached two conditions, census and delimitation, thus postponing it. Even today, we are saying, implement reservation on 543 seats," she said. Several Congress protesters gathered at the Delhi Congress office near the Rouse Avenue Court, torched an effigy of the prime minister and attempted to march towards the BJP headquarters.

Minister unveils Phirni Road in Dariyapur Kalan



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Minister for Social Welfare, SC/ST/OBC Welfare and MLA from Bawana Assembly Constituency, Ravinder Indraj Singh, inaugurated the newly constructed Phirni Road in Dariyapur Kalan, developed at an approximate cost of ₹5.73 crore.

The road connects the Dada Maldev Talab side to Nangal Mor Road, Bawana, thereby significantly enhancing connectivity in the region.

The project has been completed under the Delhi Village Development Board (DVDB) fund, with key support from the Irrigation and Flood Control Department.

Pending for nearly 20 years, the project has now been suc-

cessfully completed, marking a major achievement for the local residents. Despite consistent public demand over the years, no substantial action had been taken earlier. With the completion of this road, development in Dariyapur and nearby areas has gained new momentum.

The construction of this Phirni Road will provide thousands of residents with smooth, safe and faster connectivity. It will reduce travel time and improve traffic management in the area. The project represents a significant step towards strengthening basic infrastructure in rural parts of Delhi.

Local residents shared that villages such as Dariyapur and Sultanpur Dabas had long remained on the margins of development. However, with ongoing works in the region, visible improvements are now being experienced, leading to a better quality of life.

Residents expressed their gratitude towards the Hon'ble Minister Shri Ravinder Indraj Singh, stating that his efforts have brought new hope for development in rural areas and ensured that people are now receiving the benefits of essential infrastructure for the first time.

IP University to conduct CETs 2026-27 from April 25

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IP University is going to conduct its Common Entrance Tests (CETs) leading to admissions for various programmes for the academic session 2026-27 from April 25 to May 23.

According to the Controller of Examinations of the University, Dr S.L. Bhandarkar, the CETs will be conducted on traditional OMR sheets in two shifts (morning & evening) on every Saturday & Sunday during the period.

The morning shift will be from 10 am to 12.30 pm, and the evening shift will be from 2.30 pm to 5 pm.



"For 78 programmes, a total of 50,531 applicants are going to appear for these CETs. Except for PhDs, CETs of 9th and 10th May will be conducted at four outstation cities — Chandigarh, Jaipur, Lucknow, and Kolkata — apart from Delhi NCR-located centres," said Dr Bhandarkar.

The admit card can be downloaded from the university website around five to six days before the

conduct of the concerned CETs. No request for change of date, session, centre related to CETs will be entertained, informed Dr. Bhandarkar.

There will be a single examination paper for two CET codes, 119 and 124, for paramedical programmes of the university.

For any assistance related to CETs, applicants may contact helpline numbers 25302263 & 25302278 and also mail at cet@ipu.ac.in & coe2@ipu.ac.in

All the applicants of CETs are requested to keep visiting the university websites www.ipu.ac.in & www.ipu.admissions.nic.in regularly for further details & updates in this regard.

Noida: Teen donates part of liver to save ailing grandmother, pauses board exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Noida

A 19-year-old youth from Bihar put his class 12 board examinations on hold to donate a portion of his liver and save his 62-year-old grandmother suffering from advanced liver disease in a display of generous spirit and deep affection, doctors said on Sunday.

The youth, Aditya Raj, volunteered as a donor for his grandmother, Sunita Devi, who had been battling liver cirrhosis for over a year — a serious condition marked by repeated hospitalisations, accumulation of fluid in the abdomen (ascites) and increasing physical weakness. Doctors at Max Super

Speciality Hospital, Vaishali, said that as her condition progressively worsened, a detailed medical evaluation confirmed that a liver transplant was the only definitive treatment option.

With no other family member found medically suitable, Aditya stepped forward. He subsequently underwent extensive medical, psychological and legal screening and was declared fit for donation in accordance with national transplant protocols, according to the doctors.

"This was an emotionally moving yet medically complex case," Subhash Gupta, Group Chairman, Centre for Liver and Biliary Sciences, Max Healthcare,

said. He noted that the patient was in an advanced stage of liver disease with complications such as ascites, making timely transplantation critical, while the young donor's determination despite academic commitments stood out.

Explaining the procedure, Rajesh Dey, director of Liver Transplant and Biliary Sciences at the hospital, said a right lobe graft weighing about 710 grams was successfully transplanted.

He added that in living donor liver transplantation, both the donor's and the recipient's livers regenerate over time to near-normal size, though the surgery requires high precision and intensive postoperative care.

Police bust drug trafficking network, arrest 4

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted a drug trafficking network in west Delhi and arrested four persons, including two Nigerian nationals, with MDMA valued at around ₹1 crore, officials said on Sunday.

The accused were identified as Gurmeet Singh and Mukesh Kumar alias Vicky, both residents of Uttam Nagar, and Nigerian nationals Mancabo David and Emeka Emmanuel alias Peter, they said.

"Emmanuel is a habitual offender who was earlier arrested under the NDPS Act and had served a five-year jail term. The operation was carried out after a tip-off about drug trafficking



activities in the Tilak Nagar area," a senior police officer said.

A police team conducted a raid on April 6 at a premises in Ganesh Nagar, leading to the arrest of Gurmeet and Mukesh. During the search, around 73 grams of MDMA were recovered along with 112 zip-lock pouches, weighing machines, packing material and ₹37,500 in cash sus-

pected to be proceeds of crime. Subsequent interrogation led to the arrest of Mancabo David on April 9, from whom over 10 grams of MDMA were seized.

Another accused, Emeka Emmanuel, was later apprehended, and 7 grams of the contraband were recovered from his possession on the same day, the police said.

"The syndicate operated in a well-organised manner,

sourcing MDMA from Nigerian suppliers and distributing it across Delhi-NCR. Gurmeet was identified as the kingpin managing procurement and supply, while Mukesh handled local distribution," the officer said.

Police also found that the accused were allegedly running an escort service from the rented premises, which was used as a front for drug trafficking activities.

The syndicate used CCTV surveillance and password-based access systems to evade law enforcement agencies, he added.

Police have seized vehicles and mobile phones used in the operation and are probing interstate and international linkages of the network.

19-year-old found dead with strangulation marks

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 19-year-old newly married woman was found dead, with strangulation marks on her neck, inside a room at her residence in central Delhi on Sunday, an official said.

According to the police, a PCR call was received regarding the incident in the Nai Basti area of Anand Parbat, following which a team rushed to the spot and found the woman lying dead inside the room.

"The woman had been married for around three months. During inspection of the scene, marks were noticed on her neck, raising suspicion of strangulation," a senior police officer said.

A crime team examined the spot and collected forensic evidence to ascertain the sequence of events leading to her death. Police said the husband of the deceased is missing and is a suspect in the case.

Multiple teams have been formed to trace him, and raids are being conducted at possible hideouts. Investigators are also scanning CCTV footage from the surrounding areas to track the movement of the suspect before and after the incident.

In addition, technical surveillance is being used, and the husband's mobile phone data is being analysed to establish his location and movements, police said.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Pankaj Wadhwa S/o Mahesh Chand Wadhwa R/o H.No.585 Old Faridabad Kheri Kalan(113) Faridabad, Haryana-121002 have changed my name to Pankaj Kumar Wadhwa. PD(913)C

CM Rekha attacks Opposition over women’s reservation bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday launched a sharp attack on opposition parties over the recent developments in Parliament related to the Women's Reservation Bill, questioning their commitment to women's rights and calling the situation "deeply unfortunate."

Addressing a press conference in the national Capital, the Chief Minister said the events in the Lok Sabha over the past few days reflect a setback for women's empowerment. "How can democracy win when daughters lose," she asked, arguing that

women continue to struggle for adequate representation even decades after independence.

She accused opposition parties of blocking progress on the issue for years. According to her, the proposal for women's reservation has been introduced multiple times over the last three decades but has repeatedly failed to move forward. She alleged that the objections now raised contradict earlier positions taken when the bill was passed in 2023, with a provision linking implementation to delimitation.

The Chief Minister said the current opposition to the implementation linked to delimitation raises questions.

"If the same condition was accepted earlier, what has changed now?" she asked.

Responding to demands that reservations be implemented within the existing strength of the Lok Sabha, she said such a move would require clarity on which sitting members would give up their seats. She described the Centre's proposal to increase the total number of seats while ensuring 33 percent reservation for women as a balanced approach.

She pointed out that the number of Lok Sabha seats has remained unchanged since 1971 despite a significant rise in population. In her view, expanding representa-



tion alongside reservation is necessary to address both demographic changes and gender imbalance in politics.

The Chief Minister also criticised calls for sub-quotas within the proposed reservation, calling them an attempt to delay implementation. She

said such demands are being used to avoid taking a clear stand on giving women greater political space.

Referring to past positions on issues concerning women, the Chief Minister alleged that some parties had opposed key legal and social

reforms affecting women. She questioned their current stance, calling it inconsistent.

She also targeted what she described as dynastic politics, alleging that certain parties promote women from within political families while limiting opportunities for others. According to her, broader reservations would allow women from diverse backgrounds to enter politics and challenge established structures.

The Chief Minister said that under the current timeline, implementation of the reservation may take several years due to processes like census and delimitation. She questioned why women should

have to wait longer for representation in Parliament and state assemblies.

Citing figures, she noted that women's participation remains significantly higher in local bodies compared to higher legislatures. She said policy intervention is necessary to bridge this gap and ensure that women's voices are reflected in decision-making at all levels.

The Chief Minister also highlighted measures taken in recent years aimed at women's welfare and empowerment. She said these initiatives have helped improve participation and confidence among women across sectors.

During the press confer-

ence, several party leaders were present and expressed support for the reservation proposal. Slogans backing the bill and calling for its implementation were raised at the end of the event.

The remarks come amid ongoing political debate over the timing and framework of implementing women's reservation in legislatures.

The Chief Minister maintained that the issue should rise above political considerations and be addressed with urgency. She said the demand for fair representation is long overdue and expressed confidence that the matter will eventually move forward in favour of women.

Managing committee of Dwarka RWA defies orders of Registrar of Cooperative Societies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A defiant managing committee of a Cooperative Group Housing Society (CGHS) in Dwarka in southwest Delhi has refused to comply with the order of the Registrar of Cooperative Societies (RCS). The matter pertains to the illegal sale and purchase of stilt parking by the managing committee of Shakti CGHS Ltd in Sector 5, Dwarka.



tional cost, though the cost of open parking was equally shared by all 105 members.

However, according to several litigation cases and memorandums, in 2019 the president of the society, Vishal Taneja, allegedly started dictating the contents of the sale deed and refused to transfer membership in case the stilt was transferred to the buyer along with the flat. He misinformed the members that these 53 stilts allotted to 53 members are part of a common area for 105 flats, though the cost of these 53 stilts was exclusively borne by 53 members alone.

Interestingly, the certificate of the DDA-accredited architect engaged by the society had certified in 2004 that the 53 stilts cannot be part of the common area for

105 flats because the cost is not equally shared by all 105 members and cannot be made available to all 105 members simultaneously.

The managing committee headed by Vishal Taneja in 2019-2020 planned to take back already allotted stilt from its members and return them ₹77,000/. To coerce the members, the society started withholding NOC for sale and membership transfer in case the member resisted to such forceful attachment of the already allotted stilt by the managing committee.

The society started selling these forcefully attached stilts (which were already allotted in 2003) in ₹2,00,000/- earning a profit of ₹1,23,000/- on each illegal sale and purchase of stilt parking. Surprisingly, Vishal Taneja had used his own interpretation of the DCS Act 2003 and DCS Rules 2007 to coerce the members of society for attaching already allotted stilt parking without consulting the office of RCS.

A criminal case has already been lodged against him for misappropriating

the Green Park, cheating, criminal trespass, criminal conspiracy and criminal breach of trust of members. Pending criminal investigations against him, Vishal Taneja had recently moved the Delhi High Court for issuing directions to police to not arrest him; however, the court refused to give any relief to him.

He is presently working as Vice-President of Global Medical Technology Giant Becton Dickinson Holdings Pvt Ltd for Central Asia, South Asia and Japan and is presently posted in Singapore. The said decision of 2020 was challenged by many members of society before RCS, which passed an interim order dated 17.03.2026 to restore the stilt allotment done in 2003 within five days, but the said order of RCS remains non-complied till date by President of the present Managing Committee Rajesh Verma. Some of the residents said Verma was instrumental in executing all illegal decisions of Taneja as secretary of the committee in 2019-2021.

DDA concludes Harit Manthan 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority has concluded its first national-level hackathon, "Harit Manthan 2026", bringing together students and young innovators to develop solutions for urban green spaces.

The two-day event, held on April 17 and 18, ended with top teams receiving funding support and incubation opportunities.

The hackathon focused on finding practical and scalable ideas for ecological management in cities. Around 50 teams from 31 colleges across seven states participated in the competition. The event was organised in collaboration with the Udhmodya Foundation, linked to the University of Delhi.

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu attended the second day of the event and highlighted the importance of involving young minds in urban planning and environmental protection. He said fresh ideas are essential for improving public infrastructure and addressing ecological challenges in growing cities.



DDA Vice Chairman N Saravana Kumar said the initiative was not meant to be a one-time exercise. He stated that the authority aims to build a long-term system where innovative ideas can be tested and implemented within government projects.

The hackathon was divided into two main tracks: technology and policy. On the first day, 20 shortlisted teams received guidance from experts associated with the University of Delhi and DDA. Mentors helped participants refine their ideas with a focus on real-world use, financial feasibility, and scalability.

On the final day, teams presented their solutions before a jury panel. The evaluation process focused on originality, practicality, and

the ability to implement ideas within existing public systems.

Three winning teams were selected at the end of the event. Two teams were chosen from the technology category and one from the policy category. These teams were awarded seed funding of up to ₹10 lakh. They will also receive incubation support from the Udhmodya Foundation to further develop their ideas.

Officials said the initiative was designed to address a key challenge faced by the DDA. The authority manages more than 16,000 acres of parks, forests, and biodiversity zones across Delhi. Maintaining and improving such a large ecological network requires cost-effective and workable solutions.

6 juveniles held for stabbing man to death in Samaypur Badli

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Six juveniles have been apprehended for allegedly murdering a 19-year-old man in outer-north Delhi's Samaypur Badli area. The police apprehended the accused on Saturday after analysing CCTV footage and gathering local intelligence, police said.

The murder occurred on the evening of April 14 in the MCD Colony area, when the victim, identified as Rajeev, was attacked, they added.

The police received information about the stabbing at around 7.44 pm at Samaypur Badli Police Station. Rajeev, a tempo driver, was rushed to a hospital in Shalimar Bagh but succumbed to his injuries.

Preliminary investigation revealed that the dispute began on April 13, when a group of locals gathered near the victim's residence, leading to a heated exchange.

"The confrontation intensified the following evening when the group returned and attacked Rajeev with a knife," a senior police officer said.

Fake engine oil racket busted, 2 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has busted a counterfeit engine oil manufacturing unit operating in the Ghazipur area and arrested two men involved in producing and supplying fake branded oil. Around 700 litres of duplicate engine oil, along with packaging material and machinery, were seized during the raid, officials said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police Pankaj Kumar of the Crime Branch said the operation was part of a special drive against counterfeit manufacturing units in the city. "We recovered a large quantity of duplicate engine oil and equipment used to package it under well-known brand names. The accused were involved in the supply and distribution of these fake products," he said.

The accused have been identified as Rakesh Kumar Chhabra, 52, a resident of Shakarpur, and Kuldeep Singh, 52, a resident of Geeta



Colony. Both were arrested following a raid conducted at a godown in Village Gadholi in Ghazipur.

Police said the raid was carried out after receiving specific information about the illegal production of engine oil branded as Castrol, Yamaha, Hero, and Bajaj. A police team conducted the operation on April 16.

During the search, officers found 28 cans of loose engine oil, each containing 20 litres, and 140 one-litre bottles already filled and labelled as branded products. In total, the recovered quantity was

about 700 litres.

In addition to the oil, police seized a large amount of packaging material. This included more than 550 empty bottles of different brands, stickers, labels, sealing caps, and barcode coupons.

Equipment used in the process, such as a bottle sealing machine, funnels, buckets, filter meshes, and other tools, was also recovered. Investigators said the accused were refilling loose oil into branded containers to pass it off as genuine products.

Veteran journalist Balbir Punj cremated

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Veteran journalist and senior political figure Balbir Punj was cremated with full State honours in the national Capital. He passed away on Saturday evening. His death has drawn tributes from media organisations and colleagues across the country.

The National Union of Journalists India and the Delhi Journalists Association expressed deep grief over his demise, calling it a major loss to both the media fraternity and public life. Members of both bodies paid homage and remembered his contribution to journalism and national discourse.

NUJI President Ras Bihari said Punj was a respected member of the journalist community and had played a key role in strengthening professional organisations.



Delhi Journalists Association President Rakesh Thapliyal and General Secretary Pramod Kumar Singh also paid tribute.

Alongside his journalism career, Punj remained engaged with professional bodies. In addition to his leadership roles in NUJI and DJA, he was involved in media training and development. He also chaired a Southeast Asian media training organisation linked with the Indian Institute of Mass Communication for two years until March 2000.

LG Sandhu calls for investment in education, skill innovation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday delivered the concluding remarks at a conference titled "New Punjab: Building An Agenda Beyond Crisis," held at the Constitution Club of India, where he spoke about the need to invest in education, advance skill innovation, and build strong institutions to sustain Punjab's legacy.

Sandhu described Punjab's story as a testament to the "grit, resilience, and vision" of its people, values that he said have left a mark well beyond the boundaries of the state. "Punjab's story is a testament to the grit, resilience, and vision of its people, values that have left an indelible mark far beyond the state itself," Sandhu said at the conference.

He emphasised the importance of building on this found-



ation through concrete investments. His remarks centred on three areas: strengthening the education system, advancing skill and innovation, and creating institutions that are sustainable and reflective of Punjab's enduring strengths.

The conference, focused on charting an agenda for Punjab beyond its current challenges, brought together participants to discuss the state's future direction. Sandhu's concluding address positioned institutional development and human capital as central to

any meaningful path forward.

The LG's engagement with Punjab-focused policy dialogue comes at a time when the state continues to grapple with issues including drug abuse, agrarian distress, unemployment among youth, and questions around economic diversification. His remarks, while broad in framing, pointed toward education and skills as the primary levers for sustainable recovery and growth.

Sandhu posted about the event on social media, noting that Punjab's values had left "an indelible mark far beyond the state itself," and underlining the importance of translating that legacy into actionable institutional frameworks.

The Constitution Club of India, located in central New Delhi, is a common venue for policy conferences, parliamentary discussions, and forums involving political and public figures.

Five-member panel formed to probe student suicides at NIT Kurukshetra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Institute of Technology (NIT) Kurukshetra in Haryana has constituted a five-member committee to investigate the recent case of student suicide on campus, besides forming three separate committees to look into issues faced by students.

The probe panel will interact with students, professors, wardens, and other staff.

NIT's Public Relations Officer, Prof. Gian Bhushan, said on Sunday that the committee has been constituted to investigate the recent suicide cases on campus.

The panel is headed by Dean of Student Welfare Prof. Lillie Dewan and includes Prof. J.K. Kapoor, Prof. Praveen Aggarwal, Dr Sandeep Singhal, and Dr Manoj Sinha.

The development comes days after a 19-year-old B.Tech

student, Diksha Dubey, who hailed from Bihar, allegedly died by suicide on Thursday. Her death, which sparked protests on campus, marked the fourth such incident on the campus in the past two months.

After Dubey's death, a first-year BTech student allegedly attempted to take her own life on Friday night, police said. The female student, a Maharashtra native, allegedly threatened and tried to jump off the hostel building but was stopped by fellow hostellers. Prof. Bhushan also informed that the administration has ordered all students to vacate the hostels by Sunday in light of the events and keeping in mind the well-being of all students.

Additionally, all UG, PG and PhD students are to be on vacation until further notice and are required to vacate their hostels by April 19,

according to a notice from the NIT administration.

Bhushan further informed that out of approximately 5,300 students residing in hostels, nearly 4,300 had left by Sunday evening, while around 1,000 students were still on campus.

Notably, the situation has been particularly challenging for students hailing from far-off states. Prof. Bhushan said the administration is looking into the requests from such students to allow them to continue staying in the hostels.

The revised examination schedule, including practical examinations, will be communicated in due course. Students will be informed well in advance, before the commencement of examinations. Students have been advised to stay updated through the institute website for further announcements,



the notice issued by the registrar-in-charge of NIT said on Saturday. However, some students alleged that the notice to leave hostels has caused problems for them and disrupted their studies.

On Sunday, a 'havan' was organised at the campus of the NIT here, which has been witnessing a tense atmosphere following four suicides in the past two months. Chairperson of the Board of

Governors, NIT, Tejaswini Ananthkumar, who arrived on campus late Saturday evening, also participated in the ritual.

Prof Bhushan said the chairperson also visited various hotels late into the night to interact with students and assess their concerns firsthand. She further held meetings with senior faculty members on Sunday to coordinate administrative efforts,

particularly regarding arrangements for students returning home, he said.

A police investigation into Dubey's case is also currently underway.

The institute has replaced key hostel officials, including the chief warden and deputy warden of the girls' hostel.

Interacting with media persons on Saturday, the officiating director of NIT, Prof. Brahmjit, said the institute is taking students' issues seriously. He said each student has been assigned a faculty member for regular interaction. These faculty members will stay in touch with students, understand their concerns, and work towards resolving them, he said.

To further strengthen student support, the institute has also formed three separate committees.

The first committee comprises wardens who visit

hostels daily and interact directly with students. The second is a mentorship committee, where one mentor is assigned to a group of 20-25 students and remains in regular contact, including through phone conversations.

The third committee includes two faculty members for each hostel, who continue to visit regularly and engage with students to understand their problems.

An NIT student told reporters here that "there is a gap between students and faculty/management, which should be properly addressed. Merely assigning mentors is not going to solve the problem". Another student noted, "Students are traumatised by four suicides in just two months."

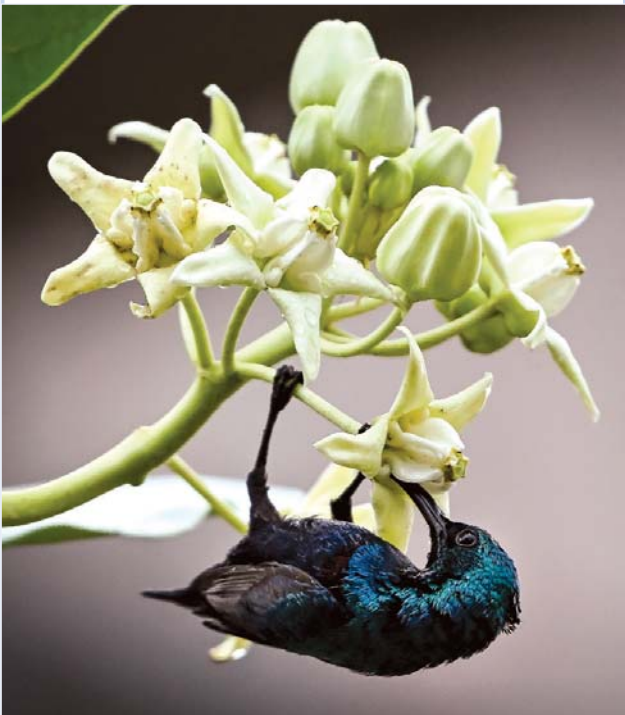
A heavy police force has been deployed outside the campus gate to maintain law and order.

Meanwhile, the developments have triggered strong reactions from various student bodies, including the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), Students' Federation of India (SFI), and Indian National Students' Union (INSU), all of which have extended support to students and raised concerns over the handling of the situation.

Expressing serious concern over the recurring incidents, the ABVP urged authorities to act decisively and demanded a probe by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), alleging that both the police and the institute administration are trying to suppress the matter.

It urged the government to take immediate cognisance and ensure transparency in the investigation. The organisation also appealed to students not to take extreme steps and to voice their concerns fearlessly.

IN FOCUS



A purple sunbird perches on a crown flower branch, in Nadia, West Bengal

PTI

BJP lambasts Revanth Reddy for calling PM Modi a ‘demon’

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday strongly criticised Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy for likening Prime Minister Narendra Modi to Maricha, a demon from the Ramayana, saying he has “insulted” the constitutional post and that hatred has become the identity of the Congress.

In a social media post, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla claimed that a source within the Congress has told him that all leaders of the Opposition party have been instructed by the high command — “higher than even the party president” — to target Modi.

Addressing a press con-



Revanth Reddy



Shehzad Poonawalla

ference in New Delhi on Saturday, Reddy alleged that the Modi Government was pushing for the passage of the Constitution amendment bill for women's reservation to strengthen its position in the 2029 Lok Sabha polls.

“Maricha had come for the abduction of Sita Maa. Modi ji and the entire BJP-NDA are also making efforts to take away the

Constitution. But we will not let any such effort succeed,” he said.

Accusing Reddy of spreading hatred, Poonawalla called the chief minister “*nafrat ke bhaijan*”. The Telangana chief minister has insulted the constitutional post of the prime minister by “abusing” Modi, the BJP spokesperson said in a video message.

“Revanth Reddy has compared the prime minister to a demon... The Congress has hurled more than 150 abuses at Prime Minister Narendra Modi. They are abusing him again because he pushed for ‘*nari shakti*’. This is not a coincidence but a well-thought-out experiment,” Poonawalla said.

“They have done this to the Election Commission, the judiciary. Even the President of India has not been spared and was referred to as ‘*rashtrapatni*’. They have shown disrespect towards the armed forces, Sanatan, and constitutional offices,” he said.

“This is not ‘*mohabbat ki dukan*’ (shop of love), this is ‘*nafrat ke bhaijaan*’. This has become the identity of



Over 65,000 road accidents reported in Gujarat in 4 months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Raising serious concerns over road safety, Gujarat has recorded more than 65,000 road accidents in the first four months of 2026, highlighting the growing risks posed by increasing traffic and negligence. According to data from the 108 emergency service, a total of 65,434 road accident cases were reported between January 1 and April 17 this year. The numbers indicate a troubling trend, with an average of around 600 accidents occurring daily across the State.

Ahmedabad has emerged as the most accident-prone city, reporting the highest number of cases at 9,941 during the period. On average, the city witnesses over 90 accidents every day, reflecting the pressures of rapid

urbanisation and heavy traffic flow.

Other districts have also reported significant numbers, underlining that the issue is not limited to major urban centres. Dang recorded 4,042 cases, followed by Sabarkantha with 6,978 and Porbandar with 3,259 cases. Additional figures include Kutch (2,401), Gandhinagar (2,381), Dahod (2,220), Vadodara (2,210), Navsari (2,084), Bhavnagar (1,932), Mehsana (1,889), and Kheda (1,828). Experts attribute the alarming rise in accidents to multiple factors, including over speeding, violation of traffic rules, drunk driving, poor road conditions, illegal highway cuts, dangerous curves, non-functional streetlights, and stalled vehicles left unattended on roads. The rapid increase in the number of vehicles has further aggravated the situation.

Air India unveils first retrofitted Boeing 787 Dreamliner

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a significant milestone for India's aviation sector, Air India, now owned by the Tata Group, on Sunday unveiled its first retrofitted Boeing 787 Dreamliner, signalling the beginning of a major transformation aimed at delivering a world-class

passenger experience.

The unveiling is part of the airline's ambitious \$400 million fleet modernisation programme, under which older aircraft are being completely upgraded with state-of-the-art interiors. Over the next year, Air India plans to retrofit its remaining 25 Boeing 787 aircraft with similar enhancements.

The revamped aircraft



introduces a modern three-class configuration, replacing the earlier two-class layout. Passengers will now

have the option of Business Class, Premium Economy, and Economy Class. The addition of Premium

Economy is expected to bridge the gap between luxury and affordability, offering enhanced comfort at competitive pricing.

All cabins feature next-generation seating and advanced in-flight entertainment (IFE) systems, designed to provide a superior travel experience. The upgraded design aligns with the standards introduced

in the Boeing 787-9 launched in January 2026.

According to Air India, the retrofit process involved a complete overhaul of the aircraft's interiors, giving it a fresh, contemporary look. Since returning to Tata Group ownership, the airline has consistently focused on modernising its fleet and improving service quality.

FROM PAGE - 1

West Bengal polls turn combative

Addressing a poll rally at Tarakeswar, she accused the PM “misusing” Government machinery for political campaigns. Addressing another poll rally at Kalna in Purba Bardhaman district, Banerjee alleged that the BJP, if it comes to power, will take away all the welfare benefits introduced by the TMC Government, such as ‘Lakshmir Bhandar’, ‘Joy Johar’ for the Adivasis or ‘Oikyoshree’ for the minorities.

Accusing the BJP of indulging in vindictive politics by using agencies such as the CBI, Enforcement Directorate (ED) and the Income Tax department to intimidate TMC leaders, Mamata threatened legal action, saying, “Nothing happens in one-sided manner.”

Iran pulls out of talks as Trump threatens strikes

The US president also accused Iran of violating the fragile two-week ceasefire – set to expire Wednesday – by allegedly opening fire in the Strait of Hormuz on Saturday. He issued a stark warning, threatening to target critical infrastructure if Tehran rejects Washington's proposal.

“We're offering a very fair and reasonable deal,” Trump wrote. “If they don't [accept], the United States is going to knock out every single power plant, and every single bridge, in Iran.”

Tehran has not directly responded to Trump's remarks on the proposed talks but has strongly criticised what it describes as a US naval blockade of its ports. Foreign ministry spokesman Esmail Baqaei termed the move “unlawful and criminal,” adding that it amounts to “collective punishment” and could constitute a war crime.

Amid the rising tensions, Iran also addressed reports of a shooting incident involving India-flagged vessels in the Strait of Hormuz, urging restraint. Dr Abdul Majid Hakeem Ilahi, the representative of Iran's Supreme Leader in India, said he was unaware of the specifics but stressed strong bilateral ties and called for peace.

“We don't want this war. We want peace,” he said, expressing hope for stability in the region.

With both sides trading accusations and standing firm on their positions, uncertainty looms over diplomatic efforts as the ceasefire deadline approaches.

Dinesh Trivedi to head India's Dhaka mission

With his background in West Bengal politics, Trivedi is expected to bring valuable regional understanding to the role, especially on issues concerning border relations, stability and security.

Trivedi, a former Member of Parliament from West Bengal's Barrackpore, joined the BJP in 2021 after leaving the All India Trinamool Congress. Over the years, he has held key positions, including Union Railway Minister and Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare.

Experts believe this move underscores New Delhi's intent to strengthen ties with Dhaka and prioritise diplomatic engagement with its eastern neighbour. Trivedi's roots in West Bengal and his political background are expected to give him a nuanced understanding of cross-border issues, particularly those related to regional stability and security. Meanwhile, Khalilur Rahman, Foreign Minister of Bangladesh, recently highlighted the evolving nature of bilateral relations.

The appointment of Dinesh Trivedi has come as a surprise in diplomatic circles, particularly within the IFS fraternity. However, both Dhaka and New Delhi appear to have anticipated this move, sensing that India would appoint a political figure to build a stronger bridge between the two countries. There is hope that this approach will foster a more dynamic and positive bilateral relationship between Bangladesh and India, with the political appointment expected to further strengthen ties between the two nations.

Trivedi has experience in Parliament and Government. Known for his administrative back-

ground and political adaptability, he has played key roles in both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha. Born on June 4, 1950, in New Delhi, Trivedi pursued his education at prestigious institutions including St. Xavier's College Kolkata and St. Xavier's Collegiate School. He also studied at University of Texas at Austin, which contributed to his global outlook.

Fiscal stress sees Himachal stall part...

Finance Secretary Ashish Singhmar clarified that the deferred portion will be fully accounted for in future financial calculations, including pension and leave encashment benefits. Pay slips will clearly display both payable and deferred components to maintain transparency. Statutory deductions such as income tax and National Pension System (NPS) contributions will continue to be calculated on gross salary to avoid accounting complications.

Special provisions have also been made for employees servicing loans, with deferment to be calculated after deduction of loan instalments, subject to written undertakings. The Government has further directed State-funded boards, public sector undertakings, universities, and autonomous bodies to adopt similar measures, signalling a wider fiscal tightening exercise across Himachal Pradesh's administrative framework.

“The Governor of Himachal Pradesh ... in exercise of the powers conferred under proviso to Article 309 of the Constitution of India, is pleased to order temporary deferment of a portion of the monthly salary of certain categories of Government employees for a period of six months, effective from the salary of April to be paid in May, 2026,” the notification read. “The payable and deferred components of salary shall clearly be reflected in the e-salary system and pay slips to ensure transparency,” it added.

Explosion at firecracker unit in Tamil Nadu kills...

This incident marks the deadliest industrial accident in the region this year. It comes just days after a similar blast in the Vembakottai area of the same district that claimed four lives.

Further details are awaited as the search and rescue operation continues.

Meanwhile, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M K Stalin expressed his sorrow and said he rushed two ministers to the site to expedite rescue operations. In a post on X, he said, “The tragic news of the deaths of several people in the firecracker unit explosion that occurred in Kattanarpatti, Virudhunagar district, causes immense sorrow. My deepest condolences to the families of those who lost their lives”.

“I have requested Ministers KKSSR Ramachandran and Thangam Thennarasu to rush to the scene immediately to expedite and monitor the rescue operations and to offer solace to the affected families,” he added.

“Upon learning of this accident, I have contacted the district collector and instructed him to coordinate all necessary assistance,” he further said.

Dirty dozen defaulters behind over ₹5 lakh...

Third top defaulter is tainted Videocon Group headed by Venugopal Dhoot and his brother former Shiv Sena MP Rajkumar Dhoot. As per the TransUnion CIBIL data, this politically exposed group owes ₹70,655 crore to seven banks. The seven banks plundered by Videocon group are: Central Bank of India (₹25,299 crore), SBI (₹23,296 crore), Bank of India — ₹9,606 crore), Bank of Maharashtra (₹6,722 crore), Bank of Baroda (₹5,296 crore), Indian Overseas Bank and UCO Bank. Interestingly, ICICI Bank has not shown the dues of Videocon Group. Venugopal Dhoot was arrested by CBI for bribing ICICI Bank head Chanda Kochhar. In 2018, it was exposed that ICICI Bank allotted ₹3250 crore to Videocon and bribery of 10

percent was diverted to Chanda Kochhar's husband Deepak Kochhar's companies. In TransUnion CIBIL data of large defaulters up to February 2026, name of Videocon is not seen in ICICI Bank's filing. Previous week only SBI approached NCLT against Dhoot brothers to materialise their personal guarantee of around ₹10,000 crore.

The banks are also silent about allotting more than ₹40,000 crore to Videocon Group's oil project in Mozambique in 2012. ICICI Bank was the lead banker in Videocon's Mozambique oil exploration project, along with many PSU Banks. In 2017, Videocon Group sold 10 per cent of share of the oil exploration company to ONGC for ₹2.47 Billion Dollars and made a huge profit, while not repaying their loans. Why Banks and Government were silent in catching Dhoot brothers is still a mystery, when they got huge bonanza?

Fourth top defaulter is fugitives Mehul Choksi and his nephew Nirav Modi headed firms Gitanjali Gems, Nakshtra World, Firestar Diamonds and Gitanjali Exports. Till 2018, these guys were holly cows. Nine banks - Punjab National Bank, Union Bank, SBI, Canara Bank, Bank of Maharashtra, Central Bank, UCO Bank, Punjab and Sind Bank and ICICI Bank — were given ₹54,225 crore to these fugitives.

Other top defaulters are Himachal Pradesh based, Delhi registered company facing insolvency Indian Technomac (₹30,666 crore), fizzled out Bhushan Power & Steel (₹30,260 crore), Hyderabad based IVRCL Ltd (₹27,418 crore) and fugitive Jatin Mehta's Winsome Diamonds (₹20,148 crore).

All these companies are facing insolvency or at the liquidation stage and ultimately banks have to write off their loans, as banks have no secure collateral securities, when providing huge loan amounts. Banks only have pledged shares of these companies and personal guarantees of directors of these companies. The shares have no value after insolvency cases and promoters have parked their assets safely in abroad and other directors are only employees, having no big assets. Many Bankers vouch all these huge loans were given out of political pressures.

Another interesting big defaulter is a Russian company named Transstroy India Ltd, facing recovery of ₹19,359 crore from four PSU Banks — Union Bank of India, Bank of Maharashtra, Central Bank of India, UCO Bank and Bank of India. This Guntur-based company is headed by long-term Guntur's Congress-turned-TDP vociferous MP Rayapati Sambasiva Rao. In 2018, CBI and Serious Frauds Investigation Office (SFO) found that funds were diverted through shell companies created in the names of employees, including his cooks, maids, drivers and sweepers.

This company and its more than 50 subsidiaries are engaged in road construction, toll plaza operations, rail, and power contracts is now facing CBI and ED cases. Interestingly, the Central Bank has given loan to Transtroy India's linked company, Betul Tollways Private Limited and a Russian Citizen Oleg Sergeev, is shown as personal guarantor.

This person is director of many toll companies of Sambasiva Rao.

Collapsed Essar Group of Ruia brothers owes ₹15,379 crore to Union Bank, Central Bank and UCO Bank. Fugitive C Sivasankaran's Aircel Mobile, Dishnet Wireless and Sterling Group plundered ₹15,033 crores of four PSU banks — SBI, Canara Bank, Central Bank and Union Bank. DMK supported Sivasankaran, now settled in Seychelles Island was plundering PSU banks up to 2010, till 2G Scam broke out.

Uttar Pradesh's big real estate company Jaypee Group owes ₹9,805 crore to four banks — ICICI Bank, Axis Bank, UCO Bank and Punjab & Sind Bank. Now Gautam Adani and Vedanta's Anil Agarwal are engaged in bitter battle to acquire insolvent Jaypee Group, leaving banks on how to acquire their dues. Other major top defaulters are collapsed real estate firms Zoom Developers (₹8314 crore) and Supertech (₹6213 crore).

Another top defaulter is a real estate firm in Delhi, UP, Haryana, Punjab based Era Group with dues of ₹5,063 crore to Canara bank, UCO Bank, Indian Overseas Bank and Punjab & Sind Bank. The

Pioneer on March 12, 2026 edition, highlighted that Union Bank of India tops among the largest defaulters with INR 9.96 lakh crore with 18,197 cases or entries as per the Bank's own filing to rating agency TransUnion CIBIL up to January 2026. The large defaulters list means those who owe more than ₹One crore and above to a bank, and the bank is conducting recovery cases against them. As per Union Bank's filings, their largest defaulter is Hem Singh Bharana controlled Era Group with dues of ₹75,714 crore.

The Pioneer emailed Union Bank of India's MD and CEO, Asheesh Pandey, and his colleagues on April 1, asking how the alteration/reduction had occurred in their filings to TransUnion CIBIL in February, reducing ₹9.96 lakh crores to ₹4.93 lakh crores within a month. Till the time of going to press, The Pioneer did not received any response.

The basic questions raised by *The Pioneer* was — “We have seen your latest report to TransUnion CIBIL after The Pioneer's expose, which reduced from ₹9.96 lakh crores to ₹4.93 lakh crores dues in large defaulters list. We are not going into the specifics of each loan. We have a specific question: According to your January 2026 list, Era Infra Engineering (Era Group, headed by Hem Singh Bharana) was your largest defaulter with more than ₹75,000 crores. In your new list of February 2026, submitted to TransUnion CIBIL, this name is not included. Has he paid dues, or have you allowed a one-time settlement, or have you written off the loans or have you re-structured the loans?”

And interestingly, a PSU Bank - Indian Bank has not filed their Large Defaulters List to any rating agency approved by Reserve Bank of India for the past one year. India has now 12 PSU Banks and except Indian Bank, all Banks are providing data of large defaulters to RBI approved rating agencies on monthly wise. Why Union Bank not giving their list of Large Defaulters?

Finance Ministry must direct Indian Bank to publish their Wilful Defaulter and Large Defaulter List. Indian Bank was involved in many scams and its' Chairman of M Gopalakrishnan (passed away in 2016) was in jail for many years for big loan frauds in mid 90s, approving from Five Star Hotels in Chennai. Indian Bank, which carries such bad legacy, for the past one year, not yet uploaded their Wilful Defaulter and Large Defaulter List to TransUnion CIBIL.

The Finance Ministry must take immediate cognisance of the glaring lapse by Indian Bank in failing to upload critical data, even as all other public sector banks adhere to the mandated monthly disclosures.

Such inconsistency raises serious concerns about transparency, accountability, and possible attempts to obscure irregularities. The Ministry, in coordination with the RBI, must initiate a time-bound inquiry to ascertain the reasons behind this non-compliance.

More importantly, this episode underscores the urgent need to confront the deeper malaise afflicting the banking system, a troubling nexus between wilful defaulters, sections of bank management, regulatory blind spots, and influential elites. This nexus has eroded institutional credibility and weakened the very foundation of financial governance.

Strict and exemplary action must follow. Authorities should not hesitate to order independent forensic audits, reopen suspicious accounts, and launch fresh criminal investigations wherever collusion is suspected. Accountability must extend across the chain-bank officials, corporate defaulters, and any external actors found complicit. Regulatory oversight mechanisms must also be reviewed and strengthened to prevent such lapses from recurring.

Restoring public trust in the banking system requires more than rhetoric; it demands decisive enforcement, institutional integrity, and zero tolerance for collusion and concealment.

Surprise stop by PM Modi on poll trail

Bystanders and the vendor were surprised when

the PM's convoy suddenly stopped before his modest shop in Jhargram and none but Modi walked up to the stall asking the price of 'jhal muri'. “Bhai, apka jhal muri khelao, kitna? Accha se bana do jhal muri (treat me with your jhal muri; how much is it? Make it tasty),” Modi told the shopkeeper. The PM, who was accompanied by his security personnel, handed over the money to the vendor, insisting that he accept the money. Asked by the shopkeeper if all the standard ingredients would be used to prepare the delicacy, Modi said, “Everything excepting nimak (salt)” which he does not use for health reasons.

Capital increases green levy on commercial...

The decision was taken in compliance to the Supreme Court's order which has okayed enhancing the ECC. The revised charges are intended to discourage non-destined vehicles from using Delhi as a shortcut and push them to take the eastern and western peripheral expressways instead.

The increase in the ECC charges will have a considerable impact on businesses that transport goods, including hauliers, packers and movers, as operating costs will be increased. Approximately 3500 2-axle trucks enter Delhi each day, and approximately 1500 3- and 4-axle commercial vehicles enter Delhi each day.

In Delhi, the ECC is levied to compensate for the environmental damage caused by vehicular emissions. The MCD collects this charge at various toll plazas, and the proceeds are subsequently deposited into a dedicated account held by the Delhi Government.

These fees are used to offset the environmental damage from vehicle emissions. The money collected is deposited into a separate account run by the Delhi Government. On average, 70000 commercial vehicles enter Delhi from NCR each day. On an average, 29000 cars, 6000 light commercial vehicles, 2800 buses, 3400-3500 trucks (two axes), 1000 three-axle commercial vehicles, 1100 commercial vehicles with more than three axes and nearly 25000 LMV enters the national capital on a daily basis.

The Supreme Court of India had approved a significant revision in the Environment Compensation Charge (ECC) levied on commercial vehicles entering Delhi, with effect from April 1, 2026. The Court passed the order on March 12, 2026, accepting the recommendations of the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM). The Court, after considering the CAQM's proposal, stated that it found “the same to be reasonable, just, and fair” and accordingly approved the revised rates.

The Court further approved an annual enhancement of 5% in ECC rates with effect from April 1 each year, to be rounded off to the nearest ten rupees and notified by the Government of NCT of Delhi.

The CAQM had justified this recommendation by noting that the revision was aimed at discouraging the “entry of diesel commercial vehicles into Delhi,” while “taking into account inflation, increases in vehicle operating costs, and annual increases in NHAI toll rates.”

The Commission also noted an approximate 4.8 per cent compounded annual increase in NHAI toll rates since 2018.

Satellite device sparks arrest of US national...

According to unconfirmed reports, after preliminary investigations in the matter, a case FIR No. 96/2026 dated 19-04-2026 under Section 42(3)(F) was lodged at Police Post, Humhama in Srinagar.

According to Section 42(3)(F) of the Telecommunications Act, 2023 (India), a person who willfully possesses radio equipment knowing that it uses unauthorised or tampered telecommunication identifiers is subject to penalties.

Till the time of filing the report, the police authorities were interrogating the US national and had not commented on record.

GRAPEVINE

Hawk-eyed Seva Teerth

After rationalising the postings of bureaucrats under the Central Staffing Scheme by giving more weightage and representations to other allied services other than IAS and IPS, Seva Teerth is now keeping an eye on the officers who are dealing with international bodies like the World Bank, Asian Development Bank (ADB), IMF, among others. This comes as it has come to notice that those dealing with them for Governmental projects develop a long-term rapport and thereafter either go on long study leave or quit the services to join either of these bodies, and simultaneously place their family member, wards, as quid pro quo. It's a conflict of interest, and it's being examined, remarked an officer at the Cabinet Secretariat.



Harivansh begins by adjourning Rajya Sabha

Harivansh Narayan Singh was re-elected unopposed as the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha for a third consecutive term last week on April 17, 2026. After he ended with his speech, Rajya Sabha Chairman CP Radhakrishnan offered Harivansh the customary 'Presiding Chair' around 1 pm which is usually the lunch break for honorable members. "I am starting my new tenure with the same command which I gave in my first tenure. The House is adjourned to meet at 2 pm," said Harivansh as the members of the Upper House burst into laughter. Harivansh was first elected as the Dy Chairman of Rajya Sabha on August 8, 2018.



Swift counter to Priyanka Gandhi by BJP IT cell !

As Priyanka Gandhi, a member of Congress's first family, gains attention for her style of delivering speeches, media addresses, and engaging with the public through her benign impression, the BJP IT cell faces a tough mandate. Reports suggest that both the cell and party spokespersons have been instructed to respond swiftly whenever Priyanka Gandhi makes a statement. According to a BJP IT cell study, Priyanka's words receive more acknowledgement and attention compared to her brother Rahul Gandhi. Her speeches, eloquent and paired with a smiling response toward opponents, receive more applause than those of any other Congress figure. This may be why she was chosen to address a press conference on Delimitation and the Women's Bill on Saturday.



Sardar is on the Moon

The conventional Saturday lunch at India International Centre (IIC), where the Capital's biggies converge to chit chat the grapevines of the power corridors and about who's who, this time had an interesting anecdote to figure out as to how the newly appointed Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu managed to get an appreciation from US President Donald Trump. In a rare expression, Trump last week said he was happy to learn that Sandhu was appointed as LG of Delhi. Some of them were his IFS batch-mates who discussed his proximity to Trump when he was the India envoy to Washington.



BJP slams INDI Alliance over women's quota bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief ministers of some BJP ruled States and central ministers on Sunday slammed the INDI Alliance for defeating the Women's Reservation Bill in Parliament and said it was a betrayal of millions of women. They branded the Opposition's move as a "grave sin" and a "historic betrayal" of India's 70 crore women.

In Bengaluru, former Union Minister Anurag Thakur accused the Congress, TMC, DMK, and Samajwadi Party of "strangling women's reservation for the fifth time." He dismissed concerns over delimitation, asserting that Southern states would only see a gain in seats. "Giving a

share in policymaking is not a favour — it is their natural right," Thakur maintained, adding that the Opposition's real intent to stall reform has been exposed.

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, speaking in Gandhinagar, claimed the Congress's "dynastic obsession" led them to derail the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam. He noted that the Congress culture has always been "anti-reform," opposing everything from GST to Aadhaar. Union Minister Raksha Khadse added that the Bill aimed to bring one lakh youth from non-political backgrounds into Parliament, a dream she said the Congress had shattered through procedural excuses.



The attack was even sharper in Panaji, where Goa CM Pramod Sawant branded the INDI Alliance as "anti-national" and "anti-women." "If anyone has truly worked

to respect women, it is the BJP," Sawant said, pointing to the nomination of a woman President. He alleged that "family-run parties" like the SP and DMK deliberately sab-

otaged the Bill to deny political space to women from ordinary families.

In Shimla, Union Minister Jitendra Singh described the Opposition's stance as a "his-

toric betrayal" after 50 years of lip service. BJP National Vice President Saroj Pandey took a swipe at Priyanka Gandhi, stating that slogans like "Ladki hoon, lad sakti hoon" ring hollow when the party abandons the biggest legislative opportunity for women's empowerment.

Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai alleged in Raipur that the Congress had adopted a British policy of "divide and rule". He claimed the Opposition deliberately raised issues like religion-based reservation to create hurdles. BJP General Secretary Arun Singh concluded that April 17 would be remembered as a "black chapter" in Indian democracy, warning that women would respond decisively in the upcoming elections.

Delimitation projected as women's quota for political gain: Kharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hosur (Tamil Nadu)

AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge on Sunday said that the Opposition opposed the proposed delimitation exercise as it was aimed at "dividing votes and ruling".

He asserted that it was being wrongly projected as a women's reservation measure for political gain. Also, it was not empowering women, he added.

Addressing a poll rally in Hosur near the Karnataka border, which has a sizeable Kannada and Tamil-speaking population, Kharge said the move sought to arbitrarily alter constituencies to weaken Opposition parties, and credited the people of Tamil Nadu, its MPs and Chief Minister MK Stalin for backing efforts to stall it.

"It is not a women's reser-



Congress President Mallikarjun Kharge addresses a public meeting ahead of state Assembly elections in Hosur

PTI

vation bill; it is a delimitation

law. They tried to divide the votes of Opposition parties and rule," he said, and added that the alliance had secured a historic victory against the delimitation attempt.

Switching between English and Kannada, Kharge praised Stalin as a man of work who fights for self-respect and leads without blind belief in

any religion.

He said Stalin carried forward the legacy of leaders like Periyar EV Ramasamy, CN Annadurai and M Karunanidhi, rooted in dignity, rational thought and equality. Invoking the ideological lineage of the Congress, he said Jawaharlal Nehru believed in scientific thinking and rationality, and

argued that both Dravidian and Congress traditions rejected blind faith and upheld truth and justice.

Targeting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Kharge questioned the delay in implementing the women's reservation law passed in 2023.

"This law was passed in 2023. Why did you not implement it? He kept quiet for 30 months, and today he is saying that the Congress, DMK and other Opposition parties are against women," he said.

Kharge asserted that the Opposition supported women's empowerment, stating, "We are for women, we are for democracy, we are for justice, and we stand for public justice and equality."

The Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha also reiterated support for one-third reservation for women.

Implement women's quota on current strength of LS: Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Congress on Sunday charged Prime Minister Narendra Modi with shedding "crocodile tears" over the issue of reservation for women and demanded that the quota be implemented immediately on the current strength of the Lok Sabha.

The Opposition party also asserted that what was defeated in the Lok Sabha on April 17 was not the women's reservation bill but delimitation.



Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinate pointed out that the women's reservation bill was passed unanimously by Parliament on

September 21, 2023, and it is part of the Constitution now.

"The women's reservation bill was not defeated; the delimitation, which you

(Government) wanted to thrust on the nation, was defeated," she said at a press conference.

"PM Modi is shedding crocodile tears and hiding behind the women's reservation bill," she said.

Shrinade displayed a cartoon, which showed the PM having a basket with 543 mangoes, but refusing to give women a 33 per cent share and telling them that he can give them their share only if he can increase the number to 850, which the Opposition is not letting him do.

Rajnath to visit Germany for defence manufacturing ties

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India and Germany will review the entire gamut of their bilateral ties and explore ways to further enhance co-operation in defence manufacturing during Defence Minister Rajnath Singh's three-day visit there beginning Tuesday, defence ministry said in New Delhi on Sunday.

Giving details, officials said the visit aims to further strengthen the strategic defence partnership between the two countries. During the visit, Rajnath Singh is scheduled to hold bilateral talks with his German counterpart Boris Pistorius and other senior leaders of the Government.

Discussions will focus on



enhancing defence industrial collaboration, strengthening military-to-military engagements, and exploring opportunities in emerging domains such as cyber security, artificial intelligence, and drones. A Defence Industrial Cooperation Roadmap and Implementing Arrangement for Cooperation in UN

Peacekeeping Operations Training are likely to be signed in the presence of both Defence Ministers.

The visit will provide an opportunity to review the ongoing defence cooperation initiatives and identify new avenues for collaboration between the defence industries of

both countries.

Rajnath Singh is also expected to interact with key representatives of the German defence industry, with a view to promoting joint development and co-production under the Make-in-India initiative.

This visit comes after a gap of seven years. The last visit by an Indian Defence Minister to Germany was Nirmala Sitharaman in February 2019. Boris Pistorius had visited India in June 2023 and held extensive talks with Rajnath Singh.

India and Germany share a strong and multifaceted strategic partnership, anchored in democratic values, the rule of law, and a shared commitment to a rule-based international order.

Delimitation to cause injustice to some States: Siddaramaiah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Haveri (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah on Sunday said the Congress supports women's reservation but opposes linking it with delimitation, alleging that such a move would lead to injustice for certain States.

Speaking to reporters, he maintained that the party has consistently backed reservations for women and accused the BJP of "politicising the issue" ahead of elections in other States.

"The Women's Reservation Bill was already passed in 2023 by both Houses, the Rajya Sabha and the Lok Sabha. Now they have brought it along with delimitation. They have



linked delimitation to it. We have never opposed women's reservation. I am making it very, very clear: we are not opposed to women's reservation," he said.

Siddaramaiah questioned the BJP's track record on women's representation in local bodies, crediting former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi

for introducing constitutional amendments that ensured reservation at the grassroots level. "Who brought women's reservation in local bodies? Who introduced the 73rd and 74th Constitutional Amendments? It was done when Rajiv Gandhi was the PM. Did the BJP do it? Or did

they even demand it?" he asked. The CM argued that delimitation could disproportionately benefit northern States in terms of parliamentary seats, citing Uttar Pradesh as an example, and said Karnataka's representation would not increase at the same rate.

"Delimitation will cause injustice to some states. That is why we oppose it, but we do not oppose women's reservation. We support women's reservation," he said. He added that any constitutional amendment requires a two-thirds majority in Parliament and approval from at least half of the states, reiterating that the Congress party's objection is limited to delimitation.

Centre releases FAQs related to reservation for women amid delimitation row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

At the backdrop questions being raised on the Women and Delimitation Bills that could not be passed in the Parliament last week, the Centre on Sunday came out with a set of Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) related to the reservation for women in legislatures that seeks to provide 33 per cent quota for women in the Lower House and state assemblies.

The FAQs came amid the Opposition's claim that in the name of women quota, the Government was trying to carry out delimitation on its own will based on 2011 census.

The Centre introduced

three key Bills in the Lok Sabha: The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026, The Delimitation Bill, 2026 and The Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026 on April 16, 2026.

On a FAQ to why were these three Bills brought at this point in time, the Government maintained the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', commonly known as the Women Reservation Act, provides that reservation for women will be implemented based on delimitation after the Census conducted post-2026. "If the Government had waited for the Census and subsequent delimitation, women would not have been able to benefit

from 33 per cent reservation even in the 2029 general elections as the Census and subsequent delimitation period takes time. Therefore, to ensure timely benefits to half the population, it was considered necessary to delink implementation of the Act from this condition," said the response.

On a query on benefits of these Bills it had been passed, the Centre said it would have enabled women to receive 33 per cent reservation in the Lok Sabha as early as the 2029 general elections.

On the controversy of linking the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, and why was there a proposal to increase seats, the Government said delimita-



tion means finalising the boundary of a constituency. "It is essential for implementing women's reservation. The limit on seats in the Lok Sabha was set at 550 in 1976. In 1971, the population of India was 54 crore. Today it is 140 crore. Therefore, it is important to increase seats to 850 in the Lok Sabha. This

would enable fair representation of people in Parliament," it said.

The Government also maintained that no changes were proposed to the Delimitation Commission Act and the existing legal framework remains intact, and any recommendations of the commission would require

parliamentary approval and Presidential assent. "Ongoing elections, including those in states like Tamil Nadu or West Bengal, would not be affected, as elections up to 2029 will be conducted under the current system," the FAQ said.

On a query about rationale behind increasing Lok Sabha seats to 850, the Centre said the proposal was based on a proportional expansion approach. A uniform 50 per cent increase in seats would maintain the proportion for all states and UTs. Applying this principle to the current 543 seats would lead to approximately 815 seats. Therefore, the upper limit on seats was increased from current cap of 550 seats in Lok

Sabha to 850 seats, it said.

Government also clarified that all states would see uniform 50 per cent increase in seats. Southern states would not face any reduction in representation; rather, their overall share would remain stable. For example, Tamil Nadu's seats would increase proportionally, ensuring no disadvantage. The southern states currently have 23.76 per cent seats in Lok Sabha. This would have become 23.87 per cent after the passage of the Bills, it said.

Lok Sabha seats in Karnataka would have increased to 42 from present 28; in Andhra Pradesh, the seats would have been 38 from the present 25; in Telangana, the total seats

would have been 26 from the present 17; in Tamil Nadu, it would have been 59 seats from the present 39 and in Kerala, it would have been 30 from the present 20 seats. Total seats in the five southern states would have been increased to 195 from the present 129. This is 543 seats to 816 seats - 50 per cent increase model, the Government asserted.

On the representation of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, the FAQ said the process of delimitation ensures proportional reservation for SC/ST. With an expanded House, the number of reserved seats would increase significantly, thereby strengthening their representation.



States Focus



NAIDU TO BEGIN TWO DAY TAMIL NADU CAMPAIGN TOUR

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu will undertake a two-day campaign tour in Tamil Nadu from Monday as part of the NDA's intensified outreach ahead of the State elections. The visit aims to energise cadre, strengthen voter connect and reinforce the alliance's development-driven narrative across key regions in the State. "Naidu will begin a two-day campaign tour in Tamil Nadu from Monday as NDA steps up its outreach ahead of the State elections," said a source from the Andhra Pradesh Government on Sunday. The NDA will focus on governance, economic growth and inclusive development while strengthening its presence in Tamil Nadu.



TMC DENIES REPORTS OF I-PAC HALTING BENGAL OPERATIONS

Dismissing reports that political consultancy firm I-PAC had suspended its operations in West Bengal as "completely baseless," the TMC on Sunday alleged that a conspiracy was being hatched by the BJP-led Centre to cripple the party's campaign machinery through intimidation. The sharp rebuttal from the ruling party came hours after reports surfaced that the Indian Political Action Committee (I-PAC), which has been closely associated with the TMC's election campaigns since 2021, had allegedly asked its employees in West Bengal to stop work immediately and proceed on a 20-day leave. A newspaper report claimed an email purportedly sent by the organisation to its employees late on Saturday night cited "legal obligations" and said work in West Bengal would remain suspended until May 11, after which the next course of action would be communicated.

No power can stop women's quota rollout: Rajnath Singh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Vasudevanallur (Tamil Nadu)

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday slammed the Congress and DMK over the defeat of the amendment bill regarding the Women's Reservation Act in Parliament but said the Government was determined to implement it and that "no power in the world can stop us," from doing so.

Addressing a poll rally in support of BJP candidate from Vasudevanallur, Ananthan Ayyasamy in Tenkasi district for the April 23 Assembly polls, he lashed out at the ruling DMK over corruption and urged people to "give it a farewell" in the hustings.

"Recently, Prime Minister Narendra Modi brought a bill in Parliament to ensure 33 per cent reservation for our mothers and sisters in Parliament, assemblies and councils. The DMK, Congress, TMC and Communist parties did not allow it to be passed. Still, I would like to assure, on the basis of the PM's resolve,



Rajnath Singh during a roadshow at Vasudevanallur constituency ahead of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Tenkasi on Sunday

that we will certainly give 33 per cent reservation for women and no power in the world can stop us," the senior BJP leader said.

Lashing out at the DMK over corruption, Singh said some Tamil Nadu ministers were under the radar of central probe agencies such as the ED and the "TASMAC scam" was an example of how "deep-rooted" corruption was in the State.

"The DMK Government is playing with the lives of poor people. Corruption allegations have become a pattern in the DMK Government. The time has come to raise your voice against this corruption and give farewell to the ruling

dispensation," he said, while batting for the AIADMK-led NDA in the State.

Further, the people of Tamil Nadu were known for their faith and anyone trying to mock Sanatan Dharma "will fall before the eyes of the people." Touching upon the Thirupprankundram lamp lighting row, he charged that despite a court order, the DMK Government did not allow devotees to light a lamp atop a pillar (Deepathoon) there.

If the NDA is voted to power, the lamp lighting tradition will be allowed and "this is NDA's guarantee," Singh assured. Further, slamming the "rampant" avail-

ability of illicit liquor in the State, he said the NDA Government will form local units to tackle the menace.

Also, Singh claimed that Tamil Nadu's debts stood at ₹11 lakh crore. However, he alleged this money was not being used for public welfare and that it was "going into the pockets of DMK leaders."

"Our Government will probe everyone and punish the guilty," he added.

He also dismissed DMK's allegation of "discrimination" by the Centre against Tamil Nadu vis-à-vis funds, saying PM Modi has given ₹11 lakh crore so far.

Further, only two States — Uttar Pradesh and Tamil Nadu — have been given the defence industrial corridor.

Escalating his attack against the ruling party, he said DMK in Tamil meant "*Dushprayogam* (misuse of power), *Muraikedu* (irregularities), *Kutram* (crime). The NDA, on the other hand, stands for "*Nalan*, *Nyayam* (welfare, justice), Development and *Amaithi* (peace)," he said.

DMK, Congress betrayed women on reservation: Amit Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Erode (Tamil Nadu)

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday lashed out at the Congress and DMK for voting against the Women's Reservation amendment bill in the Lok Sabha, accusing them of "betraying" women from getting the quota in Parliament and State Assemblies. However, the Prime Minister Narendra Modi Government would not allow the "conspiracy" to succeed and ensure justice for the women of the country,

he said.

Addressing a roadshow in Erode in support of his party's Modakurichi candidate for the April 23 Assembly polls, Kirthika Shivkumar, the senior BJP leader, also expressed confidence that the NDA would form the Government under the leadership of AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami in the State post the polls.

"Congress and DMK have certainly deprived sisters and mothers across the country, in Tamil Nadu, of reservation in Parliament and assem-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah waves to a gathering during a roadshow ahead of Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Erode, Tamil Nadu

blies. There was a chance for a 50 per cent (Lok Sabha) seat increase for Tamil Nadu. But they have conspired to reduce Tamil Nadu's seats by

insisting on their increase based on the 2026 census."

"But on behalf of PM Narendra Modi, I want to assure the people of Tamil

Mamata accuses PM of misusing govt machinery for campaigns



West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee addressing a campaign ahead of the State Assembly elections in Hooghly district, West Bengal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tarakeswar (WB)

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of "misusing" Government machinery for political campaigns.

Addressing a poll rally in Hooghly district's Tarakeswar, Banerjee alleged that Modi indulged in "illegal campaign" for the BJP through his address to the nation regarding the women's quota bill.

"They (BJP) misused the Government machinery yesterday for political campaigns. We condemn this and will file a complaint (to the EC)," she said, accusing the PM of violating the Model Code of Conduct (MCC).

In an address to the nation on Saturday, a day after a bill

to implement 33 per cent women's reservation in legislatures from 2029 was defeated in the Lok Sabha, Modi warned the Congress and its allies that the women of India will severely punish them for "the sin of foeticide".

Banerjee said, "You (PM) have to answer to the people of India as you did an illegal campaign for your party."

The TMC chief said that the women's reservation bill was passed in September 2023, and asked why the Central Government has not yet implemented it.

Questioning how many times the "same bill needs to be passed," Banerjee claimed that the BJP-led Government linked the delimitation bill with the women's quota legislation tabled in the Lok Sabha.

Release ₹2 lakh crore dues before professing love: Abhishek to PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

TMC national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Sunday urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to first release the pending ₹2 lakh crore central dues to West Bengal before professing his love for the people of the State and their well-being.

Addressing an election meeting at Sagar Island in South 24 Parganas district, Banerjee also asserted that "Modi's guarantee" means "zero guarantee" while Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee keeps her words.

"I am telling the hon'ble PM with all respect, please speak like the Prime Minister. I wish you a long life. Please facilitate sending the ₹2 lakh crore



dues you failed to release for Bengal over the last few years," he said.

Banerjee claimed that "people from Gujarat" are issuing threats to people of Bengal to put them in jail.

"Let me tell Modi and Shah, use central force and agencies, but your game plan and conspiracy have been

exposed before the people. Wait for May 4 to see the (election) results." Banerjee, the de facto number 2 in the TMC hierarchy, demanded that Modi show his commitment to the welfare of women and youth by sending money to the accounts of women, youth, fisherfolk and farmers. Banerjee alleged that BJP

leaders have become "allergic" to the TMC's slogan '*Jai Bangla*', which, he said, is a call to strengthen Bengali pride and the growth and welfare of the State in the federal structure.

The BJP has been alleging that the '*Jai Bangla*' slogan belongs to Bangladesh.

"Some of the BJP leaders are behaving like madmen on hearing the Jai Bangla slogan at rallies. They are trying to get down from the vehicles to confront those who chant the slogan. I pity such leaders," the TMC leader said.

Banerjee was apparently referring to BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari, who, during a recent roadshow in Bally, had engaged in an argument with TMC workers who raised the slogan.

Women will not forgive DMK for opposing reservation: Palaniswami

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Namakkal (Tamil Nadu)

Charging the DMK Government for opposing the women's reservation amendment bill, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Sunday said that every woman would not forgive the ruling party.

Addressing a poll rally in Tiruchengode constituency, he asked, "What exactly did the Central Government propose? It was a bill granting 33 per cent reservation for women, yet the DMK defeated this bill. It was the Congress and the DMK that obstructed the rights of the women they were poised to receive."

Claiming that the AIADMK genuinely desires reservation for women, the former CM said the parties aligned with the DMK lack commitment to the cause.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi held consultations with us, and we gave our assent, following which he introduced the bill.

"However, the DMK, along with its alliance partners, voted against it and ensured its defeat. Will the women of this State ever forgive them?" he asked.



Palaniswami said the DMK opposed it despite the Centre's assurances that Tamil Nadu would not be affected.

Targeting Chief Minister MK Stalin, he said concerns were raised that population-based delimitation would reduce the State's representation. According to him, the Centre had clarified that Tamil Nadu's share would not decline and could, in fact, rise from 7.18 percent to 7.23 per cent with the number of seats proposed to increase from 39 to 59.

"The Centre's stance was entirely favourable to Tamil Nadu," he said.

Alleging that Stalin had let down the people of this nation, he said, "you (Stalin)

have shattered the dreams of the public-and specifically, the dreams of women".

"Teach a fitting lesson to the DMK-Congress alliance, which obstructed the provision of 33 per cent reservation for women in both Parliament and the State Assemblies," he told the gathering. Regarding the law and order situation in the State, Palaniswami alleged a rise in crime, citing figures attributed to the Minister of Social Welfare.

He claimed that 24,000 cases of sexual offences were registered during the DMK regime, and of these, 18,000 involved minor girls and 6,999 were cases registered under the POCSO Act.

"Criminals have no fear of the police, because members of the DMK stand as their accomplices.

Just as reports regarding gold prices used to dominate the news in the past, today they are filled with reports of murders, sexual crimes, and drug-related offences," he added.

Listing out the AIADMK election manifesto, Palaniswami said if his party comes to power, the rice, which is supplied through ration shops, will be on par with that available in the provision stores.

Debate on Congress CM candidate only after results: Natesan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Alappuzha (Kerala)

SNDP Yogam leader Vellappally Natesan on Sunday said discussions within the Congress over the chief minister candidate are premature and should take place only after the election results are announced.

Speaking to reporters, Natesan said such debates would be inappropriate if the LDF returns to power.

"After the election results, if the LDF comes to power, such discussions will be

shameful. It would have been better to hold them after the results," he said.

The Kerala Assembly election was held on April 9 and the results will be announced on May 4.

Natesan said internal competition for power in the Congress is not new and leaders like Ramesh Chennithala and K Sudhakaran are ambitious.

"It is Congress culture. There is no point in commenting on it," he said.

Natesan said any leader who wins the election is capable of becoming the

BJP's Khushbu defends 'outsiders', hits back at DMK ministers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Madurai (Tamil Nadu)

Senior BJP leader Khushbu Sundar on Sunday dismissed criticism regarding the induction and fielding of "outsiders" in elections, pointing out that the ruling DMK's own Cabinet has leaders who switched from other parties.

Responding to queries about her husband Sundar C's candidacy and criticism from actor Prakash Raj, Khushbu asserted that political merit is not exclusive to those born into a party.

"Look at the history of the DMK ministers like Senthil Balaji, KKSSR Ramachandran Reddiyar, and S



Regupathy — did they all grow up in the DMK? They came from elsewhere," she said.

She further took a swipe at Prakash Raj, suggesting he focus on his own

electoral record, where he failed to save his deposit, before questioning the credentials of others.

Earlier in the day, actor Prakash Raj, campaigning for DMK's candidate for Madurai central assembly constituency, Palanivel Thiaga Rajan, launched a scathing political attack on both Sundar C and Khushbu.

He strongly criticised their political stances and reliability, taking a direct dig at Khushbu by pointing out that she had "jumped 3 parties in 10 years" (referencing her moves between the DMK, Congress, and BJP). In the Madurai central assembly constituency, Palanivel Thiaga Rajan will be up against Sundar C, a film director, producer and actor,

that infighting within the Congress is a key issue, as it leads to differing opinions among leaders.

"It is Congress culture—they fight among themselves and then unite. Once they get power, they will start fighting again," he said.

Natesan also said Ramesh Chennithala would not become irrelevant amid the power tussle between Satheesan and Venugopal, as he is a senior and capable leader. He added that there is no doubt that Pinarayi Vijayan will lead the LDF if it retains power.

fielded by the NDA through Puthiya Needhi Katchi. Khushbu emphasised that, unlike the "dynasty politics" of the DMK, her family has built a brand through public service and hard work.

In a sharp escalation, she labelled the DMK-Congress alliance as "educated fools" for their stance on the Women's Reservation Amendment Bill. She argued that the Opposition is intentionally "misleading" the public by ignoring the constitutional necessity of a census and delimitation before implementation.

"They are stabbing women in the chest by trying to stall this progress," she added, slamming the UPA's previous inaction on the same issue.



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Order Order

NGT seeks response on illegal groundwater extraction



The National Green Tribunal has sought a response from the Delhi Government and others on the alleged large-scale illegal extraction of groundwater in Najafgarh.

The green body was hearing a plea claiming unauthorised extraction by "private tanker mafia" operators in a plot in the Pankaj Garden locality of the area. In an order dated April 13, a bench of NGT Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava and expert members A Senthil Vel and Afroz Ahmad noted the plea alleging "collusion and inaction on the part of the authorities", including the Delhi Jal Board (DJB).

"Issue notice to the respondents," the bench said.

The respondents in the matter include the Delhi Government, DJB, the sub-divisional magistrate and district magistrate concerned, Delhi Police, Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) and others. The matter has been posted to July 10 for further proceedings.

POCSO court acquits man accused of raping, impregnating stepsister

A special POCSO court in Thane acquitted a man accused of raping and impregnating his minor stepsister after the victim turned hostile and a DNA test established he was not the father of the child she delivered later.

Special Judge Ruby U Malvankar acquitted the man, who was 20 at the time of the alleged incident, of Indian Penal Code and Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act charges related to aggravated rape, causing hurt by means of poison, or any stupefying, intoxicating, or unwholesome drug/substance with the intent to commit offence, among others.

As per the prosecution, the man gave his then 14-year-old stepsister a spiked soft drink and committed sexual assault in December 2023, leading to her getting pregnant and delivering a child in September 2024.

During the trial, the victim denied that the accused had administered any intoxicating substance or committed sexual assault, adding that she implicated him "out of fear."

Concluding the prosecution had failed to prove the victim was a "child" as per the legal definition (due to conflicting age reports) or that the accused committed the crime, the court, in its order of April 17, ordered his immediate acquittal.

Legal if a parent takes child's custody by force without violating law: Allahabad HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj (UP)



The Allahabad High Court has dismissed as non-maintainable a habeas corpus petition moved by a woman seeking custody of her minor children from her estranged husband, observing that a father is a natural guardian of a Hindu minor and cannot be said to illegally detain a child even if he forcibly takes custody unless such an act is in violation of court order.

The petitioner's mother had moved to court alleging that her estranged husband forcibly took away their two minor children at gunpoint in 2022 and had kept them under illegal detention since then.

Dismissing the petition, Justice Anil Kumar-X, relying on the Supreme Court's judgment in Tejaswini Gaud and others vs Shekhar Jagdish Prasad Tewari and others, observed that habeas corpus in child custody matters can be invoked only when the custody of a child is illegal or without lawful authority.

On behalf of mother, Anjali Devi, it was submitted that several applications were filed before different forums seeking custody of the minors. However, no effective action had been taken by the authorities.

The petitioner's counsel also relied upon the high court's recent judgment in Rinku Ram alias Rinku Devi and another v. State of UP and seven others to argue that the court can invoke its extraordinary jurisdiction in the best interest of the child even in cases where a child

is in the custody of another parent. The state counsel and the counsel for the respondent submitted that both minors have been residing with the father since 2022, and the petitioner-mother, before moving to the high court, had not availed of any remedy under the Guardian and Wards Act to date.

It was also argued that the custody disputes between parents ordinarily cannot be adjudicated in a writ petition under Article 226 of the Constitution.



A 30-year curse revived: Behind the defeat of the women's reservation bill, 2026



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The Women's Reservation Bill (Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam) was defeated in the Lok Sabha on April 17, 2026. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, which sought to operationalise the reservation by 2029, failed to secure the required two-thirds majority. While 298 members voted in favour, 230 voted against it — leaving the Government 54 votes short of the "magic figure" of 352.

This April 2026 defeat is not an isolated event; it marks the latest setback in a 30-year struggle. Since its introduction in 1996, the Women's Reservation Bill failed six times before the 2023 version was finally signed into law.

For decades, the path to implementation was blocked by deep-seated political divisions. Parties like the RJD and Samajwadi Party frequently stalled the Bill, demanding a specific sub-quota for OBC and Muslim women out of fear that the reservation would only benefit "elite" women.

Beyond public debates, there was also quiet resistance from male MPs across party lines who feared losing their seats to the massive "rotation" of constituencies that a 33 per cent reservation would trigger. Until 2023, there was never a moment when both the ruling party and the major opposition parties were on the same page regarding the technical details.

The 2026 Bill was designed as a "bridge" to fast-track the women's reservation, which was technically passed in 2023, and remains stuck in legal limbo. Its primary aim was to implement the 33 per cent quota by the 2029 General Election by decoupling it from the requirement of a fresh Census.

Specifically, the Bill sought to achieve three main objectives: The original 2023 Act stated reservation would only kick in after a new Census and subsequent delimitation—a process likely to push implementation to 2034. This Bill proposed



using 2011 Census data to start delimitation immediately for a 2029 rollout. It aimed to increase the Lok Sabha's strength from 543 to 850 seats. By doing so, the Government could reserve 283 seats for women without reducing the absolute number of seats currently held by men, thereby reducing "political resistance" from sitting MPs.

The Bill sought to remove the constitutional freeze (in place since 1976) on the number of seats per state, allowing for a "reset" of India's electoral map based on current population densities.

Following the defeat after a high-voltage debate, the Government withdrew two related pieces of legislation: the Delimitation Bill, 2026, and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026. The Lok Sabha was subsequently adjourned sine die, ending this legislative push for the current session.

The primary reason for the Bill's defeat was its linkage to the new delimitation exercise. While the amendment promised a 33 per cent quota by 2029, the united opposition (INDIA Bloc) argued the Bill was a "Trojan horse." They claimed the Government was using women's rights to sugar-coat a massive electoral overhaul that would unfairly shift political power toward certain states.

While Shashi Tharoor is credited with popularising the "Trojan horse" label, it became a collective "war cry" for the opposition led by Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi to justify defeating a Bill that, on the surface, supported a popular cause. Concerns were particularly

sharp in Southern and Northeastern states, which feared a loss of political representation. States like Tamil Nadu and Kerala argued that redrawing seats based on 2011 or 2026 population data would penalize them for successful population control.

Ultimately, the Opposition insisted that women's reservation should be a standalone measure rather than a tool to overhaul the entire parliamentary structure, noting that the proposal to use 2011 Census data failed to inspire confidence.

Despite the defeat of the amendment, the original Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023, remains law. In a late-night move on April 16, the Government formally notified the commencement of the 2023 Act. This means the legal framework is technically "active," though its practical execution remains tied to the completion of the next Census and subsequent delimitation.

Without the now-defeated 2026 amendments, the implementation of women's reservation is likely to revert to the original timeline, which experts suggest may not be feasible until the 2034 elections.

The Opposition has stated they will write to the Prime Minister demanding the implementation of the reservation as a "standalone" measure, without tying it to the controversial redistribution of parliamentary seats.

An interesting aspect of the whole issue was that the debate was triggered by the sudden announcement of a Special Session of the House. This was a significant depar-



ture from the normal legislative course, as Special Sessions are traditionally reserved for landmark historical milestones or national emergencies.

Because the agenda was kept under wraps until the very last moment, both the Opposition and political observers were left completely unaware of the true reasons for holding such a high-stakes debate under these extraordinary circumstances.

The timing of the development was particularly striking, as the debate was called while the country was in the midst of a major election cycle. The Election Commission of India (ECI) had already scheduled assembly elections for four states—Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal, and Assam—and the Union Territory of Puducherry, alongside several key bye-elections.

With voters in these regions heading to the polls this month, critics argued that a discussion on such a sensitive and transformative issue as women's reservation should have waited for a regular session. This timing provided a clear opening for leaders from opposition-ruled states currently in the heat of a campaign to question the Government's motives. They contended that the sudden urgency was less about constitutional progress and more about creating a political narrative to influence the electorate in those poll-bound states.

On one side, the Government has taken a sharp offensive. They are portraying the defeat of the Bill as a betrayal of Indian women by the Opposition. Their narrative is that they provided a practical "bridge" to make the 33 per cent quota a reality by 2029, rather than making women wait another decade.

By focusing on the "Nari Shakti" (Women's Power) theme, the Government is telling voters—especially in the states currently going to the polls—that they tried to fast-track equality, but were blocked by "regressive" political rivals.

On the other side, the Opposition has stood firm on its "Trojan Horse" argument. They argue that their role was not to block women's rights, but to protect the country from a secret overhaul of the electoral system. By voting against the Bill, they claim they saved the

SC issues pan-India directions for road safety

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Observing that expressways must not become corridors of peril due to administrative lethargy or infrastructural gaps, the Supreme Court has issued a slew of pan-India guidelines for enhancing road safety, including a ban on parking of heavy vehicles on such roads.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar pointed out that national highways constitute two percent of India's total road length but account for nearly 30 per cent of all road fatalities.

A bench of Justices JK Maheshwari and AS Chandurkar issued directions to the Ministry of Road and Transport, National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) and States and Union Territories to make roads safer, observing that the loss of even a single life to avoidable hazards like illegal parking or blackspots etc., represents a failure of the State's protective umbrella. "The loss of even a single life



to avoidable hazards like illegal parking or blackspots etc., represents a failure of the State's protective umbrella. The 'Right to Life' enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution of India is not merely a guarantee against the unlawful taking of life, but a positive mandate upon the State to ensure a safe environment where human life is preserved and valued," the top court said in its order of April 13.

It passed the order in a suo motu case registered in the aftermath of the loss of 34 lives in successive road accidents on November 2 and 3, 2025, in Phalodi in Rajasthan, and Rangareddy in Telangana on the systemic negligence and catastrophic infrastructure failures that led to these inevitable casualties.

The bench, which issued pan-India directions said, "Recognising the safety of the commuter as an integral facet of the right to live with dignity as a constitutional obligation under Article 21 of Constitution of India, it is necessary in the interest to address the systematic root causes that these interim directions are issued in exercise of powers under Article 142 of the Constitution of India."

The bench said the court reiterates that no pecuniary or administrative constraint can outweigh the sanctity of human life, and the strict timelines provided herein reflect the urgency of this constitutional obligation.

Delhi HC to hear on ED plea against Sonia, Rahul today



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear a plea by the ED challenging the trial court's order that refused to take cognisance of its chargesheet against Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and others in the National Herald-linked money laundering case.

The case is listed for hearing before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma.

On December 22, the high court had issued notice to the Gandhis and others on the main petition as well as on the ED's application seeking a stay on the December 16, 2025 trial court order, which held that cognisance of the agency's complaint in the case was "impermissible in law" as it was not founded on an FIR.

Besides Gandhis, the high court had also issued notices to Suman Dubey, Sam Pitroda, Young Indian, Dotex Merchandise Pvt Ltd and Sunil Bhandari on the ED's plea.

The ED has accused Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi, as well as late Congress leaders Motilal Vora and Oscar Fernandes, along with Suman Dubey, Sam Pitroda, and a private company, Young Indian, of conspiracy and money laundering.

It has been alleged that they acquired properties worth approximately ₹2,000 crore belonging to

Associated Journals Limited (AJL), which publishes the National Herald newspaper. It further alleged that the Gandhis held the majority 76 per cent shares in Young Indian, which "fraudulently" usurped the assets of AJL in exchange for a ₹90 crore loan.

On February 19, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta appeared for the ED and argued that the case concerned a "neat question of law" and the reasons given by the trial court to refuse taking cognizance were "patently perverse".

He said the case has to be argued on law and not facts, and the trial court's findings were "coming in the way" of other cases. In its order, the trial court had said that an investigation and the consequent prosecution complaint (equivalent to a chargesheet) pertaining to the offence of money laundering were "not maintainable" in the absence of an FIR for the offence mentioned in the schedule to the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA).

It said the agency's probe stemmed from a private complaint and not an FIR and despite receiving the complaint made by BJP leader Subramanian Swamy and the consequent summoning order in 2014, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) refrained from registering an FIR in relation to the alleged scheduled offence.

Writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

Nashik court sends 'godman' Kharat in police custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nashik



A holiday court in Nashik on Sunday remanded self-styled godman Ashok Kharat in police custody till April 23 in the fifth case of sexual assault and exploitation registered against him.

Kharat, who was arrested on March 18 after a 35-year-old woman lodged a rape complaint against him at Sarkarwada police station here, has since been accused of sexually assaulting several women and indulging in large-scale financial frauds by claiming to have divine powers and knowledge of black magic. Kharat was formally placed under arrest on Saturday in the fifth case, in which he is accused of cheating the victim by using black magic and pretending to be an incarnation of God.

He was presented in court on Sunday through video conferencing by police, who sought five-day custody.

While advocate Sachin Thore, appearing for Kharat, contended that all cases are similar in nature and enough custody has been granted to police on the same grounds, and, therefore, further remand was not required, Government lawyers Shailendra Bagade and Kiran Bendbhar asserted that stories of each victim woman are different.

The crimes were very serious in nature and thorough investigation was required, Bagade and Bendbhar told court.

"It is important for us to conduct a thorough investigation into each case separately," Bendbhar said.

After hearing both sides, the court remanded Kharat in police custody till April 23.



During the hearing, Kharat, through his lawyer, orally sought permission to consult a neurosurgeon for shoulder pain, saying pain killers were not helping him.

The court directed the police to provide treatment as per requirement when the accused is taken for medical examination at the civil hospital while in jail.

The Maharashtra Government has set up a Special Investigation Team to probe cases of sexual assault and financial fraud registered against Kharat. He is facing at least 12 criminal cases in Nashik and Ahilyanagar districts, including eight for sexual assault.

Editor's
TAKE

Women’s Bill falls: A reform lost in distrust

The Women’s Reservation Bill: where empowerment and federal equity clashed, and consensus gave way to confrontation, stalling a long-awaited reform

In an unprecedented development, the Women’s Reservation Bill fell on the floor of Parliament, dashing hopes of women’s reservation of 33 per cent in Lok Sabha. The government had worked hard on it and had called a three-day special session of Parliament to pass the bill. But that was not to happen as the opposition parties and regional parties did not agree to the provisions of the proposed bill. The southern states, in particular, felt that their representation, though might improve in absolute terms, would decrease in proportion to the northern states where population is dense and the sole criterion for the delimitation was the head count. The collapse of the women’s reservation amendment in Parliament show the lack of political consensus on reform, representation, and federal balance. The subsequent address to the nation by Narendra Modi sought to recast the defeat as a moral and political betrayal by the Opposition, but the reality is perhaps more complex and needs to be studied carefully. Setting aside the Opposition’s reservations does not help, as their fears must be assuaged. What the government had proposed was a set of three Bills that attempted to expand the size of Lok Sabha while ensuring 33 per cent reservation for women. This linkage—between representation and redistribution of seats—proved to be its undoing. The Opposition parties – the Indian National Congress, Samajwadi Party, Trinamool Congress, and Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam – viewed it with suspicion, fearing that the absence of a written guarantee on proportional seat distribution could open the door to a politically sensitive delimitation exercise based on outdated population data of the 2011 census. They also said that the upcoming caste census would be a better basis for deciding the seat allocation in the Lok Sabha. Southern states, which have historically performed better on population control, have long feared losing parliamentary weight if delimitation is conducted on raw population numbers. By failing to codify assurances within the Bill, the government left space for mistrust. In that sense, the Opposition’s resistance was rooted in structural anxieties about federal equity. Yet, the Opposition too cannot escape responsibility. By voting down a measure tied—however imperfectly—to women’s representation, it risks being seen as prioritising political calculus over a long-pending social reform. Their negation would cause further delay in ensuring women participation in the politics. However, the women’s representation must be carefully thought out. As the ground reality is grimmer. The attempts to ensure women’s political participation at lower rungs remains uneven. More often, women may be in power, but the centre of power remains elsewhere. In his address, the Prime Minister chose confrontation over conciliation. His characterisation of the Opposition’s actions as “foeticide” and branding them “anti-reform” may energise political supporters, but it does little to rebuild the consensus necessary for constitutional amendments. Equally, the Opposition’s dismissal of the bill reflects a hardened distrust. The way forward lies not in confrontation but in building consensus through dialogue and debate.

Re-energising Bureaucracy for Viksit Bharat

Recent capacity building initiatives such as Mission Karmayogi may prove to be the silent force which determines whether Vision of Viksit Bharat 2047 succeeds or falters

AMITABH RANJAN

As India pushes aggressively toward the Viksit Bharat 2047 vision, the dominant conversation has been on energy sovereignty, digital public infrastructure and economic growth trajectories. However, under these visible drivers lies a less glamorous, yet decisive factor: the capability of our bureaucracy to deliver outcomes at scale. Recent governance challenges, from Covid-19 containment to rapid digitalisation, have made one thing clear: public policy without administrative capacity to implement is a weak proposition. This is where Mission Karmayogi, the Government of India’s flagship civil services initiative, becomes crucial. For a long time, capacity building in the government sector was viewed as a ‘Compliance Theatre’. Training programmes were episodic, often detached from actual job requirements and focused more on information awareness rather than skill development. The result was a foregone conclusion. Officials who were trained but not necessarily transformed. Mission Karmayogi seeks to change this notion. Its essence is simple but powerful: from rule-based training to competency-driven, role-based learning. Instead of asking what a civil servant knows, the ecosystem focuses on what s/he can actually do. This includes not only domain knowledge but also behavioural capabilities like problem solving, collaboration, communication, empathy, etc., skills which are indispensable in a citizen-centric governance set-up. The iGOT-Karmayogi platform has operationalised this change. As a digital learning ecosystem, it has revolutionised anytime, anywhere learning. The real innovation, however, lies in linking learning with performance. Training is no longer a box to be ticked. It is tied to appraisals, outcomes and service delivery improvements. This is a huge shift from the past. Probably for the first time, capacity building is being ingrained into the DNA of governance rather than being treated as an external addition. Early signals are heart-warming. Participation levels have skyrocketed, ministries and departments are aligning training with functional necessities, and a gradual cultural shift is now obvious. The bureaucracy is beginning to move away from a compliance mind-set toward a learning mind-set. This shift, though subtle, may prove to be transformational. The timing of these reforms is crucial. India’s governance ecosystem is becoming increasingly complex. Emerging technologies and AI disruptions, climate change, cybersecurity threats and global economic volatility are no longer abstract concerns. They are immediate administrative challenges. The COVID-19 pandemic demonstrated both the strengths of India’s civil services and the need for continuous, structured upskilling. Mission Karmayogi acknowledges that governance today requires more than technical expertise. It requires adaptability. It requires innovation. And above all, it requires a growth mind-set, and not a fixed mind-set, that is open to continuous learning. More importantly, the reform push is not limited to the higher bureaucracy. Initiatives like National Learning Week and Sadhana Saptah are extending this culture of capacity building to states, districts, municipalities and panchayats i.e. addressing the grassroots public administration and challenges. This decentralised approach is critical because India’s development outcomes are ultimately determined at the last mile. This initiative is now democratising the training ecosystem in India: ‘Training for All’, available from chairmen to linemen. However, the reform journey is far from complete. One significant threat is the dilution of training quality. As the number of courses expands, there is a real danger of falling back to a checklist approach unless the content is rigorously curated and updated. Quantity must not come at the cost of quality. Another sore point is the digital divide. Platforms like iGOT promise inclusivity, but uneven access to connectivity and digital infrastructure, particularly in rural India, may limit their impact. Bridging this gap is necessary if the reform is to achieve relevance across India. But probably the toughest challenge is institutional inertia. Systems can be rebooted quickly, but not mindsets. Embedding a culture of continuous lifelong learning asks for sustained leadership push, rewards and incentives. So, what is the way forward? Firstly, capacity building must be made outcome-oriented. Training programmes should be directly linked to measurable improvements in governance like efficient public service delivery, better grievance redressal and enhanced citizen satisfaction. Public dashboards and transparent metrics can help push accountability. Secondly, technology must be leveraged more strategically. AI-driven analytics can identify skill gaps and create personalised learning driveways for officers, ensuring that training remains relevant in a rapidly evolving ecosystem. Thirdly, states and local bodies must be equal partners. Governance in India is federal in nature and capacity-building frameworks must reflect that reality. Investing in grassroots administrative capability is now not an option but mandatory for inclusive development. Finally, learning must be incentivised. Career progression, recognition and peer-learning platforms can help institutionalise continuous capacity-enhancement within the civil services. At its core, Mission Karmayogi is not just a training initiative; it is a huge governance reform. It recognises the fact that strong institutions are created on capable individuals and that administrative excellence is the foundation of national development. India’s aspiration to become Viksit Bharat by 2047 is bold, but it is achievable. The real test lies not in framing policies but in implementing them effectively on the ground. If Mission Karmayogi succeeds in sustaining momentum and deepening its impact, it could quietly become one of the most consequential reforms of our time. In conclusion, Viksit Bharat would not be defined only by what India builds, but by how effectively and efficiently it governs.

MISSION KARMAYOGI ACKNOWLEDGES THAT GOVERNANCE TODAY REQUIRES MORE THAN TECHNICAL EXPERTISE. IT REQUIRES ADAPTABILITY. IT REQUIRES INNOVATION. AND ABOVE ALL, IT REQUIRES A GROWTH MINDSET, AND NOT A FIXED MINDSET, THAT IS OPEN TO CONTINUOUS LEARNING.

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PIC TALK

A woman performs rituals in the River Ganga on the occasion of ‘Akshaya Tritiya’, in Patna

PHOTO: PTI

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Emotional Intelligence: The anchor of human connection

SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

In an era marked by volatility and constant uncertainty, emotional intelligence has become less of a soft skill and more of a necessity. Global tensions, such as the ongoing conflict in West Asia, have far-reaching economic and psychological consequences, often filtering into everyday life. While such events are beyond individual control, the way people process and respond to them is not. This is where emotional intelligence—understood as the ability to recognise, manage and express emotions judiciously—assumes critical importance. It shapes the tone of relationships, deepens empathy, and sustains mutual respect. The present climate of anxiety, driven by economic uncertainty and an unrelenting stream of distressing news, has heightened emotional vulnerability. When left unchecked, these emotions can spill into personal and professional relationships, magnifying minor disagreements into serious conflicts. Emotional intelligence provides a safeguard against this erosion. At its foundation lies self-awareness—the capacity to identify one’s emotional state and understand how it influences behaviour. Recognising feelings of frustration, fear or fatigue allows individuals to prevent them from distorting interactions with others. Closely linked to this is self-regulation, the discipline of managing emotional responses. Emotionally intelligent individuals tend to resist impulsive reactions, choosing instead to pause, reflect and respond thoughtfully. This deliberate restraint, often described as the “power of the pause,” helps de-escalate tension and fosters a more balanced environment. In both personal and professional spaces, such composure can make the difference between conflict and resolution. Empathy, another cornerstone of emotional intelligence, plays a vital role in strengthening relationships. The ability to understand and share another person’s perspective builds trust and emotional closeness. However, empathy must remain balanced. When it becomes excessive or misplaced, it risks enabling unhealthy behaviour or avoiding necessary truths. Effective communication is deeply intertwined with emotional intelligence. It is not limited to articulate expression but extends to attentive and mindful listening. Many conflicts arise not from fundamental disagreements but from misunderstandings and unspoken expectations. When people feel genuinely heard and acknowledged, relationships naturally grow stronger. Within families, emotional intelligence acts as an anchor of stability. Children, in particular, are sensitive to the emotional climate around them. Similarly, in professional settings, emotional intelligence has emerged as a defining leadership trait. Beyond individual relationships, emotional intelligence influences how people engage with society at large. In times marked by division and conflict, the ability to approach differences with understanding rather than hostility becomes invaluable. It encourages respect for diverse viewpoints. Importantly, emotional intelligence is not innate; it requires conscious cultivation. Practices such as mindful listening, reflection, gratitude and presence in conversations can gradually strengthen this capacity. In an unpredictable world, intellectual ability alone is insufficient. It is emotional intelligence that sustains relationships, nurtures trust and anchors individuals amid uncertainty. Ultimately, when external stability falters, it is the depth and quality of human connections—shaped by emotional awareness—that provide enduring strength.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

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DELIMITATION BILL DEFEAT TRIGGERS POLITICAL STORM

A day after the Delimitation Bill failed to pass in Parliament, sharp political reactions underscored the deep divide it has created. While some described the outcome as a “victory of democracy,” the opposition INDIA bloc termed it a “black day” for the Centre. The defeat marks the first significant parliamentary setback for the BJP-led government. Critics of the bill argued that it was an attempt to alter India’s federal structure and weaken democratic institutions. They hailed the result as a victory for the Constitution envisioned by Dr. B.R. Ambedkar, as well as for the unity of the opposition. At the same time, they urged the government to revive and implement the women’s reservation framework that was passed unanimously in 2023, without linking it to delimitation. On the other hand, voices within the ruling establishment dismissed the opposition’s criticism, suggesting that the backlash reflects political discomfort after an unexpected setback. They maintained that women voters are perceptive and capable of seeing beyond political narratives and media messaging. The bill, which sought to tie women’s reservation to a future delimitation exercise, fell short of the required two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha. It secured 298 votes in favour and 230 against, with reports indicating dissent even within the ruling party ranks. BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Political flux in Italy

Political tremors are becoming increasingly visible in Italy as Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni faces waning authority after the failure of a key judicial referendum and signs of internal dissent within her ranks. Her once warm rapport with Donald Trump has also cooled, particularly following public disagreements over policies in the Middle East, thereby denting her global standing. Amid this uncertainty, Silvia Salis has emerged as a dynamic progressive challenger. Her leadership in Genoa—a major port city—has been marked by youth-centric reforms and an emphasis on inclusive governance. This approach is energising a fragmented opposition and positioning her as a potential unifying figure at the national level. Meloni’s weakening grip has wider implications. For India, the evolving political landscape in Italy could affect trade continuity and strategic engagement within the broader European framework, calling for a measured and cautious diplomatic recalibration. In sum, Italy’s shifting political landscape signals both uncertainty and opportunity, with leadership transitions likely to reshape domestic priorities, international alignments, and economic partnerships, demanding calibrated responses.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Urgent need to manage space traffic

This refers to “ISRO report: 1.5 lakh space collision alerts recorded in 2025” (The Pioneer, April 17). The Indian Space Situational Assessment Report (ISSAR) 2025 by Indian Space Research Organisation highlights how increasingly congested outer space has become. With 315 global launches placing 4,651 objects into orbit last year, space now mirrors the traffic chaos we often associate with roads. The report underscores the urgent need for effective space traffic management systems.ISRO itself carried out 18 collision avoidance manoeuvres to safeguard its satellites, reflecting the growing risks. Not only operational spacecraft but also defunct satellites, debris fragments, and rocket bodies are competing for orbital space. The rise of large satellite constellations has further complicated tracking, reducing warning times and increasing vulnerability. Both Low Earth Orbit (LEO) and Geosynchronous Orbit (GSO) face persistent collision threats.To address these challenges, ISRO has implemented the IS40M system for monitoring close approaches. Measures such as designing satellites for controlled re-entry and enhancing surveillance through advanced radars and telescopes are vital steps toward ensuring sustainable and safe space operations.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Workplace safety is a serious concern

The recent case involving a Nashik-based BPO reportedly linked to Tata Consultancy Services has raised serious concerns about workplace safety and ethics. Allegations of sexual harassment and coercive practices have surfaced, with the arrest of the primary accused, Nida Khan, and an ongoing investigation pointing to lapses in internal oversight. It is deeply troubling that employees, particularly women, may have faced mental harassment within a workplace associated with a reputed corporate brand that many young professionals aspire to join. At a time when India seeks to improve women’s participation in the workforce and promote empowerment, such incidents highlight the gap between policy and practice. Workplaces must be safe, inclusive, and respectful environments, especially within large organisations that set industry benchmarks. There is an urgent need for authorities to review the implementation of the POSH Act, 2013, relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and mechanisms like the She-BOX portal across corporate India. Employers must strengthen internal safeguards, ensure accountability, and create transparent redressal systems. This case should serve as a wake-up call for both the government and corporate sector to prioritise the safety and dignity of women at workplaces.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Women’s Reservation Bill: A historic opportunity lost

Championed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Women’s Reservation Bill aimed not only to empower women but also to restructure representation through delimitation. However, fierce opposition in the house derailed the effort, raising serious questions about the future of women’s political participation in the country



ANOOP BOSE

On April 17, 2026, “a date which will live in infamy”, the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeking to reservation of 33 per cent seats for women in an expanded Lok Sabha and State Assemblies and facilitate delimitation of constituencies, nosedived in the Lok Sabha and crashed even before taking off into self-sustained growth. Of the 528 members present in the House, 298 voted in favour of the Bill and 230 opposed it, resulting in the Bill failing to clear the decisive hurdle of attaining the two-thirds majority (popularly termed as the “special majority”) required for a Constitutional Amendment Bill to clear the House, in terms of the affirmative procedure mandated by Article 368 of the Constitution of India. Our most respected and revered Prime Minister Narendra Modi, valiantly leading the charge of the government, had sought to allay a lurking fear of the Opposition parties regarding inequitable representation of Southern States and had personally guaranteed that no injustice would be done to the southern states with the increase in seats in the Lok Sabha. Modi had thundered in ringing tones on the floor of the Lok Sabha, “Let all of us not miss this important opportunity to give reservation to women. I have come to appeal to you - do not see this from a political lens, this is in the national interest”. The Union Home Minister Amit Shah (affectionately known as “Mota Bhai”), in his characteristic style, had also assured the House that the current representation of southern states would be preserved, or increased marginally, once the seats in the Lok Sabha were increased from the current 543 to roughly 816.

Yet, the Bill, despite its avowed merits, faced a wholly unjustified defeat because of the machinations of the opposition parties led by Rahul Gandhi, resplendent in his signature white T shirt, whose grasp of and commitment to the Constitution (his great grandfather, the versatile Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, was one of the principal architects of the Constitution and authored the pivotal “Objectives Resolution” on 13th December, 1946, which laid the philosophical foundation of the Constitution, and chaired key committees like the Union Constitution Committee!) leaves much to be desired and has yet to pass the acid test. It is indeed a lamentable travesty of fate that Rahul Gandhi is the great grandson of the brave and resilient first and only Lady Prime Minister of India Indira Gandhi who was aptly hailed as “Maa Durga” by the prodigious former Prime Minister of India Atal Behari Vajpayee in the very same Lok Sabha after India’s spectacular victory over Pakistan in the 1971 Bangladesh Liberation War as well as the formidable Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray in an interview published in the Shiv Sena mouthpiece Samana on 19th October, 2011.

In his lacklustre speech, full of polemics but shorn of substance and conviction, Rahul fondly remembered his “Dadi”, but conveniently strayed away from the very subject matter of an important constitutional debate and raised wholly extraneous, frivolous and irrelevant pleas. Rahul ranted, “There is a hidden power, massive, extremely strong, but completely hidden. And that power, that force, that doesn’t show itself, but is there, knows the entire history of the magician, it knows every single detail about the magician from when he first came into politics, till when he arrived as Prime Minister. The truth is, the magician has been caught. The magician of Balakot, the magician of Demonetisation, the magician of Sindoor has suddenly got caught, why?... ”

what happened was, the last session of Parliament completely destroyed the structure because a deal was signed with the United States that under no circumstances would have been signed by any Prime Minister of this country, unless he was compromised.” Reprehensively, apart from ridiculing, disparaging and denigrating Modi sarcastically as a “magician” and mockingly assailing the Indo-US trade deal (apparently blissfully ignorant of the fact that Nehru had fostered a warm and cordial “Nehru-Kennedy spirit”) and the US had promptly come to the aid of an embattled and encircled India after the Chinese Dragon (with whom the Gandhis have dishonourably struck a secret pact!) tossed the 1955 Bandung Declaration aside, treacherously stabbed Nehru in the back and unleashed upon India a devastating war on 20th October, 1962, and induced China to declare a unilateral ceasefire on 21st



The Pioneer SINCE 1865

THE HOPES AND DREAMS OF OVER 60 CRORE INDIAN WOMEN HAVE BEEN RUDELY DASHED TO THE GROUND AND THE JUST AND WORTHY CAUSE OF GREATER PARLIAMENTARY REPRESENTATION FOR WOMEN HAS BEEN CONSIGNED TO THE FREEZER LOCKER OF HISTORY!

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November, 1962 and cede considerable territory it had forcibly captured in Arunachal Pradesh!), Rahul has unpatriotically roped in our brave armed forces into the debate and has sought to portray them in a very poor light by raising the spectre of Balakot and Sindoor! Surprisingly, even an astute, enlightened and erudite parliamentarian like the charismatic Shashi Tharoor, who is known as an indefatigable feminist and who is feted, admired and adored by women the world over virtually a la the Italian born actor and dancer Rudolf Valentino (popularly known as the “The Sheik of Araby”), scrupulously chose to tow his party line virtually throwing all his lofty ideals about women’s rights and empowerment literally to the wind! The hopes and dreams of over 60 crore Indian women have been rudely dashed to the ground, and the just and worthy cause of greater parliamentary representation for women has been consigned to the freezer locker of history!

In a powerful, hard hitting special televised address to the nation at 8.30 pm on 18th April, 2026, Modi, said, “Today, every citizen of India can see how the rise of women’s power has been halted and how their dreams have been brutally crushed. Despite our best efforts, we could not succeed. The Women’s Reservation Bill could not be amended, and for this, I sincerely apologize to all mothers and sisters.” He then launched an all-out scathing attack on the opposition saying that the opposition had committed “bhroon hatya” (“female foeticide”) of this honest endeavour by defeating the women’s quota bill. He further went on to assert without mincing words, “What happened in Parliament was not just desk thumping, but an attack on the dignity and self-respect of women. A woman may forget many things, but she never forgets her insult. The conduct of the Congress and its allies in Parliament will remain in the minds of women across the country.”

Retracing the pages of our chequered history, Swami Vivekananda, a staunch advocate of the cause of women, had proudly proclaimed on 21st January, 1895, “Our God is both personal and absolute, the absolute is male, the personal, female. And thus it comes that we now say: ‘The first manifestation of God is the hand that rocks the cradle.’” Again, in May, 1896, he had asserted, “There is no chance of the welfare of the world unless the condition of women is improved. It is not possible for a bird to fly on one wing.” Likewise, Mahatma Gandhi, the Father of the Nation, was a firm believer in women’s empowerment. He had remarked at the All India Women’s Conference on 23rd December, 1936, “When a woman, whom we call abala becomes sabala, all those who are helpless will become powerful.” We are indeed proud of our women parliamentarians and the names of some of them like Radhabai Subbarayan, Rukmini Devi Arundale, Anne Mascarene, Vijay Lakshmi Pandit, Rajkumari Amrit Kaur, Vijaya Raje Scindia, Sucheta Kripalani, Sheila Dikshit, Sushma Swaraj and Geeta Mukherjee read like a veritable roll of honour in the glorious saga of Indian politics.

I am highly emboldened to conclude with the invigorating words of our national poet and Nobel laureate, Gurudev Rabindranath Tagore, “For we women are not only the deities of the household fire, but the flame of the soul itself.”

Countries must master the art of policy exit too!



SHISHIR PRIYADARSHI

support morphs into permanent distortion. Subsidies become entitlements. Fiscal stimulus becomes structural dependence. Protectionist measures outlive the strategic rationale that justified them. The real test of economic statecraft is therefore not just managing disruption; it is restoring normalcy without undermining credibility.

The Hidden Risks of Prolonged Intervention

The longer extraordinary policy measures remain in place, the greater the risks they create. Liquidity support, if extended too far, distorts financial markets. Fiscal expansion, if normalized, weakens sovereign balance sheets. Industrial policy, if left unchecked, degenerates into protectionism. Regulatory forbearance, if prolonged, conceals rather than resolves stress. These risks rarely manifest immediately. That is precisely what makes them dangerous.

Periods of apparent stability often mask the slow accumulation of structural vulnerabilities. Banking systems look strongest before credit quality deteriorates. Fiscal positions appear manageable until market sentiment shifts. Growth remains steady until distortions begin to bite.

In other words, the cost of delayed exit is not visible in the short term. It is a price that economies end up paying later.

Compounding this challenge is the nature of the global environment itself. What the world is experiencing is not a temporary phase of turbulence-it is a structural shift towards persistent volatility.

Geopolitical fragmentation is deepening. Trade is increasingly shaped by strategic rivalry. Supply chains are being redesigned around resilience rather than efficiency. Energy markets remain vulnerable to conflict-driven shocks. Capital flows are more reactive to monetary tightening and political uncertainty. In such a world, the assumption that normalcy will soon return is no longer tenable. It is against this turbulent global backdrop that India’s recent economic performance stands out.

At a time when many economies have struggled with instability, India has maintained a degree of macroeconomic balance that has strengthened its global credibility. Growth remains relatively robust. Inflation, while significant, has been managed without systemic disruption. The financial sector is far healthier than in previous cycles. Fiscal consolidation, though gradual, has not been abandoned.

This relative stability is not accidental. Over the past several years, the government has helped anchor a policy framework that places increasing emphasis on macroeconomic discipline, institutional continuity, and buffer-building. The clean-up of bank balance sheets, the push towards infrastructure-led growth, the measured approach to fiscal management, and the broader focus on structural reform have collectively strengthened India’s economic foundations.

Equally important has been a degree of policy calibration-avoiding both excessive stimulus and premature tightening, even amid significant external shocks. This has created what may be described as a “stability dividend.” In a world where investors and firms are increasingly sensitive to risk, India is seen not just as a high-growth market, but as a relatively predictable one. That perception is a strategic asset.

The Next Test: Knowing When to Step Back

But the very success of this approach creates its own challenge.

The temptation, after a period of relative resilience, is to do more-to extend support, broaden intervention, and accelerate state involvement in the economy. That temptation must be resisted. The next phase of India’s economic management will require discipline rather than expansion. Fiscal prudence must remain intact despite competing demands. Industrial policy must remain targeted, time-bound, and performance-linked. Financial sector vigilance must not weaken simply because immediate stress has receded. Policymaking must therefore adapt.

The objective must no longer be to “bridge” temporary disruptions, but to operate effectively in a state of continuous uncertainty. This requires a governing philosophy rooted in calibration, restraint, and forward-looking risk management. Importantly, policymakers must internalise a difficult but critical principle: not every risk requires intervention, and not every slowdown requires stimulus. Exit strategies are inherently unpopular. Withdrawing support after it has been extended, normalising policy after prolonged accommodation, and allowing markets to adjust can create short-term discomfort. But these are precisely the decisions that preserve long-term credibility. India has demonstrated that it can manage crises with competence. The next test is whether it can exit from periods of extraordinary support with equal skill. Because in an era defined by continuous disruption, success will not belong to those who intervene the most. It will belong to those who know when and how to stop.



Beyond cover and counts: India’s forests need better metrics

BHASKAR SINHA, JIGYASA BISARIA and AAHELI CHAKI

While the recent move to open up forest plantations to private participation has triggered debate, it also offers a timely opportunity to revisit a more fundamental concern: how India understands, measures and manages its forests. India’s improving global forest rankings are often cited as evidence of policy commitment and administrative success. With more than one-fifth of its geographical area under forest cover and an ambitious national target of one-third, the country appears to be on a steady trajectory. Yet, beneath this narrative lies a more complex reality. The central question is not whether forest cover is increasing, but whether India is adequately capturing the full value and sustainability of its forests. Forests in India are no longer just ecological assets. They are central to economic growth, social well-being, and climate commitments. They provide a wide range of ecosystem services, from carbon sequestration and biodiversity conservation to water regulation and climate resilience. At the same time, they sustain millions of livelihoods. Forest-dependent communities derive a significant share of their income from these resources, making forests integral to both environmental and developmental goals. Given this multi-dimensional role, the need to monitor and report forest sustainability across eco-

logical, social and economic dimensions becomes critical. However, India’s current frameworks remain disproportionately focused on ecological indicators. While these are essential, they offer only a partial picture. The country relies primarily on two institutional mechanisms for monitoring and reporting forest resources. The Forest Survey of India publishes the India State of Forest Report on a biennial basis, providing detailed assessments of forest cover, tree cover, carbon stock, biodiversity and related parameters. Alongside this, the National Working Plan Code lays down the scientific principles for forest management and guides the preparation of working plans at the divisional level. Over time, these frameworks have evolved and improved, particularly in their ecological assessments. Yet, they continue to fall short in capturing the social and economic dimensions of forests. While recent iterations have begun to acknowledge these aspects, the depth of assessment remains limited. There is a clear absence of well-defined indicators, standardised methodologies, and robust data collection systems for measuring social and economic outcomes. This gap is significant. Forests contribute not only to environmental stability but also to livelihoods, income generation, and local economies. Issues such as community participation in forest management, tenure rights, conflict resolution, and capacity building are central to sustainable forestry but are not systematically captured. Similarly, economic aspects such as the value of non-timber forest products, financial flows, cost



of forest management, and revenue generation remain underreported in national databases. The consequence is a fragmented understanding of forest sustainability. When policy discourse is driven largely by ecological metrics, there is a tendency to equate forest expansion with sustainability, without sufficient attention to quality, diversity, or socio-economic outcomes. Addressing this requires strengthening existing monitoring and reporting systems rather than replacing them. A key priority is the development of a comprehensive and standardised framework that integrates ecological, social and economic indicators. However, this transition is not without challenges. Forest departments often face constraints in terms of human resources and technical capacity. Building expertise within the system will require targeted training and capacity development ini-

tiatives. At the same time, identifying appropriate stakeholders for collecting data on social and economic indicators is essential. Effective coordination among departments and institutions will be critical to ensure consistency and reliability of data. Equally important is the need to institutionalise these processes. Incorporating modules on monitoring and reporting frameworks into the training of forest officials can help reduce inconsistencies and improve data quality over time. Standardised platforms for data collation and reporting would further enhance transparency and enable better decision-making. Encouragingly, there are emerging efforts to address these gaps. Recent research has proposed comprehensive frameworks that include a wide range of indicators across ecological, social and economic dimensions. These include measures of livelihood generation, employment patterns, occupational health and safety, and community participation, alongside economic indicators such as financial flows, value of forest-based enterprises, and cost structures of forest management. Such approaches recognise that sustainability cannot be assessed through a single lens. They also highlight the importance of capturing both quantitative and qualitative aspects of forest governance. By integrating these dimensions, it becomes possible to develop a more accurate and holistic understanding of forest resources. The idea of an indicator-based forest sustainability index merits serious consideration in this context. Other sectors such as energy, water, education and health have already adopted similar

approaches to improve governance and accountability. A comparable framework for forests could enhance transparency, support evidence-based policymaking, and enable better tracking of progress against national and global commitments. This is particularly relevant in the context of India’s climate goals. Robust monitoring and reporting systems are essential for effective carbon management and for meeting Nationally Determined Contributions under the Paris Agreement. They also play a crucial role in advancing broader sustainable development objectives, including those related to poverty reduction, gender equality and economic growth. The ongoing debate on private sector participation will continue, as it should. But it must not overshadow the larger issue. The real challenge lies in moving beyond a narrow focus on forest cover towards a more comprehensive understanding of forest sustainability. India does not lack intent or institutional frameworks. Forests must be seen not just as areas to be counted, but as systems to be understood, managed and sustained across multiple dimensions. Until that shift takes place, rising forest cover figures may offer reassurance. Whether they reflect truly sustainable and inclusive forest management is a question that remains open.

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BRAIN VERSUS AI



It is just a matter of years. Within 24-36 months, yes 2-3 years, artificial intelligence (AI) will match our brains, or human intelligence. After a similar prediction by OpenAI’s Sam Altman, who faced two personal and violent attacks recently, Ben Goertzel, the father of artificial general intelligence (AGI), or human-like AI, sets a similar timeframe. Hence, the way we work, think, believe, act, and decide will be done by either Claude or ChatGPT, or even Meta and Google AI. If the machines become like humans, it is inevitable and imperative to ask, what will the humans do? A simplistic way to answer is to swear by technology, and claim that it will relieve the pressures on humans, make them relax, and enable them to enjoy the pleasures of life. Of course, such assumptions were proved wrong in the past, as they are likely to be in the future. Past tech made humans work harder, despite the huge hike in productivity, and created more stress, problems, and disorder.

While one can discuss the social, political, philosophical, cultural, moral, and religious implications of AGI, what presses us more urgently is the economic-cum-business consequences. In one line, we are worried about jobs, incomes, savings, investments, and expenditure. In another one, what makes us nervous is the possible inability to acquire and enjoy modern assets and gadgets, and give the best to our children. In this respect, there is a bad, sorry scary, nah nightmarish scenario, according to the future sketched by Goertzel. He talks about a massive ‘job apocalypse,’ which may “render the vast majority of current professions obsolete.” This was his overall assessment in a “blunt’ podcast that talked about AGI’s economic consequences. “Once you have a human-level AGI, the vast majority of human jobs become obsolete,” the reverend guru said irreverently. The only hope is that the transition will not happen overnight but in phases. As if to calm us, he said that it would be similar to the adoption of AI. What? AI? It has already roasted and toasted us within three years since 2022.

Forget about his timeline. Maybe Goertzel has a sense of humour that we do not possess. Maybe his sense of three years is like the three millennium because that is what it possibly took humans to reach from a stage of minimal farm-based intelligence to AI. But if he is right, and we are being a bit pessimistic about it, our lives will change in 5-10 years.

First, many professionals, or the so-called skilled professions, may fall by the wayside faster than manual jobs. Forget about coders, writers, lawyers, artists, and graphics persons. Even the current AI roles will be ancient, and forgotten, like is the case with prompt engineering jobs that were crucial two years ago but not now. In effect, the ones with the basic household-related skills such as plumbing, electricians, painters, possibly teachers (which is a good sign; imagine the revival of the teachers as they were a few decades ago, or possibly not because they were still not respected enough then, as is the state now) will triumph.

One just hopes that the guru is wrong, as is Altman, and Claude, and others. Sorry, let us not include Claude, the AI which will possibly be the forefather of AGI. One further hopes that the politicians, policy-makers, and the rest, who know next-to-nothing about AI, or AGI, or even prompt engineering, are right. A recent parliamentary report in India quoted the IT ministry as maintaining that tech, or AI, will not reduce but increase jobs.

The Indian prime minister too felt that past experiences show that new tech does not take away jobs but forces humans to acquire new skills, which hikes the number of jobs. Let us hope, just to be confusing, that the guru is right in another respect that the world of AGI can imply the emergence of an ‘utopian world,’ which marks the end of the 9-to-5 (sorry, 9-to-10) grind, and leads to a better quality of life. Humans will spend more time with families, and loved ones, as “robots handle the heavy lifting.” The people will have the freedom to “pursue hobbies and creative endeavours that offer emotional fulfillment rather than just a paycheck.”

But wait, was not this the simplistic explanation we gave at the beginning of this article? More importantly, has not this been proved wrong, at least in some ways, again and again. Yes, people have more time for holidays, and spend a lot on entertainment. But this is restricted to a few sections, and even the holidays come with higher stress. Of course, different studies and different metrics can show different results. Of course, the number of jobs is up despite tech disruptions. But no one has explained the counter whether jobs would still be up minus tech. More crucially, productivity has gone up, and the world has more access to modern amenities and facilities. More nations were pulled up from the depths of poverty in the last century. Yet, hundreds of millions suffer, and remain underprivileged. Tech obviously helps the fortunate, whose population or proportion shrinks, from radio, TV, Internet, to AI. Now, on to AGI, and what not.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | MONDAY | APRIL 20, 2026



BUSINESS10

Sweetness’ gone out of chocolates

Cocoa prices. chocolate demand down; but are bullish trends ahead?

Over the past few months, cocoa prices are down, as is the demand for chocolates, and chocolate-laced candies. Despite the geopolitical trends, and trade disruptions, cocoa supplies are high, even as chocolate makers, the main users of the raw material, clock lower revenues because of the customers’ aversion for the sweets. However, drought conditions in major producer nations like Ghana and Ivory Coast, as well as the winding down of short positions may curtail cocoa supplies, and boost prices in the future. But only if chocolate demand picks up, and user firms are willing to hike their oftakes.

According to media reports, cocoa prices, which peaked at \$12,000 per tonne by the end of 2024, are down in the dumps. By early 2026, the prices of the futures had slumped to \$3,000, or a depressing fall by 75 per cent. One of the reports explains that “it would be easy to frame the episode as (a typical) boom and bust. But that misses what has changed underneath.” Suddenly, within a year or so, supplies recovered, even as demand by the chocolate makers faltered. The prices, which expanded due to demand and supply conditions, were now squeezed.

Industry figures indicate that the sales of cocoa grindings in the first quarter of this calendar year (2026) fell by nearly four per cent in North America, and the decline in Europe was nearly eight per cent, or higher than the expected six per cent. Asia offered some form of a relief, where the first quarter’s demand boomed by more than five per cent, amidst a prediction of a nearly seven per cent decline. However, in volume terms, Asia’s quarterly demand of over 2,00,000 tonnes was nearly half of the combined

America-Europe sales of over 4,00,000 tonnes.

One of the reasons for the overall reduced offtake was the bearish demand for chocolates. In the 13 weeks ending March 22, 2026, the sales of chocolate candy in North America were down by more than one per cent. During the past Easter holiday, when candy sales boom, the consumption was down by an unexpected five per cent. Easter came in early April this year, and bang in the middle of the ongoing Iran war. Higher prices of goods, apart from inflation expectations, may have curtailed the festive excitement. But the downturn was an ongoing one.

Thanks to the high prices in 2024, and 2025, chocolate makers hiked prices, and looked for alternatives to cocoa. This forced the consumers to go slow on the candy-eating habits. The trends continued, even as cocoa prices slumped. Despite the fall in cocoa prices, Barry Callebaut, a leading chocolate maker, warned that its “recurring operating profit” for the year ending August 2026 would decline by a “figure in the mid-teens percentage range.” Its shares plunged by 16 per cent on the day of the announcement, but remained 44 per cent higher than a year ago.

According to a last year’s report by JP Morgan, “The global chocolate market has seen a decline in volumes as prices increase, with private labels gaining market share among price-sensitive consumers, while the premium segment continues to expand. Some of the volume weakness for some players was attributable to temporary factors, but we also see this as reflective of higher elastic pressures in the chocolate market that may build with still higher pricing in the second

half of the year.” It added that the chocolate industry was set to hike prices by the teens this year and, hence, volumes will remain pressured.

On the cocoa supply side, there are several factors that impacted the prices over the past few months. Based on the high prices, grower nations like Ivory Coast upped the supplies. Nigeria, the fifth-largest cocoa producer, exported huge quantities, and its overseas supplies grew by 17 per cent in 2025.

In March, the global cocoa surplus estimates were hiked by nearly 50 per cent to 75,000 tonnes, up from 49,000 tonnes in November 2025, “which was the first surplus in four years.” Overall production grew by more than eight per cent, and neared five million tonnes. The surplus may continue.

Although one is not sure of how speculation, and futures trading will impact the cocoa prices, there are no doubts that the existing short positions will play a vital role. As cocoa prices continue to fall rapidly, several funds boosted their short positions in expectations of even-lower prices. In the week ending April 7, 2026, the short positions were the highest in the past three years. If cocoa prices fall, the positions will increase. But if prices recover, the unwinding may give a further boost. In both cases, the trends will accelerate, and deepen.

However, the chances of a recovery in cocoa prices and, hence, the impact on the short positions, will be decided by the future produce. According to media reports, “Recent rainfall in West Africa has been insufficient to ease drought concerns in the Ivory Coast and Ghana.” An agency reported that they “blanket more than half of the Ivory Coast, and about two-thirds of Ghana.” Together, the two nations account for more than half of the world’s cocoa. Ivory Coast’s production is likely to fall by nearly 11 per cent in 2025-26 and, in February 2026, Rabobank cut the nation’s surplus estimate by almost a quarter.

Both Ghana and Ivory Coast have decided to cut the official price they pay to the cocoa farmers despite the drought situation, lower production in the future, and the chances of global price recovery. Reports indicate that Ghana cut the official price by nearly 30 per cent last month, for supplies for the 2025-26 growing season. Ivory Coast may resort to a higher cut, almost 60 per cent, for the mid-crop harvest that started in April 2026. Obviously, the price cuts to farmers are goaded by the 75 per cent drop in global prices over the past few months.

In addition to the farm-related implications, as well as the sales of chocolates, the Iran-Israel-US war will play a major, though temporary, role. If the Strait of Hormuz remains open, supplies will enhance, and depress cocoa prices. If the choke point remains choked, as Iran threatens more disruptions, it will have an opposite effect. The grower nations, chocolate makers, traders, and speculators will need to deal with the fast-changing scenario. The worst hit may be the farmers, whose incomes will dip in the midst of a drought.

OUR TAKE



Personal-Finance Medicine

Arrest in cardiac-related claims

With young people prone to heart issues, insurance premiums are up



though not on the regular terms. Most policies will include restrictions mentioned above. In extreme cases, insurers may decline the coverage altogether or offer a reduced sum insured, which will invariably involve out-of-pocket expenses. This makes it crucial to secure insurance early, preferably before any diagnosis, when premiums are lower, and coverage is broader.

For those who are already diagnosed with cardiac problems, or face difficulty in obtaining regular and normal insurance, specialised policies can serve as a useful supplement. These heart-related policies are particularly relevant for individuals with a history of coronary artery disease, angioplasty, or bypass surgery. Such policies are of two types.

First, the indemnity-based plans that reimburse hospitalisation expenses. Second, the fixed-benefit or critical illness plans that provide a lump sum payout upon diagnosis or surgery. Both tend to cover major procedures such as angioplasty, bypass surgery, ICU hospitalisation, and limited pre- and post-hospitalisation expenses.

However, they come with exclusions, which include waiting periods for the pre-existing conditions, and limited coverage for the non-cardiac complications or long-term medication. Hence, one cannot rely solely on these special policies. At best, they can be used as add-ons rather than a replacement for a normal, comprehensive health insurance. As mentioned earlier, one of the biggest problems with cardiac-focused insurance is the cost.

Premiums for those with heart conditions are invariably higher than the standard policies. In addition, thanks to co-pay clauses, sub-limits, and non-payable items in the policies and claims, out-of-pocket expenses are expected to increase.

Even policies that seem affordable initially may include hidden restrictions such as caps on specific treatments or limits on room rent, which can significantly reduce the claim payouts. Several patients face this issue at the time of the claims, as they fail to read the fine print, or are unaware of the restrictions. In many cases,

despite a high coverage, and hiked premiums, the claim payouts may be as low as 50-60 per cent. Thus, what may seem to be a high coverage may turn out to be inadequate, which leaves the policyholders financially exposed.

Choosing the right policy is crucial, and requires a careful evaluation of several factors. For example, as stated above, the sum insured should be sufficient to cover high treatment costs, especially if one prefers tertiary care hospitals, and surgery by senior and reputed heart specialists, and want adequate coverage despite the low claim payouts. The sum insured cannot be correlated with objective factors like the cost of surgery, but needs to be collated with the possibility of higher-than-estimated costs, coupled with lower payouts by the insurers. Room rent limits are a critical aspect, as they influence the claim amount. Buyers should review the waiting periods for the pre-existing conditions, co-payment clauses, and sub-limits on procedures like angioplasty or bypass surgery. Policies that offer regular annual health check-ups, and wellness benefits are useful for early detection and ongoing management.

For those with existing conditions, full and honest disclosure of the medical history is essential at the time of the purchase of a policy. Any non-disclosure can lead to a rejection of the claim later, and defeat the purpose of insurance. The maintenance of proper medical records, adherence to prescribed treatments, and opting for higher coverage can provide better financial protection.

Heart disease is no longer a late-life concern, and it does not merely afflict those who are 50 years and above. Younger people, in their mid-thirties and forties are facing these problems. It is becoming a financial risk for the youngsters. This shift underscores the importance of planning ahead.

A combination of a comprehensive base policy, coupled with a specialised cover offers better protection. At the same time, one needs to understand that insurance cover is not enough. Preventive measures, regular screenings, and lifestyles are equally important. In a landscape where risks are rising, and costs escalating, informed choices remain the most effective tools to safeguard health and finances.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

Relearning Agroecology from India’s Living Traditions

Ancient Indian agrarian knowledge recognised that soil fertility, crop resilience and food security arise from diversity, not monoculture. Agricultural land was treated as a living ecological system sustained through crop rotation, mixed cultivation, and attentive stewardship. This ecological orientation was not abstract philosophy; it was codified in classical texts and embedded in archaeological and lived agrarian practices across regions.

Textual and Archaeological Roots

The Krishi Parashara (c. 400 BCE) presents agriculture as seasonally calibrated and soil-conscious, advocating crop rotation and mixed cultivation based on rainfall and lunar cycles. This ecological orientation is elaborated in Vrikshayurveda (c. 1000 CE), Surapala, classified soils and described organic nutrient formulations such as Kunapajala, a fermented mixture of plant and animal matter, indicating an early understanding of circular fertilisation and soil management. The Arthashastra (c. 300 BCE) formalised agriculture; the Sita Adhyaksha (superintendent of agriculture) was tasked with seed preservation, irrigation oversight, manure regulation and seasonal planning. Sangam literature (c. 300 BCE) reflects region-specific agroecology in ancient Tamilakam through its classification of five ecological landscapes: Kurinji (mountain), Mullai (forest), Marutham (wet plains), Neithal (coastal), and Palai (arid). Each zone was associated with distinct crops, water systems, and livelihoods adapted to terrain and rainfall.

Similarly, epic literature reinforces these concerns. In the Sabha Parva of the Mahabharata, the sage Narada asks King Yudhishtira whether farmers remain dependent solely on rainfall, a condition termed Adevamatraka. This query implies the ruler's duty to construct tanks and canals, framing water as a shared trust. The Aranya Kanda of the Ramayana depicts forest hermitages where fruit-bearing trees, cultivated fields, and groves coexist, reflecting early agroforestry principles.

Moreover, archaeological evidence further grounds the agrarian knowledge. The Indus Valley regions of Harappa and Mohenjodaro demonstrate grain storage, irrigation management and diversified cropping patterns, including barley, pulses, sesame and millets. Early rice cultivation in the middle Ganga plains at Lahuradewa suggests experimentation with regionally suited crops, while Neolithic sites in peninsular India, such as Brahmagiri and the ash-mound complexes of Karnataka, point to millet-based agro-pastoral systems adapted to semi-arid ecologies. All these indicate regionally adapted agricultural experimentation across ecological zones since antiquity.



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Landscapes as Laboratories

India's geography spans diverse climates, from Himalayan glaciers to tropical coasts and arid deserts. Each ecological zone generated distinct agricultural knowledge systems shaped by centuries of observation and experimentation.

In the Himalayan belt, terrace farming stabilised fragile slopes and reduced erosion. Ladakh's Zing irrigation system stored and gradually released glacial meltwater, conserving topsoil and supporting nutrient cycling during short growing seasons. Crop selection prioritised frost resistance and early maturity. In coastal Kerala, the saline-tolerant Pokkali rice system combined rice with prawn and fish cultivation, restoring soil fertility through tidal nutrient exchange and aquatic biomass. Agricultural calendars tracked rainfall rhythms and seasonal winds with notable precision rooted in lived experience. In the north-eastern hills, Jhum cultivation functioned as rotational agroecology. Land was briefly cultivated, then left fallow for forest regeneration and nutrient renewal. Mixed cropping and community labour suited fragile terrains. In western India, Rajasthan's Khadin system captured monsoon runoff through earthen embankments, depositing nutrient-rich sediments onto fields even under minimal rainfall. Sacred pastures such as Oran and Gochar sustained livestock-based nutrient cycles while preventing desertification. Together, these practices reflected a cultivation ethos aligned with ecological limits.

Why Traditional Agroecological Wisdom Matters Today

India has not been institutionally passive. The Soil Health Card Scheme, nutrient-based fertiliser subsidy reforms, the Paramparagat Krishi Vikas Yojana, the National Mission on Natural Farming, and the Indian Council of Agricultural Research's (ICAR) 'National Innovations in Climate Resilient Agriculture' reflect policy awareness of ecological risk. Yet, ecological pressures persist. ICAR estimates that nearly 30% of India's land is degraded. Soil Health Card data indicate widespread soil organic carbon deficiencies. NITI Aayog's Composite Water Management Index (2018) highlights severe groundwater depletion across agrarian regions. The policy architecture exists; it is now time to place ecological resilience at the centre of agricultural performance.

Way Forward

A systematic pan-Indian repository of Indigenous agroecological knowledge is now essential. Much of this knowledge survives in fragments preserved in community memory, manuscripts and local practices, yet remains unsystematically documented. A national repository could document farming methods alongside ecological parameters such as soil type, rainfall and irrigation systems, linking historical insight with contemporary needs. To move beyond mere documentation, it must be structured around clear institutional and intellectual priorities.

First, traditional agroecological practices must be documented in context, grounded in diverse geography, seasonal cycles and environmental conditions. Second, interdisciplinary collaboration among agronomists, ecologists, historians and farmers to evaluate how traditional practices perform under climatic stress. Third, agricultural and environmental curricula should recognise indigenous knowledge as part of India's scientific tradition. Fourth, digital platforms can connect this repository with advisories, enabling tradition and technology to reinforce one another.

Finally, the repository must inform practical ecological interventions. Indian soils are experiencing declining soil organic carbon and humus levels, while substantial volumes of organic waste remain underutilised. Treating biomass and organic waste as resources can restore fertility while reducing dependence on synthetic inputs. Integrating composting, biomass recycling and traditional organic formulations into soil management policy would strengthen long-term ecological resilience.

The aim is not to return to pre-modern agriculture but to broaden what counts as knowledge. In an era of ecological uncertainty, sustainability depends on reinterpreting inherited wisdom that understood land as a living system to be sustained with care and continuity.

Fable with Moral

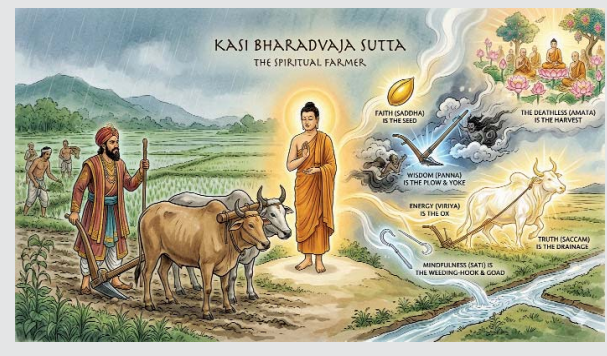
The Kasi Bharadvaja Sutta (Discourse to Bharadvaja, the farmer)

The Pali Canon, Sutta Nipata 1.4

The Kasi Bharadvaja Sutta is a well known narrative from the Pali Canon that beautifully illustrates the Buddha's ability to use analogies to bridge the gap between worldly activities and spiritual practice. Once upon a time, a wealthy brahmin farmer named Kasi Bharadvaja was preparing his fields using 500 plows in Magadha. When the Buddha approached him for alms, the brahmin, seeing the Buddha's serene but seemingly 'unproductive' lifestyle, remarked:

"I, ascetic, plow and sow; and having plowed and sowed, I eat. You, too, ascetic, should plow and sow; and having plowed and sowed, you shall eat."

The Buddha responded by claiming that he, too, was a farmer who plowed and sowed. Confused by the lack of actual farming tools, the brahmin asked for evidence of the Buddha's 'farming.' The Buddha then delivered a brilliant metaphor involving the agricultural process. He stated, "faith is my seed, austerity the rain, wisdom my yoke and plow, modesty is the pole, mind the strap, mindfulness is my ploughshare and effort is my beast of burden."



The Buddha explained that his "plowing" targeted the weeds of suffering resulting in enlightenment. This kind of farming released one from all sorrow. Deeply moved by the depth of the teaching, Kasi Bharadvaja offered the Buddha a golden bowl of milk rice. The Buddha however declined the food, stating that it was not the practice of enlightened ones to accept what one received for chanting verses.

Moral of the Fable

This story validates agriculture by using it as the key metaphor for spiritual growth. By comparing enlightenment to a successful harvest, the Buddha honoured the farmer's labour as the most relatable and essential human activity. It suggests that if we do not "sow" (work), we cannot "reap" (eat or find peace).

Wisdom Word Search

S	G	K	S	H	E	T	R	A	L	K	B
G	W	I	X	L	Y	O	J	A	V	A	I
A	L	Q	T	M	I	P	K	Q	R	N	J
Y	P	K	R	I	S	H	I	J	I	K	A
O	A	J	V	P	A	P	W	L	H	X	V
H	I	V	T	L	S	A	Q	P	I	O	R
L	C	T	A	E	Y	J	G	A	O	T	L
A	Y	M	N	T	A	A	A	S	K	L	S
T	O	A	Q	P	I	Y	H	L	M	Q	E
D	H	A	N	Y	A	S	L	K	A	D	T
I	K	G	P	M	F	N	A	I	S	Z	U
A	N	N	A	P	O	S	H	A	N	A	W

WORDS TO FIND

Annaposhana, Bija, Dhanya, Jala, Kshetra, Krishi, Sasya, Setu, Vrihi, Yava

ANNAPOSHANA - From anna (food) + poshana (nourishment): sustenance and nutritional well-being through food.

BIJA - The seed as the origin of life, central to regeneration and agricultural continuity.

DHANYA - Food grains symbolising prosperity, sustenance, and food security.

JALA - Water as the essential resource enabling cultivation and crop survival.

KSHETRA - Cultivated land representing the productive base of agrarian economy.

KRISHI - From krish (to cultivate): the act of farming as a foundational human activity.

SASYA - Growing crops reflecting agricultural cycles and seasonal rhythms.

SETU - Irrigation and water management structures supporting sustainable farming.

VRIHI - Rice, one of the oldest and most important staple crops in India.

YAVA - Barley, an ancient grain associated with resilience and early agriculture.

Marvels of India

GHATIYANTRA

A Marvel of Indian Mechanical Ingenuity
The Ghatiyatra exemplifies Bharat's advanced understanding of hydraulics and mechanical aids in early Indian agricultural society, showcasing a practical, science based approach to water management.

Monolithic Engineering Feat
The term denotes a "pot machine" or water lifting device, usually a wheel or pulley system with attached pots that draw water from wells or tanks and pour it into channels. In Banabhatta's literary composition - the Harshacharita (seventh century CE) - the image of fields being watered by Ghatiyatra pots indicates a relatively organised, field scale irrigation apparatus, not just a simple rope and bucket.

Architectural and Artistic Excellence
Its design reflects efficient rotational mechanics and load balancing, anticipating later forms such as the Ara ghatta (Persian wheel). The rhythmic, repetitive motion of the device became a poetic symbol of sustained, ordered cultivation in early literary imagination.

Civilisational Significance
By enabling reliable irrigation, the Ghatiyatra supported food production, agrarian stability and the growth of settlements and institutions. It stands as a micro marvel of Indian technological culture, linking empirical innovation with literary and philosophical reflection on Yantra and Yukti in the service of society.

QUIZ Agriculture & Food Security

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1 Which of them is a traditional organic formulation made from cow products that helps in enhancing soil health as well as plant growth by promoting beneficial microorganisms, as per the ancient Indian texts?	Sunai	Agniastra	Kunapajala	Panchagavya
2 Which is the ancient Indian text that offers holistic methods for plant health, including soil management, seed treatment, irrigation, and plant disease treatment with natural remedies inspired by Ayurveda?	Atharvaveda	Arthashastra	Vriksh-Ayurveda	Krishi-Parashara
3 Which one of the following is a nutritious as well as heat-tolerant crop, having evidences of being grown even during the Indus Valley Civilization?	Rice	Ragi	Wheat	Sugarcane
4 Which is the traditional interconnected earthen tank system used in Tamil Nadu for rainwater harvesting and irrigation?	Cheruvu	Phad	Kere	Eri
5 Which of these sites is likely to be the earliest with evidence of agriculture in India?	Chirand	Madurai	Daimabad	Uraiyur

Answers: 1 - D, 2 - C, 3 - B, 4 - D, 5 - A

panchatantra

Belling the Cat

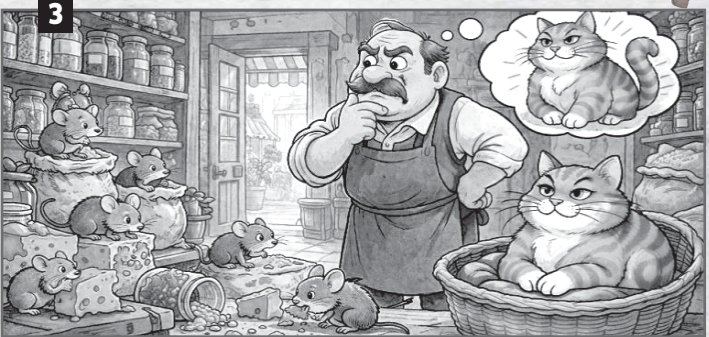


1



2

Once there was a shop which was full of mice. The mice nibbled at all the things in the shop. Everything went to waste because of the mice.



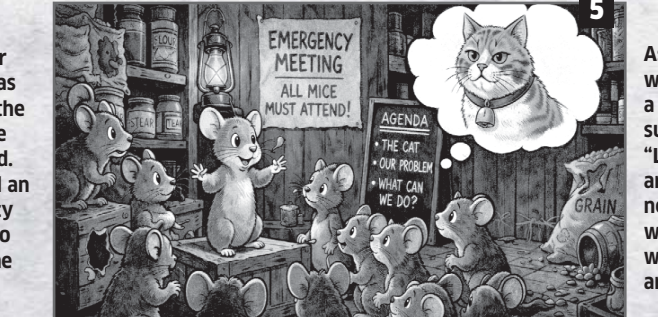
3

Finally the grocer was fed up with the menace and decided to bring in a big fat cat.



4

Soon after the cat was brought, the mice were frightened. They held an emergency meeting to discuss the issue.



5

As the meeting was in progress, a young mouse suggested, "Let us tie a bell around the cat's neck so that we would know when the cat arrives."



6

The mice rejoiced as they thought it was a good idea. Just then, an old wise mouse stood up and asked, "But who will bell the cat?" Suddenly all the mice fell silent.

MORAL OF THE STORY:
It is easy to propose impossible ideas.

FROM THE

WORLD

LEBANON

Hezbollah rejects US plan

Naim Kassem, head of the Iran-backed Lebanese militant group Hezbollah, in a statement read on the group's al-Manar TV said a paper published by the US State Department that it described as the text of a ceasefire agreement between Lebanon and Israel "means nothing at the practical level, but it is an insult to our country". "Everyone knows that the Government of Lebanon has not met or approved this statement," he said. The text published by the US described the 10-day truce as a gesture by Israel "to enable good-faith negotiations" toward a permanent peace agreement with Lebanon. The text gives Israel the "right to take all necessary measures in self-defence, at any time, against planned, imminent, or ongoing attacks".

UK

Queen Elizabeth II charity starts

The UK Government is marking the birth centenary of the late Queen Elizabeth II this month with a new independent charity that will honour her lifelong commitment to public service by focusing on bringing communities together across the country. The Queen Elizabeth Trust will be formally launched on Tuesday, which would have been the British monarch's hundredth birthday, with a one-off Government endowment of 40 million pounds as a catalyst for future fundraising. King Charles III will be instrumental in bringing his mother's values to life for present and future generations as the Royal Patron of the charity, the Cabinet Office said. "This is a real chance to support communities across the United Kingdom and bring shared spaces back to life: places where people of all ages and backgrounds can meet, connect, and belong," said Sir Damon Buffini, founding-chair of the Queen Elizabeth Trust.

Iran reverses Hormuz move, keeps strait closed over US blockade

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Iran reversed its decision to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and warned that it would continue to block transit through the strait as long as the US blockade of Iranian ports remained in effect. The escalating standoff over the critical choke point threatened to deepen the energy crisis roiling the global economy and push the two countries toward renewed conflict, even as mediators expressed confidence that a new deal was within reach. The strait is closed until the US blockade is lifted, Iran's Revolutionary Guard navy said Saturday night. Hours earlier, two gunboats from Iran's Revolutionary Guard

opened fire on a tanker transiting the Strait of Hormuz, the British military's United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre said. It reported that the tanker and crew were safe, without identifying the vessel or its destination. Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil passes through the strait, and further limits would squeeze the already constrained supply, driving prices higher once again. Meanwhile, a 10-day truce between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon appeared to be holding. The fighting in the Middle East conflict, which is approaching the two-month mark, has killed at least 3,000



people in Iran, nearly 2,300 in Lebanon, 23 civilians and 15 soldiers in Israel, and more than a dozen in Gulf Arab states. Thirteen US service members have also been killed. Israel says it killed a Hezbollah commander just before the ceasefire. The Israeli army says it carried out a series of strikes that killed more than 150 Hezbollah fighters. Among those killed was Ali Rida Abbas, who it said was Hezbollah's commander in Bint Jbeil. The southern Lebanese town and its surroundings were the site of intense clashes between

Israeli troops and Hezbollah militants in the days leading up to the ceasefire. Israel gave no evidence to support its claims, and Hezbollah didn't immediately confirm the death of its commander. The ceasefire took effect early Friday. Iran's chief negotiator says his country wants "a lasting peace so that war is not repeated again." Parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf made the comments in a televised interview late Saturday, a few days before a ceasefire deadline is set to expire, according to Iranian State media. "What is fundamental for us is distrust of the United States," he said. "At the same

time, we have good intentions and seek a lasting peace - one that prevents the recurrence of war." He said that the Islamabad negotiations didn't address the mistrust, but that the US and Iranian negotiators "reached a more realistic understanding of one another." He said that the two sides achieved progress in the Islamabad talks, but disagreement remained on some key issues, including the nuclear program and the Strait of Hormuz. "The gaps remain wide, and some fundamental issues are still unresolved," he said. He didn't elaborate with further details. The Lebanese army said in a statement Sunday that it reopened the

Khaddali road that links the southern city of Nabatiyeh with the town of Marjayoun. The army said that it also reopened the road that links the port city of Tyre with the village of Bourj Rahhal. The army is also working on reopening other roads, including a bridge on the Litani River in the village of Tayr Filsay. During Israel's invasion of southern Lebanon over the past several weeks, Israel's air force has destroyed several bridges on the river. After a 10-day ceasefire was declared as of midnight Thursday, the Lebanese army and the Litani Authority have been working on putting up temporary bridges to replace the destroyed ones.

Pope Leo XIV urges Angola to end cycle of exploitation in Africa

NICOLE WINFIELD-GERALD IMRAY ■ Luanda (Angola)

Pope Leo XIV challenged Angola's leaders to break the "cycle of interests" that have plundered and exploited Africa for centuries as he arrived in the southern African country on Saturday with a message of encouragement for its long-suffering people. Leo's arrival in Angola, the oil-and-mineral rich former Portuguese colony, marked the third leg of his four-nation African voyage. En route from Cameroon, he spoke again of the ongoing back-and-forth with US President Donald Trump over the Iran war. Leo, history's first US-born

pope, said that it was "not in my interest at all" to debate Trump, but that he would continue preaching the Gospel message of peace, justice and brotherhood in Africa. US Vice President J D Vance later wrote on social media that "I am grateful to Pope Leo for saying this." Vance, a Catholic convert, suggested earlier in the week that Leo "be careful" when speaking about theology. In Angola, Leo met with President Joao Lourenco and delivered his first speech to Angolan Government authorities, in which he referred repeatedly to Angola's tortured history of colonial plunder and civil war.



"I desire to meet you in the spirit born of peace and to affirm that your people possess treasures that cannot be bought or stolen," he said. "There dwells within you a joy that not even the most

adverse circumstances have been able to extinguish." A long-suffering people Angola, which has a population of around 38 million, gained independence from Portugal in 1975. But it still bears the scars of a devastating civil war that began straight after independence and raged on and off for 27 years before finally ending in 2002. More than a half-million people are believed to have been killed. For years, the civil war was a Cold War proxy conflict, with the United States and apartheid South Africa backing one side and the Soviet Union and Cuba backing the other. Angola is now the fourth-largest oil producer in Africa and among the world's top 20 producers, according to the International Energy Agency. The country is also the world's No 3 diamond producer and has significant deposits of gold and highly sought after critical minerals. (AP)

'Maximalist' demands of US stall face-to-face talks: Iranian official

SUZAN FRASER ■ Antalya (Turkiye)

Iran is not yet ready to hold a new round of face-to-face talks with US officials, a senior Iranian official said Saturday, citing Washington's refusal to abandon "maximalist" demands on key issues. In an interview with *The Associated Press* on the margins of a diplomacy forum in Turkiye, Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Saeed Khatibzadeh also said his country will not hand over its enriched uranium to the United States, rejecting claims made by US President Donald Trump. "I can tell you that no enriched material is going to be shipped to the United



States," Khatibzadeh said. "This is a non-starter, and I can assure you that while we are ready to address any concerns that we do have, we're not going to accept things that are nonstarters." On Friday, Trump said that

Khatibzadeh said there have been many exchanges of messages between the sides, but accused the United States of holding firm on demands Iran deems to be excessive. "We are still not there yet to move on to an actual meeting because there are issues that the Americans have not yet abandoned their maximalist position," Khatibzadeh said. Iran was seeking the finalisation of a "framework agreement" before moving to an in-person meeting, he added. The Iranian official would not go into specifics of the negotiations with the United States or say which issues remain unresolved, but called on Washington to

address Iran's concerns, including sanctions imposed on Iran. "The other sides also should understand and address our main concerns, which are illegal unilateral sanctions that Americans have imposed on Iranians and this economic terrorism which has targeted Iranian people to suffocate them and make them revolt against the political structure inside Iran," Khatibzadeh said. Asked whether Iran would respond to renewed attacks by Israel on Lebanon despite the ceasefire, Khatibzadeh said: "Iran has no option, just to stop aggressors once and forever." (AP)

Humanoid robot in China breaks human world record for half-marathon

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

A Humanoid robot made by a Chinese company on Sunday broke the human world record with a timing of 50 minutes 26 seconds in a race alongside amateur runners here on Sunday. 'Flash,' the Humanoid robot made by China's Shenzhen Honor Smart Technology Development Co, Ltd, claimed victory at the 2026 Beijing E-Town half-marathon in autonomous navigation, beating the human world record of 57:20, official media here reported. The men's half-marathon world record was created by Uganda's star distance runner Jacob Kiplimo at the



Lisbon Half Marathon in Portugal last month. Over 100 teams from China, Germany, France and Brazil took part in the race along with human runners. In terms of competition rules, robots and human runners followed the same route of 21-kms but separate lanes to ensure safety, and the robot's cutoff time was set at three hours and 40 minutes, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. The newly added format

this year includes two ways of participation — remote control and autonomous navigation. For teams in remote control, their finishing times need to be multiplied by a coefficient of 1.2. About 40 per cent of the teams adopted autonomous navigation to achieve better results. "The setting of coefficients aims to guide and encourage the research and development of autonomous navigation, which represents a technological foundation for humanoid robots to be applied in more scenarios in our daily life towards the future," Liang Liang, deputy secretary-general of the Chinese Institute of Electronics said. (PTI)

Bulgarians head to polls to elect parliament for 8th time in 5 years

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Sofia

Bulgarians are heading to the polls on Sunday for the eighth time in five years, hoping to finally elect a parliament able to resolve the longtime political impasse that has gripped this Balkan country. The snap vote follows the resignation of a conservative-led Government amid nationwide protests last December that drew hundreds of thousands, mainly young people, to the streets. The protesters called for an independent judiciary to tackle widespread corruption. Since 2021, the nation of 6.5 million has struggled with fragmented parliaments that produced weak Governments, none of which managed to survive more



than a year before being brought down by street protests or backroom deals in parliament. The revolving door of Governments has fostered widespread public mistrust, voter apathy and a shrinking turnout in elections. Still, Sunday's vote is significant as it could bring to

power a left-leaning, pro-Russian former president - just days after Hungarian voters rejected the authoritarian policies and global far-right movement of Viktor Orban, who cultivated close ties with Russian President Vladimir Putin. The front-runner, Bulgaria's former President Rumen Radev, is

leading a newly formed, centre-left Progressive Bulgaria coalition. He resigned from the mostly ceremonial presidency in January, a few months before the end of his second term, to launch a bid to lead the Government as prime minister. The 62-year-old former fighter pilot and air force commander is seen as Bulgaria's most popular politician and has promised to give the nation a fresh start. His supporters are split on those hoping he will put an end to the country's oligarchic corruption and those lining up behind his Eurosceptic and pro-Russian views. Polling stations opened at 7 am, and are to close at 8 pm, after which initial exit polls will be announced.

While Trump lashes out at Spain, US Democrats join a progressive rally in Barcelona

JOSEPH WILSON ■ Barcelona

Progressive leaders from around the globe gathered in Barcelona on Saturday to try and galvanise their forces and defend the multilateral rules-based order in a world turning to the right and violently torn by superpowers. Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez, an outspoken critic of US President Donald Trump and the US-Israeli war against Iran, hosted two overlapping events about democracy and progressive politics in Spain's second largest city. Democrats US Sen Chris Murphy and Minnesota Gov Tim Walz were both present

alongside the leaders of Brazil, South Africa and high-ranking officials from other left-leaning Governments. While no foreign leader criticised Trump by name in public, the staunchly unilateral position of the American president that breaks with decades of US foreign policy, including his derision of NATO and the United Nations, hung over the meetings. "We all see the attacks against the multilateral system, the repeated attempts to undermine international law and the dangerous normalisation of the use of force," Sanchez said. Trump again lashed out on



Saturday on social media at Sanchez, who has faced Trump's scorn for not allowing the US to use jointly operated military bases in Spain for operations related to the Iran war and for refusing to raise military spending from 2 per cent to 5 per cent of GDP. "Has anybody looked at how badly the country of

Spain is doing. Their financial numbers, despite contributing almost nothing to NATO and their military defense, are absolutely horrendous. Sad to watch!!!!" Trump posted on Truth Social. Sanchez says the right's time is running out Spain, like the US and other developed countries, is in debt, but it has one of the world's leading economies under Sanchez. Sanchez told the rally of progressive politicians and party members held later on Saturday that the populist right "screams and shouts not because they are winning but because they know their time is running out. "They know their vision of

how the world should be ordered is falling apart due to the tariffs and wars. Their embrace of climate change denial, of xenophobia, or sexism is their greatest error," he said. "They have tried again and again to make us embarrassed of our beliefs. That ends now. From now on they can be the ones who feel ashamed," Sanchez added. Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Colombian President Gustavo Petro, and other leaders and officials, including Cabinet members from

the United Kingdom and Germany, were in attendance at the IV Meeting in Defence of Democracy that kicked off Saturday's double-header of political events at the Barcelona convention centre. Later in the day, Sanchez, Lula and Ramaphosa stayed put to attend the inaugural Global Progressive Mobilisation, where some 6,000 left-leaning elected officials, policy analysts and activists exchanged ideas. "The far right is international, so we must be too," German Vice Chancellor and Finance Minister Lars Klingbeil told a crowd of activists. (AP)

Pak steps up security ahead of second round of US-Iran talks



SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan has stepped up security in and around the national capital, as US President Donald Trump on Sunday announced that American negotiators will be there on Monday for peace talks with Iran. The US and Iran held rare direct talks in Pakistan on April 11 and 12 in Islamabad aimed at ending their conflict, but the talks concluded without any agreement. In his Truth Social post on Sunday, Trump said that American negotiators will be in Pakistan on Monday for talks with Iran. It was not immediately clear whether the American negotiating team will be led by Vice President JD Vance, who was in Islamabad for the first round of talks. "Jared Kushner and Steve Witkoff are heading to the Middle East," Trump told Fox News. Special Envoy Witkoff and Kushner, Trump's son-in-law, had accompanied Vance during the first round of talks. Even before Trump's announcement, the administration of Islamabad and Rawalpindi indicated the arrival of foreign delegates for talks. "Due to the arrival of foreign delegations in Islamabad, Red Zone and Extended Red Zone will remain completely closed for all kinds of traffic," Islamabad police said on its official X account. "Citizens are advised to use alternate routes and cooperate with traffic police to ensure smooth flow and security," it said. Earlier, a police spokesperson said more than 10,000 police personnel have been deployed and over 600 checkpoints have been established across Rawalpindi, the sprawling city adjacent to Islamabad, the Express Tribune newspaper reported. The security protocol is also being implemented in the capital city. Authorities have announced that from Sunday midnight, several sensitive areas surrounding Nur Khan Airbase and Islamabad International Airport will be sealed. The Nur Khan Airbase is located in Rawalpindi while the Islamabad International Airport falls in the territorial jurisdiction of Attock district of Punjab province but the passengers have to pass through the Rawalpindi district area to reach Islamabad. (PTI)

2 INDIAN MEN SHOT DEAD IN ITALY WHILE LEAVING GURDWARA



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Rome

Two Indian men have been shot dead in Italy's Covo in Bergamo province just as they were leaving a warehouse used as a place of worship during a gathering for Vaisakhi festival, local media reported on Sunday. The attack occurred on Friday, a few minutes before midnight in the square in front of the Gurdwara Mata Sahib Kaur Ji in the industrial area of the town, according to La Sicilia newspaper. The deceased were identified as Raginder Singh, 48, a resident of Covo, and Gurmit Singh, 48, from Agnadello. The assailant allegedly approached the men, opened fire and then fled in a car, the paper reported. According to initial findings, a sudden brawl that escalated into bloodshed has been ruled out, the report said. Approximately ten shell casings were recovered from the scene as authorities investigate the hypothesis of a "coldly planned execution". A witness was quoted as telling reporters that the shooter was "an Indian" who also frequented the gurdwara.

Russian strikes kill 2 as Ukraine hits drone factory

DEREK GATOPOULOS ■ Kyiv

Russian strikes killed at least two people in Ukraine, officials said Sunday, as the Ukrainian military struck a drone factory in southwestern Russia.

A "massive" nighttime drone strike on Chernihiv in northern Ukraine killed a 16-year-old boy and wounded four others, according to the head of the city's military administration.

Rescuers found the teenager's body as they cleared away rubble, Dmytro Bryzhynskyi reported on Telegram on Sunday morning.

He said the drone strike also wounded three women and one man. Several houses were set on fire, he added.

Russian drones also attacked the southern city of Kherson on Sunday, local officials reported.

A man died of his wounds after a drone hit a van driving through the city center, according to Oleksandr Prokudin, the head of the regional administration. A second man was hospitalised with blast injuries, regional authorities said.

Russia launched 236 drones into Ukrainian territory overnight into Sunday,

Ukraine's air force reported. Of those, 203 drones were shot down while 32 hit targets in 18 separate locations, it said.

Kyiv says it struck a Russian drone factory Meanwhile, Ukraine hit a drone factory in the city of Taganrog, Ukraine's General Staff reported. The site lies some 55 kilometres (35 miles) east of Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine in southwestern Russia.

According to the military, Ukrainian drones sparked a fire at the Atlant Aero factory, which designs and produces strike and reconnaissance drones, as well as compo-



nents for more powerful UAVs that can carry guided bombs weighing up to 250 kilograms (550 pounds).

Ukraine's navy said it carried out the attack on the drone factory in southern

Russia, using domestically manufactured Neptune cruise missiles.

"This defense enterprise is an important part of the Russian military-industrial complex, where drones were

developed and manufactured," the navy said in an online post.

It also posted images showing a huge cloud of smoke over the city, which it said was the impact of the strikes. Three people were injured in a nighttime air attack on commercial infrastructure in Taganrog, according to the Russian regional governor, Yuri Slyusar. He did not specify what facility was hit, but said warehouses were set on fire following the strike. Taganrog Mayor Svetlana Kambulova said the strike damaged "commercial enterprises" in the city, as

well as a vocational school and multiple cars.

Russia's Defense Ministry said its forces shot down 274 Ukrainian drones during the night, as well as guided aerial bombs and a Neptune cruise missile. The ministry did not say how many struck targets.

Ukraine launches inquiry into mass shooting in the capital Ukraine's Interior Ministry on Sunday launched an official inquiry into a mass shooting in Kyiv the previous day that killed six people and wounded at least 14 others.

A gunman wielding an automatic weapon killed six people and barricaded himself inside

a supermarket with hostages in the Ukrainian capital before he was shot and killed by police, authorities said. Interior Minister Ihor Klymenko described the attacker's mental state as "clearly unstable."

The 58-year-old gunman has not been named, but Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Saturday said he was born in Russia. Authorities worked to piece together a motive for the violence.

Several police officers were suspended for allegedly failing to respond appropriately in the initial stages of the shooting. (AP)

VP Radhakrishnan meets Sri Lankan President Dissanayake, discusses Indian housing project

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan met Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Dissanayake here on Sunday and held discussions on various initiatives, including the Indian housing project, and fishermen issues between the two South Asian neighbours.

Radhakrishnan, who arrived here earlier in the day on a two-day visit, also discussed with Dissanayake the ongoing Indian project implementation in Sri Lanka with emphasis on the \$450 million Cyclone Ditwah aid offered by India.

Accompanied by a 49-member delegation, the vice president was received at the



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, during a meeting with leaders of Sri Lankan Tamil parties and Indian-origin Tamil groups during his visit in Colombo, Sri Lanka

PTI

Bandaranaike International Airport in Colombo by Sports Minister Sunil Kumara Gamage and several other dignitaries.

Radhakrishnan's visit is the first ever by an Indian vice president to Sri Lanka, officials said. Radhakrishnan laid emphasis on India's

'Neighbourhood First' policy and developmental bilateral cooperation, officials said.

"Both leaders held productive discussions on further deepening the multifaceted India-Sri Lanka ties, rooted in shared history, strong civilisational and people-to-people linkages," according to a social media post by Radhakrishnan.

They held wide-ranging discussions on various initiatives, including the Indian housing project and projects being implemented under the \$450 million package for areas affected by Cyclone Ditwah in Sri Lanka, including reconstruction and rehabilitation efforts in the most affected regions of the Indian-origin Tamil community, it added.

Over 2,200 Sikh pilgrims return to India from Pakistan after Baisakhi celebrations

M ZULQERNAIN ■ Lahore

Over 2,200 Indian Sikhs on Sunday returned to their homeland after attending the 10-day Baisakhi Festival and the 327th Khalsa Janam Din celebrations in Pakistan, an official said.

"Pakistan's Punjab Minister for Minority Affairs Sardar Ramesh Singh Arora, Chairman Evacuee Trust Property Board Qamar-uz-Zaman and Additional Secretary Shrines Nasir Mushtaq saw the Sikh pilgrims off at Wagah Border," Evacuee Trust Property Board (ETPB) spokesperson Ghulam Mohyuddin said.

Around 2,238 Sikh pilgrims arrived on April 10 to participate in Baisakhi fes-



tivities. Pakistan had issued around 2,800 visas to Sikh pilgrims this year, while approximately 600 pilgrims were unable to travel.

At the end of their visit, a cultural night was hosted by the Punjab Government at historic Hazuri Bagh outside the Lahore Fort for Indian Sikh pilgrims, and a special ceremony was held at the

Dayal Singh Trust Library under the World Centre for Punjabi on Saturday.

The Hazuri Bagh event featured colourful cultural performances, traditional music, and a lively atmosphere, wherein Sikh pilgrims enthusiastically participated. Many were seen enjoying the music and performing bhangra to the beat of drums, reflecting the spirit of joy and unity.

During the visit, the pilgrims performed religious rites at Gurdwara Panja Sahib Hassan Abdal, Gurdwara Janamasthan Nankana Sahib, Kartarpur Sahib and Dera Sahib Lahore, where they made collective applications for peace and interfaith understanding. (PTI)

North Korea fires multiple short-range missiles into sea



HYUNG-JIN KIM AND MARI YAMAGUCHI ■ Seoul

North Korea launched multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea on Sunday, its neighbours said, days after the UN's nuclear watchdog warned that North Korea was making "very serious" advances in efforts to build nuclear weapons.

The missiles fired from the North's Sinpo area flew about 140 kilometres (87 miles) each in a direction toward the country's eastern waters, South Korea's Joint Chiefs of Staff said. It said South Korea maintains a readiness to repel any provocations by North Korea and is closely exchanging information with the US and Japan.

In an emergency meeting of the National Security Council, senior South Korean officials expressed concerns about North Korea's repeated ballistic missile tests and urged it to stop them immediately. Sunday's launches came hours before South Korean President Lee Jae Myung left the country to

visit India and Vietnam.

The US and Japanese militaries also said they detected the launches. The US Indo-Pacific Command said it remains committed to the defence of the US homeland and its allies in the region. Japan's Defence Ministry said Tokyo strongly protested to Pyongyang, saying the launches threaten regional and international peace and violate UN Security Council resolutions that ban any ballistic activities by North Korea.

Sinpo, the launch site, is an eastern coastal city in North Korea that has a major shipyard used for building submarines.

South Korea's military was analysing whether the latest launches were made from a submarine, a land-based launcher or both platforms, according to South Korean media. Asked about where the missiles were launched, Japan's Deputy Minister of Defence Masahisa Miyazaki told reporters that Japan was analysing launch details in coordination with the US and South Korea. (AP)

8 children killed in Louisiana mass shooting: Police

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Shreveport (US)

A gunman in Louisiana killed eight children in shootings at two different homes early Sunday in the nation's deadliest mass shooting in more than two years, police in Shreveport said.

The victims ranged in age from one to about 14 years old, said Shreveport police spokesperson Chris Bordelon. A total of 10 were shot and some of the children were related to the suspect, Bordelon said.

The gunman later died after a chase with officers who fired at the suspect, Bordelon said. The suspect stole a car while leaving the scene of the shootings and



was followed by police, according to Bordelon.

Police did not release the name of the suspect but did say he was an adult male. The shootings were the result of a "domestic disturbance," Bordelon said.

Officials said they were still gathering details at the crime scenes south of down-

town Shreveport - the two homes and a third location.

"This is an extensive scene unlike anything most of us have ever seen," he said.

It was the deadliest mass shooting in the US since eight people were killed in a Chicago suburb in January 2024, according to a database maintained by The

Powerful winds, tornadoes leave heavy damage in Midwest US, no deaths

FREIDA FRISARO ■ Wisconsin

A trail of damaged homes and buildings dotted a wide swath of the US on Saturday after a burst of destructive winds and reported tornadoes tore off roofs, uprooted trees and rendered rural roads impassable with debris.

No deaths were reported following Friday's storms, which barreled through the Upper Midwest and delivered the latest round of severe weather to batter the region. Officials braced residents for a long recovery in some rural communities.

"We are extremely fortunate that this storm did not result in loss of life or serious injury," Stephenson County Sheriff Steve Stovall

said of the storm that hit Lena, Illinois.

Officials in Wisconsin and Minnesota echoed those sentiments.

In central Wisconsin, a reported tornado that tore through the cities of Kronenwetter and Ringle left behind damaged homes and some residents briefly trapped in their basements, Ringle Fire Chief Chris Kielman told reporters.

Marathon County Sheriff Chad Billeb said he had not seen this much devastation during his 34 years in law enforcement.

"A lot of people are going to need a lot of help," Billeb said. In Kronenwetter, neighbours were helping each other clear debris from their properties, and Wisconsin



Public Service was working to restore power. Police Chief Terry McHugh said it could be a lengthy process.

He noted that the Community Foundation of North Central Wisconsin has partnered with United Way of Marathon County to help

residents whose homes were damaged. In Olmsted County, Minnesota, sheriff's officials said tornadoes caused "multiple levels" of damage. At least 30 homes were damaged in Marion Township, with a number of those sustaining damage

180,000 residents. "It's a terrible morning."

Louisiana State Police said their detectives have been asked by Shreveport police to investigate. In a statement, state police say no officers were harmed in the shooting that involved an officer after a police pursuit into Bossier City on Sunday morning.

State police are asking anyone with pictures, video or information to share it with state police detectives.

Louisiana Gov Jeff Landry said in a statement that he and his wife were heartbroken. "We're deeply grateful to the law enforcement officers and first responders working tirelessly on the scene," he added.

Canadian man facing 14 murder charges to plead guilty to aiding suicide

JIM MORRIS AND ROB GILLIES ■ Vancouver

A Canadian man facing murder charges for allegedly selling lethal substances online to people at risk of self-harm has agreed to plead guilty to 14 counts of counseling or aiding suicide, his lawyer said on Saturday.

In turn, Canadian prosecutors will withdraw all 14 murder charges filed against Kenneth Law, lawyer Matthew Gourlay told The Associated Press in an email.

"The plea will be to the charges of aiding suicide," he said in an email. The Canadian Broadcasting Corporation first reported the plea.

Law will make a virtual appearance by Zoom before a Newmarket, Ontario, court on Monday afternoon for the purpose of further schedul-



ing, Gourlay said. The plea and the sentencing will take place at a later date. Calls to Ontario's Ministry of the Attorney General were not immediately answered.

Canadian police say Law, from the

Toronto area, used a series of websites to market and sell sodium nitrite, a substance commonly used to cure meats that can be deadly if ingested. They say he is suspected of sending at least 1,200 packages to

more than 40 countries.

Authorities in the United States, Britain, Italy, Australia and New Zealand also have launched investigations.

It is against the law in Canada for someone to recommend suicide, although assisted suicide has been legal since 2016 for people aged at least 18. Any adult with a serious illness, disease or disability may seek help in dying, but they must ask for assistance from a physician.

Law has been in custody since his arrest at his Mississauga, Ontario, home in May 2023.

According to the Canadian Criminal Code, abetting suicide carries a maximum sentence of 14 years. A murder conviction automatically means life in prison, with no chance of parole for at least 25 years. (AP)

Pakistan to repay USD 1.5 billion outstanding UAE debt by April 23

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Karachi

Pakistan's central bank on Saturday said it hopes to repay the outstanding \$1.5 billion of the \$3.5 billion loan to the United Arab Emirates by April 23.

The announcement by the State Bank of India (SBP) comes in anticipation of the disbursement of about \$1.2 billion from the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and a day after it repaid \$2 billion to the United Arab Emirates, which in turn, was done after Saudi Arabia deposited \$2 billion, part of the \$3 billion aid, with the SBP. "Pakistan



has repaid \$2 billion of a \$3.5 billion fund, which was placed by the United Arab Emirates with the State Administration of Foreign Exchange (SAFE) deposit with the central bank," a spokesperson of the SBP told

PTI. "The amount of \$2 billion was transferred to the UAE following the maturity of deposits held by the State Bank. The remaining amount has to be paid by April 23," he said.

The spokesperson claimed that Pakistan's foreign exchange reserves remained stable due to the inflow of funds. In a related development, Finance Minister Muhammad Aurangzeb said in Washington that Pakistan is expecting to get a disbursement of about \$1.2 billion from the Staff Level Agreement (SLA) with the IMF after a round of talks in Washington.

PROSPECT

Beer industry welcomes
Karnataka’s draft notification
on Alcohol based tax structure

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Welcoming Karnataka Government’s draft notification on the new tax structure for the alcobev sector, the Brewers Association of India (BAI) has said the AIB taxation structure based on the actual amount of alcohol in a product is a watershed moment which will not only optimise revenue but also meet public health goals of moderation.

The Karnataka Government on Saturday (April 18) issued a Draft Notification to amend the Karnataka Excise (Excise Duties and Fees) Rules, 1968, to implement sweeping reforms in the state’s alcobev sector by introducing Alcohol-in-Beverage (AIB) based taxation structure besides announcing several other structural reforms.

These changes were earlier announced by Chief Minister K Siddaramaiah while presenting the Karnataka State Budget 2026–27 last month and are now in process of notification.

The new rules, called the Karnataka Excise (Excise Duties and Fees Amendment) Rules, 2026, outline a taxation system which is based on premise that the product to be taxed is the alcohol and not the water that accompanies it.

This is the WHO recommended gold standard for alcohol taxation and is widely followed in in the world, BAI said in a statement.

“By announcing AIB-based taxation mechanism, Karnataka has become the first state in the country to explicitly link revenue maximisation goal of the State with desired public health out-



Vinod Giri, Director General, Brewers Association of India.

comes. We commend Honourable Chief Minister Siddaramaiah for bringing in such a major excise policy reforms in India. We hope that other states too will soon implement an explicit linkage of tax with alcohol content in their excise policy soon.” said Vinod Giri, Director General, Brewers Association of India.

While the BAI has wholeheartedly welcomed the AIB-based taxation, it believes that few suggestions regarding slabs in beer would improve this model further. BAI will soon be submitting this separately to the Karnataka Government.

The reforms in the new Excise rules go beyond to also bring about step changes in Ease of Doing Business for the alcobev sector such as full deregulation of Government-administered price fixation, simplification of taxation framework, auto-renewal of manufacturing licences, online approvals, 24-hour operations for distilleries and breweries, and creating tourism opportunities around breweries.

Such progressive steps will promote state’s economy and the industry and make Karnataka more attractive investment destination, Giri added.

CBI arrests DGCA, Reliance officials
in drone import bribery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has arrested DGCA official Mudavath Devula and Reliance Industries’s top official Bharat Mathur in a ₹2.5 lakh bribery case to facilitate the import of drones for another private company, officials said Sunday. Devula is a Deputy Director General at the Airworthiness Directorate, Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), Headquarters, New Delhi and Mathur is handling Regulatory and Corporate Affairs of Reliance Industries.



Both was arrested by CBI on Saturday, red handed with bribe amount. The accused DGCA public servant allegedly demanded undue advantage from private

persons in lieu of issuing approvals and permissions for applications pending with DGCA for a private aerospace company, a CBI spokesperson said in a statement. “The

CBI arrested Deputy Director General at the Airworthiness Directorate, Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), Headquarters, New Delhi, along with a representative of a private company in a bribery case of ₹2.5 lakh resulting in the seizure of the entire amount,” it said.

The CBI conducted searches at the premises of the accused public servant and other private persons across four locations in Delhi, resulting in the seizure of cash worth ₹37 lakh along with gold and silver coins and multiple digital devices, the statement added.

India, US chief negotiators to begin
three-day trade pact talks in Washington

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

About a dozen officers from India will reach Washington on April 20 for three-day talks with the US authorities on the first phase of the bilateral trade agreement (BTA), an official said. As the tariff landscape has changed in the US, both sides may like to relook at the framework of the agreement, the text of which was released on February 7.

Following the decision of the US Supreme Court against the sweeping tariffs imposed by US President Donald Trump on a number of countries, the Trump administration imposed a 10 per cent tariff on all countries from February 24 for 150 days.

“The meeting will happen from April 20-22 in Washington DC. India’s chief negotiator Darpan Jain (additional secretary in the department of commerce) is leading the team. Officers from customs and external affairs ministry are also part of the Indian team,” the official said.

Further, the two unilateral investigations launched by the US Trade Representative (USTR) may also figure in the three-day deliberations.

India has strongly rejected allegations made by the US Trade Representative in those two investigations under its Section 301 of trade law and has requested to terminate the probes as the initiation notice has failed to provide cogent rationale to substantiate the claims.



According to that framework, the US had agreed to reduce tariffs on India to 18 per cent, from 50 per cent. It had removed the 25 per cent tariffs on Indian goods for buying Russian oil and was to cut the remaining 25 per cent to 18 per cent under the pact.

But on February 20, the US Supreme Court ruled against Trump’s reciprocal tariffs which were imposed under the 1977 International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA). After that, the President announced the imposition of 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days, starting February 24.

In light of these changes, a meeting between chief negotiators of India and the US scheduled in February was postponed. Now, they are meeting in Washington from April 20, 2026.

Under the agreed framework, India proposed to eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including dried distillers’ grains (DDGs), red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed

fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products. India had also expressed its intentions to purchase \$500 billion of US energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal over the next five years.

Further, when India finalised the deal, it enjoyed a comparative advantage over its competitor countries. Now, with all US trading partners facing a uniform 10 per cent tariff, the pact requires recalibration.

“So the agreement will have to be recalibrated, redrafted,” a Government source has said, adding, “that amount of change will take place from their side”. “In our case, since the agreement has not been signed, we have got the option where we can right now change whatever needs to be changed,” the source has said.

As the circumstances have changed, every country is engaging with the US to see what is going to be the nature of their trade agreements with America. China has overtaken the US to emerge as India’s largest trading partner in 2025-26. The US was India’s largest trading partner for four consecutive years till 2024-25.

The country’s outbound shipments to the US grew marginally 0.92 per cent to \$87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to \$52.9 billion. The trade surplus declined to \$34.4 billion in 2025-26 from \$40.89 billion in 2024-25.

iLive Connect launched
to monitor cardiac
activity, reduce mortality

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

India is confronting a significant cardiovascular burden, with nearly 8,000 deaths occurring daily due to heart disease. Current estimates indicate 10,000 to 15,000 heart attacks per day, with 3,000 to 5,000 resulting in mortality, often without preceding clinical warning.

Cardiovascular and thoracic surgeon Dr Rahul Chandola said this on the occasion of South India launch of iLive Connect, a device which reduces the risk of sudden cardiac events.

The iLive Connect device has wearable biosensor patch and wellness bracelets which monitor vital parameters such as heart activity and blood pressure in real time and the system data is tracked 24x7 by experienced doctors at a remote command centre, who alert patients and their families in case of any abnormality.

Around 40 doctors were present at the launch event held in Chennai on Sunday, including Dr Thillai Vallal, Managing Director of Venkateswara Hospitals; Dr M A Raja, Director and Senior Consultant in Medical Oncology at MGM Healthcare; Dr Amit Kumar, Critical Care Physician; Dr Gopala Murugan, Senior Consultant in Interventional Cardiology at MGM Healthcare; Dr Prashanth Krishna, MD of Prashanth Group of Hospitals; Dr Manoj SivaramaKrishnan, Senior Interventional Cardiologist at Kavery Hospital and Dr Dhenesh, Critical Care Physician.

Clinicians are increasingly emphasising that symptom-driven care is insufficient, particularly in the context of rising incidence of heart attack among younger and asymptomatic populations.

In response, there is a growing shift toward doctor-led continuous cardiac monitoring platforms such as iLive Connect, which enable longitudinal assessment of cardiovascular physiology



and support early risk identification.

Adoption is expanding across South India and nationwide, with clinicians integrating such platforms into routine practice to enhance diagnostic accuracy and continuity of care, said Dr Chandola, founder of iLive connect while addressing the gathering.

Dr Viveka Kumar, well known Cardiologist and co founder of iLive Connect highlights that such platforms function as a clinical extension beyond hospital settings, enabling physicians to maintain visibility over patient physiology and make data-driven decisions in real time, even in ambulatory environments.

“Real-time physiological data allows earlier recognition of cardiac instability, enabling timely intervention and potentially preventing acute events,” he said.

Beyond cardiac care, the platform is being used in the management of chronic conditions such as diabetes, hypertension, chronic obstructive pulmonary disease (COPD) and asthma, he said.

With India accounting for nearly 20 per cent of global heart attack-related deaths, clinicians are calling for a shift from episodic care to a continuous care model based on preventive monitoring and real-time intervention.

“The future of cardiac care lies in continuous visibility, where early detection and timely intervention can significantly improve outcomes,” Dr Chandola said.

Digital arrest scams: CBI to
launch chatbot to help people

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To tackle the menace of digital arrest frauds, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) will on Monday unveil an artificial intelligence-powered chatbot that will help people verify the authenticity of notices issued to them.

The chatbot, ‘Abhay’, will be launched by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on the occasion of the 22nd DP Kohli Memorial Lecture organised by the CBI in honour of its founding director, officials said. The CJI will deliver the lecture on ‘Challenges of Cyber Crime - Role for Police and Judiciary’. He will also confer 24 Medals for Meritorious Service.

“The AI-powered notice verification chatbot, ABHAY, will allow the public to verify the genuineness of a notice purportedly issued by the CBI. In the context of digital arrest frauds, this provides a much-required tool for the citizens,” a CBI spokesperson said.

In a number of cases, it has emerged that scammers posing as CBI officials have coerced the public by showing fraudulent notices purportedly issued by



the agency in non-existing cases, holding the victim hostage in the name of digital arrest and extorting crores of rupees in the process, the spokesperson said.

The Supreme Court has recently flagged that ₹54,000 crore was siphoned off by cyber criminals in various scams and termed the menace “robbery or dacoity”.

Organised since 2000, the D P Kohli Memorial Lecture has seen addresses by many eminent personalities.

“Born in 1907 in Uttar Pradesh, Kohli joined the police service in 1931 and went on to serve with distinction in multiple regions and the Government of India. He led the Delhi Special Police Establishment (DSPE) from 1955 and became the founding director of CBI upon its establishment on 1st April 1963, serving until his retirement in 1968,” the CBI said in a statement.

Army CSD liquor smuggling
racket busted in Assam

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

On 17 April 2026 at general area near Misamari railway station, a massive consignment of liquor of around 150 Cases originally intended for sale through CSD outlets catering to Army personnel, was seized during an attempted smuggling operation at the Canteen Stores Depot in Misamari. The joint operation, carried out by “Assam Police”, the Tezpur-based “Gajraj Intelligence Unit”, and “local Army authorities”, exposed a well-coordinated effort to divert restricted supplies into unauthorised channels. Acting on precise intelligence, the team intercepted the consignment while being moved out of the depot premises.

The seizure highlights ongoing vigilance and



strong inter-agency coordination to curb illegal activities and safeguard the integrity of military supply chains.

FIR in this regard has been done at Misamari Police Station.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.



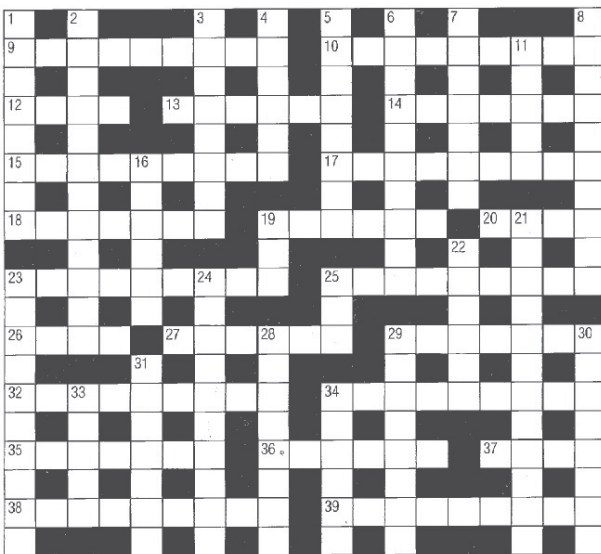
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SOLUTION (18.04.26)

6	2	9	5	7	8	3	4	1
8	4	5	3	6	1	9	2	7
1	3	7	9	2	4	6	5	8
2	5	6	7	8	3	1	9	4
7	9	8	4	1	5	2	3	6
4	1	3	2	9	6	8	7	5
5	7	1	8	3	2	4	6	9
9	6	2	1	4	7	5	8	3
3	8	4	6	5	9	7	1	2

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
MONDAY | APRIL 20, 2026



ACROSS

- 9 What the illiterate butcher didn't recognise? (9)
10 "If not a change for the worse" one put in (9)
12 Make an impact on that will leave a lasting impression (4)
13 They're possibly Spanish, si? No, no: wrong (6)
14 Opening for a chap in the sanitation department (7)
15 A minor luminary in Hollywood (5,4)
17 It's doling out things he can manage without (9)
18 "Birds" were for a long time included among "Animals" (7)
19 The dread of all governesses and nannies? (6)

DOWN

- 1 And the new chap I brought round is no help (8)
2 The one about footing the bill we never tire of? (8,4)
3 Means to study music (8)
4 Turn in, having wandered back to have a quick meal (6)
5 Think you regard as (8)
6 They mean no, you're not trying to get a hitch (6,4)
7 And having raised the cover, put one's initials on it (7)
8 Commemorated by the famous (10)
11 Is neither brought back in chains? (5)
16 He has cattle with him, the little daughter and a dog (6)

- 20 Eat like lightning (4)
23 Bird that's foolishly trapped, once having flown in (9)
25 Claimed to have fought with (9)
26 Was a looker, I had heard (4)
27 I require a day to go through it, certainly (6)
29 Sign as sender, having wrapped the ring in it (7)
32 Reminding you of your transgressions is irritating (4,5)
34 Overlook the lack of respect (9)
35 Write in, having shot back, about the vacancy (7)
36 For the little creature carrying it, it's a strain (6)
37 How many in favour of restraining the union? (4)

- 19 Have an addition - to the family? (3)
21 Is bossy with, when one buys drinks from (6,6)
22 "It's an honour," you say, "to involve myself in your business" (6)
23 Are not fooled by: that's transparent (3-7)
24 Giving to an undomesticated dog in the shed (7,3)
25 The fish - a portion of haddock - is sent back (3)
26 Beseeches when sent off, concealing a tear drop (8)
29 Taking to quarters wrapped in rugs, leaving nothing to chance (8)
30 A fabulous place for older swingers to have a party (2,6)

SOLUTION (18.04.26)

- ACROSS
4, Genial
7, Over-time
8, Team up
10, Cl-own
13, Bolt
14, Ho-me
15, W-in-e
16, Pet
17, Stag
19, Va-i-n

- 21, He-artfelt
23, Corn
24, Rent
26, Sow
27, Ey-Ed
29, Ave-R
32, F-lee
33, Arise
34, Mala-ya
35, Rich-mond
36, Adjoin

- DOWN
1, Touch
2, Veno-m
3, Stun
4, Get on
5, Neat
6, Accu-men
9, Eleven
11, Lo-W
12, Weser
13, Big tree
15, War

- 16, P-it
18, Tame-ly
20, Altar
21, How
22, Fed
23, Coward
25, Les(-lie)
26, Yea-RN
30, Vi's-O-R
31, Re-ady
32, Far-O
33, Ache

BRIEFLY

Aditi Ashok cards 69 to move to T-36 in Los Angeles



India's Aditi Ashok fought back with three birdies on the back nine to move up to tied 36th place with a third-round card of 3-under 69 at the JM Eagle Los Angeles Championship in Los Angeles. Aditi birdied the sixth but gave it back on the Par-5 seventh. On the back nine, she birdied the 11th and added two more gains on the 16th and the 18th for a 69, after 70-72 on the first two days. Korea's Sei Young Kim led by two following a roller-coaster round of 71. She had five birdies on the front and ran up an eight-stroke lead with five holes left at El Caballero Country Club. She then bogeyed four times in a row, from the 14th to the 17th. Her late meltdown with four straight bogeys gave two-time event winner Hannah Green and others a foot in the door. She salvaged an up-and-down from off the back of the 18th green to salvage a two-shot advantage. Kim (71) is 15-under, while Green, the 2023 and 2024 champion at Wilshire Country Club, had a 67 to join Suvichaya Vinijchaitham (67), Jessica Porvasnik (68) and Ina Yoon (71) at 13 under. Former UCLA star Patty Tavatanakit was another stroke back after a 67.

Serge Gnabry likely out for the rest of season



Bayern Munich forward Serge Gnabry is likely to miss the rest of the season, putting his World Cup participation for Germany in doubt. Gnabry tore the adductor muscle in his right thigh and will be out "for a longer period," Bayern announced Saturday. The club did not give any further details, leaving the extent of the injury and the timeline for the 30-year-old forward's return uncertain. But it seems he'll miss Bayern's remaining games of the season as it chases a treble of trophies. Bayern is likely to clinch the Bundesliga title on Sunday unless it loses at home to Stuttgart, in which case it will have another four rounds to secure the trophy. Bayern then faces Bayer Leverkusen away in the German Cup semifinals on Wednesday, before it turns its attention to Paris Saint-Germain in the Champions League semifinals. Gnabry contributed eight goals and set up seven more as Bayern broke the Bundesliga record for goals scored last weekend. He started every World Cup qualifier for Germany and two friendlies in March, and was sure to have been included in coach Julian Nagelsmann's plans for the tournament in Mexico, Canada and the United States.

Al-Ahli to face Vissel Kobe in Asian Champions League semifinals

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Jeddah

Al-Ahli is the sole remaining Saudi Arabian team in the last four of the AFC Champions League Elite and will take on Vissel Kobe of Japan on Monday, while Japan's Machida Zelvia meets Shabab Al-Ahli of the United Arab Emirates with a place in the final at stake.

Al-Ahli, which lifted the trophy for the first time last May, struggled to a 2-1 win over Malaysia's Johor Darul Tazim on Friday in Jeddah, the Saudi Arabian city that is hosting the knockout stage of the tournament.

Ali Majrash scored an own goal after 19 minutes to put Johor ahead, and the Al-Ahli



defender was red-carded soon after. Just before the break, former Barcelona midfielder Franck Kessie levelled. Nine minutes after the

Union Berlin coach looks ahead after loss

CIARAN FAHEY
■ Berlin

Marie-Louise Eta was in little mood for celebrating after making her debut as the first female coach in the Bundesliga. Eta was feted by the Union Berlin fans before the game, but the team was unable to live up to the sense of occasion as it slumped to a 2-1 defeat at home to Wolfsburg, which was previously winless in 12 games.

Eta had spoken before the match of just wanting to get on with the job, deflecting attention from her own barrier-breaking achievements, and focusing instead on her task of securing Bundesliga survival for Union.

She was appointed as interim coach with five games to go before the end of the season. Now it's four, and Union is a point closer to the relegation zone, just six points away, despite dominating toward the end against Wolfsburg.

"First of all, of course, I'm disappointed that we lost this game. But I'm very happy with how we approached it today, with the lads' performance," Eta said.

"We talked about a lot of things this week. We also saw the lads training with good energy, with great conviction, and we implemented the plan we'd developed over the past few days very well today." Her team missed a host of good chances, with



Wolfsburg goalkeeper Kamil Grabara proving to be the decisive figure, while lapses at the back allowed Patrick Wimmer and Dzenan Pejcinovic to score early in each half for the visitors.

"Today it was simply about

focusing on the essentials. In the end, it was about football, and I was really looking forward to playing this Bundesliga match here," Eta said. "Ultimately, it's bitter and disappointing that we're leaving here without any

Pranavi shoots 3-under to move to 30th place in Joburg

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

Pranavi Urs, the lone Indian in the weekend rounds, carded 3-under 70 to rise up to the 30th place at the Joburg Ladies Open on the Ladies European Tour here.

After 70-74 on the first two days, she had six birdies against three bogeys and reached 5-under for 54 holes and was placed a respectable T-30th in the Euros 330,000 event.

The other Indian golfers, Diksha Dagar, Tvesa Malik, Avani Prashanth and Hitaashree Bakshi, missed the 36-hole cut at the Par-73 course measuring 6710 yards. Three French golfers, all past winners on the Ladies



European Tour (LET), Camille Chevalier, Celine Herbin and Agathe Laisne went low on moving day at Randpark Golf Club. They will now play in the final group. Chevalier and Herbin lead the way on 16-under par after carding rounds of 67 (-6) and 68 (-5) respectively in South Africa.

Navarroa but fell back early doors after carding a double-bogey at the 1st. The two-time LET winner bounced back brilliantly, birdying the next hole before adding another at the 9th.

Herbin came alive on the back nine, birdying the 13th before rolling in a lovely eagle on the 14th following an exceptional approach.

A birdie-birdie finish for the Frenchwoman would see her reclaim her share of the lead at the top of the leaderboard. Herbin, 43-years-old, is chasing a third LET victory this week.

Chevalier, meanwhile, playing in the same group, went bogey-free for the second day in a row at Randpark Golf Club.

FC Goa hand Mumbai City first defeat of ISL season

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Margao

FC Goa snapped leaders Mumbai City FC's unbeaten run with a 2-0 win in their Indian Super League match here on Saturday.

It was the first defeat of the Mumbai side this season.

Goals from Sahil Tavora (29th) and Muhammed Nemil Valiyattil (45+3) ensured that the Gaurs made the most of their dominance, while a disciplined defensive display kept Mumbai City at bay throughout the contest.

The hosts started brightly and controlled possession in the opening exchanges, moving the ball with purpose and looking to break down Mumbai City's organised defensive struc-

ture. Early attempts from Raynier Fernandes and Sahil Tavora hinted at Goa's attacking intent, though the Islanders' backline, marshalled by Nuno Reis and Bijay Chhetri, held firm.

The breakthrough arrived in the 29th minute following sustained pressure from the hosts. A corner from Dejan Drazic caused chaos inside the Mumbai penalty area, and after an initial effort was blocked, Sahil Tavora reacted quickest to guide the loose ball into the bottom corner, giving FC Goa the lead. Mumbai attempted an immediate response, with Noufal testing Goa keeper Hrithik Tiwari from distance and Joni Kauko seeing a follow-up effort blocked, but the hosts continued to look



the more composed side.

The Gaurs doubled their advantage in stoppage time of the first half with a moment of brilliance. After winning an aerial duel in midfield, Muhammed Nemil was picked out by Raynier Fernandes, took a touch, and unleashed a spectacular left-footed strike from nearly

35 yards that flew into the top corner, leaving Phurba Lachenpa with no chance and sending the home crowd into raptures.

Holding a 2-0 lead at the break, Goa entered the second half with confidence, while Mumbai City pushed men forward in search of a way back into the contest.

Bhatia, Theegala slip in 3rd round at RBC Heritage

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hilton Head Island (USA)

Akshay Bhatia had a modest 2-under 69 while Sahith Theegala shot an even par 71 as both slid down the leaderboard on the third day of the RBC Heritage golf tournament. Bhatia, now at 8-under, is down six places to T-25, while Theegala is T-41 after being T-19 a day earlier.

Meanwhile, Sudarshan Yellamaraju (72) also fell nine places to T-55.

Bhatia birdied the third, fifth, 10th, 11th and the 14th and dropped shots on the fourth, seventh and 13th.

Theegala had a bogey on



the fourth, but it was rectified by a birdie on the seventh. However, three straight bogeys from the ninth ruined the card before he made a partial recovery with birdies on the 15th and the 17th. Matt Fitzpatrick

affectionately known as Louie. She made four changes to the team that lost at the bottom side, Heidenheim, the weekend before, bringing back Union veteran Christopher Trimmel. "For Louie, of course, it's difficult to impose all the new things in just three or four days, so everything can be implemented immediately. That's perfectly understandable. It would have been difficult for any coach, and yet we still managed to execute a solid match plan well. A lot of things worked out," Trimmel said. "I'm staying positive."

Union next faces Champions League-chasing Leipzig away, then relegation-rival Cologne at home. (AP)

Inter Miami beats Colorado Rapids 3-2



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Commerce City (US)

Lionel Messi had two goals, German Berterame scored for the second consecutive game, and Inter Miami beat the Colorado Rapids 3-2 to extend their unbeaten streak to seven games and win their first game under interim coach Guillermo Hoyos.

Hoyos, who had been serving as the club's sporting director, took over coaching duties after Javier Mascherano unexpectedly left the club due to personal reasons. Mascherano led Inter Miami to the 2025 MLS Cup title in his only full season with the club.

Messi, who opened the scoring when he converted a penalty kick in the 13th minute, scored the go-ahead goal in the 79th minute. After a Colorado turnover near midfield, Messi cut back near the right corner of the penalty box and flicked a rising shot that split a pair of defenders and slipped inside the back post. Messi has seven goals this season, tied with Sam Surridge and Petar Musa for the most in MLS. Miami (4-1-

3) hasn't lost since a season-opening 3-0 defeat to Los Angeles FC. Yannick Bright was shown a straight red card in the 87th minute, and Miami played a man down the rest of the way. The Rapids (4-4-0) had won back-to-back games and three of their last four.

Bright drew a penalty conceded by Josh Atencio, and Messi converted from the spot to open the scoring. Mateo Silvestri, along the right end line, played an arcing cross to the back post where Berterame slammed home a header to make it 2-0 in the fifth minute of first-half stoppage time.

Bertarame made his first career start and scored his first goal in MLS last time out in a 2-2 tie with the New York Red Bulls. Rafael Navarro scored in the 58th minute for the Rapids.

The 26-year-old forward scored two goals in a 6-2 win over Houston last time out and has six goals this season. Darren Yapi subbed on for Hamzat Ojediran and, moments later, scored on the counter-attack to make it 2-2 in the 62nd minute.

Tottenham's survival hopes hit as Chelsea loses to Manchester United

STEVE DOUGLAS
■ Manchester

Tottenham remain rooted inside the relegation zone. Chelsea is stuck outside the Champions League spots.

It was a disappointing Saturday for the two London giants in the Premier League, starting with Tottenham conceding an equalizer deep into stoppage time to draw 2-2 with Brighton.

That kept Spurs, ever-presents in England's top flight since 1978, in third-to-last place and in grave danger of relegation with five games left. Chelsea then lost 1-0 at home to Manchester United in a showdown between teams fighting for a place in the top five and therefore Champions League qualifi-

cation. Matheus Cunha scored the only goal.

While United strengthened its grip on third place, Chelsea stayed in sixth and is looking increasingly unlikely to get back into Europe's top competition next season. That would be a huge financial blow to Chelsea's American ownership, which has spent heavily to build an underperforming playing squad.

Tottenham is still without a win in the Premier League in 2026 — a stretch of 15 matches. That's a remarkable run for one of the country's so-called "Big Six", which played in the Champions League this season as the reigning Europa League winner.

Yet Tottenham manager Roberto De Zerbi still believes

his team is capable of winning all of its remaining games and staying up.

"Now it's difficult to hear my words," he said, "but if you watch the players and analyse the level of the players, I think we can win five games in a row."

"Not to be arrogant because I am not arrogant, especially now, but we have the quality enough to fight and win games in a row."

Georginio Rutter's late equaliser for Brighton at Tottenham Hotspur Stadium meant last-place Wolverhampton's impending relegation was put off for a bit longer. However, Wolves are destined for the drop, with their 3-0 loss at Leeds meaning they are 15 points from safety with five matches



remaining. Xavi Simons looked as if he'd won the game for Tottenham when he cut inside and curled a finish into the top corner in the 77th minute, sparking joyous celebrations by newly hired manager Roberto De Zerbi. The Italian, formerly

Brighton's manager, was taking charge of his second game and first at home.

Earlier, Pedro Porro gave Tottenham the lead with a 39th-minute header, before Kaoru Mitoma volleyed home an equaliser in first-half stoppage time. Tottenham is a

point behind West Ham, which visits Crystal Palace on Monday, and two behind Nottingham Forest, which hosts Burnley on Sunday.

Wolves have been in the Premier League for the past eight seasons but are now on the brink. Dominic Calvert-Lewin converted a stoppage-time penalty to round off the win for Leeds after early goals by James Justin — with a bicycle kick — and Noah Okafor. Leeds is eight points clear of the relegation zone.

Man United moved 10 points clear of Chelsea and looks certain to qualify for the Champions League after a big win sealed despite not having four centre-backs available.

Cunha converted a cut-back from Bruno Fernandes, who now has 18 assists for the

campaign - two off the Premier League record held jointly by Kevin De Bruyne and Thierry Henry.

Chelsea was without Joao Pedro, who was injured in training this week, and lost Estevao to an injury midway through the first half.

Chelsea has lost its last three league games and five of its last six games in all competitions, piling the heat on inexperienced manager Liam Rosenior. "At the moment, any small mistake we are making and the ball ends up in the back of our net," Rosenior said, "and that has to change." Howe under more pressure after latest Newcastle loss. Newcastle's players were jeered after a 2-1 home loss to Bournemouth, the team's third straight

defeat in the Premier League. It left Newcastle in 14th place in the 20-team top flight with five games remaining of the campaign and manager Eddie Howe under increasing pressure. Adrien Truffert grabbed the winner in the 85th minute as eighth-place Bournemouth extended its unbeaten run to 13 straight league matches.

Brentford failed to boost its unlikely Champions League qualification hopes by drawing a fifth straight game in the Premier League, this time 0-0 at home to Fulham.

Brentford could have climbed above Chelsea, which plays Manchester United later, and into sixth place with a win but missed a slew of chances. Top scorer Igor Thiago hit the goal frame. (AP)

Arya, Connolly guide Punjab Kings to 54-run win over LSG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly slammed 93 and 87 respectively as Punjab Kings defeated Lucknow Super Giants by 54 runs in an IPL match here on Sunday.

Arya and Connolly added 182 runs in just 13.2 overs for a massively entertaining second wicket stand for PBKS, as they tallied 254/7, this IPL season's highest total, going past RCB's 250 for three.

LSG managed to dismiss the duo and Punjab skipper Shreyas Iyer in quick succession but the home team had already built a superb launching pad by then for Marcus Stoinis (29) to cash in.

In reply, LSG could manage just 200 for 5 in 20 overs with skipper Rishabh Pant (43), opener Mitchell Marsh (40) and Aiden Markram (42) providing some resistance.

Earlier in the game, Priyansh Arya, one of country's most exciting T20 batting talent alongside Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, smashed his way to a magnificent 93 off just 37 balls as Punjab Kings blew the Lucknow Super Kings into smithereens posting an imposing 254 for 7 in an IPL match here on Sunday.

The 24-year-old Delhi man joined hands with next most talked about Australian batting talent Cooper Connolly, who also oozed

class in his 45-ball-87.

The duo added an astounding 182 runs off just 80 balls with 16 sixes (9 from Priyansh and 7 from Connolly) and 12 fours shared between them.

If the Power play score of 63 for one was good, they were even better in the middle phase between overs 7th and 11th in which 66 runs came.

Priyansh, the beefy south-paw, just stood and delivered with minimal footwork and maximum bat speed as balls flew thick and fast.

The full balls were muscled down the ground or over extra cover. The short and wide deliveries were slashed or ramped while bouncers on the shoulders were either pulled or hooked without an



iota of expression on his face.

It seemed like a regular job for the man, who also learnt ropes from Gautam Gambhir's childhood coach Sanjay Bhardwaj.

Connolly was in a different mould as his lofted sixes over extra cover and front-foot pull-shots into the deep mid-wicket stands would have even made his franchise coach Ricky Ponting proud.

Their batting styles were contrasting – Priyansh scoring his half-century off just 19 balls and scoring the next 43 off 18 balls.

Connolly, on the other hand took some time as his 50 came off 35 deliveries but the next 37 came off 12.

Priyansh, who had a stellar

first season has been time and again proving that 2025 wasn't a mere flash in the pan.

The Delhi youngster was unfazed even as his opening partner Prabhsimran Singh was out first ball nicking an outswinger from Mohammed Shami.

A clueless LSG skipper Rishabh Pant would certainly rue not taking the DRS when left-arm seamer Mohsin Khan had trapped Connolly in-front fairly early in the innings.

The replays confirmed that the TV umpire would have adjudged Connolly out.

Mohsin lost his confidence after that and gave 20 runs in his third over and the momentum slipped completely out of LSG's grasp.

The only saving grace for them was Prince Yadav (2/25 in 4 overs) who shone brightly as most of his colleagues were sent on a leather hunt. He was simply outstanding with his change of pace and blockhole deliveries.

Both Connolly and Priyansh were dismissed in quick succession when century was there for the taking.

The Indian youngster was ambitiously going for his 10th six, but Mitchell Marsh got him at the boundary ropes.

Even as LSG owner Sanjiv Goenka was seen heaving a sigh of relief, the damage that had already been done by the Priyansh-Connolly pair seemed to be beyond repair.

Chief selector Ajit Agarkar's contract renewed till next year



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ajit Agarkar will continue as chairman of the senior selection committee after the BCCI decided to renew his contract for one more year, keeping an eye on the 2027 ODI World Cup. Under Agarkar's chairmanship, the selected Indian teams between October 2023 and March 2026 reached four ICC tournament finals, winning three of them – two T20 World Cups and one ICC Champions Trophy – and it was a foregone conclusion that his contract would be renewed for a fourth year.

"Agarkar didn't seek extension. A selector can continue up to four years in either junior or senior selection committee and five years cumulatively across both committees. Hence, Ajit's contract is being renewed and not extended," a senior BCCI source said.

Sources close to Agarkar always maintained that he preferred to let the decision-makers assess his panel's performance rather than seek a renewal himself.

Continuity ahead of the 50-over World Cup is one of the key factors behind the board's decision.

During his tenure, the committee has taken several tough calls, including overseeing the Test retirements of Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma, and gradually phasing out senior pacer Mohammed Shami from international cricket. It also made a bold selection call, dropping Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill from the T20 World Cup squad and instead fielding a form player in Ishan Kishan.

KKR end winless run with four-wicket win against RR

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Vice-captain Rinku Singh lived up to expectations with a composed unbeaten 53 as Kolkata Knight Riders survived anxious moments to script their first win of IPL 2026 with a four-wicket victory over Rajasthan Royals here on Sunday.

Courtesy of Rinku and Anukul Roy, the target was achieved with two balls to spare, and the win took them to ninth spot in the 10-team table.

Wily Varun Chakravarthy (3/14) returned to his best, showing perfect chemistry with veteran Sunil Narine (2/26) as KKR rediscovered their spin magic at Eden Gardens to restrict RR to an under-par 155/9. Rookie pacer Kartik Tyagi (3/22) also

shone at the death with important wickets. The bowlers had done half the job for KKR in pursuit of their maiden victory after six matches, and it was up to the batters to finish the task.

But what followed was another familiar batting horror from a line-up that has struggled for consistency this season. Reeling at 85/6 in 13.3 overs, KKR needed 69 runs from the last six overs, with RR's bowlers tightening the screws and Rinku alongside Anukul Roy appearing to be the last recognised pair. Then came a moment of fortune as Rinku was dropped on eight by Nandre Burger – a sitter that proved to be the turning point.

The KKR vice-captain made full use of the reprieve to



Kolkata Knight Riders' Rinku Singh plays a shot during the Indian Premier League (IPL) 2026 T20 cricket match between Kolkata Knight Riders and Rajasthan Royals at Eden Gardens in Kolkata West Bengal on Sunday

change gears, while Roy played the perfect supporting role as the duo stitched a match-winning 76-run seventh-wicket stand off just 37 balls to seal KKR's first win of the season.

The much-awaited victory came after a six-match winless run, taking KKR to three points at the halfway stage. For RR, it was a second successive defeat, with their middle-order concerns persisting, especially with skipper Riyan Parag enduring a lean run. The win will bring much-needed relief for KKR, who had lost from winning positions in recent games. It took them 22 days to finally break the jinx. On a day when skipper Ajinkya Rahane failed again, registering a second successive duck,

it was Rinku who led from the front with 53 not out off 34 balls (5x4, 2x6). Roy complemented him well with 29 not out off 16 balls (1x4, 2x6). Rinku shifted momentum with a slog-sweep six off Ravi Bishnoi in the 16th over, while Roy matched him with a six in an over that yielded 19 runs. Rinku then took on RR's best bowler Jofra Archer with two boundaries, and Roy showed great composure by striking a six off him in the penultimate over as KKR were left needing just 11 runs in the final over. RR will rue falling short by at least 30 runs, undone by the brilliance of Chakravarthy, Narine and Tyagi. However, they had a perfect start while defending 155. (PTI)

Ishan Kishan praises young bowlers

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad skipper Ishan Kishan couldn't have been more pleased with a group of young pacers, who are executing the bowling plans to the 'T.

Chasing 195, Chennai Super Kings were kept down to 184 for 8 as pacers Eshan Malinga (3/29 in 4 overs), Sakib Hussain (1/32 in 4 overs), Nitish Reddy (2/31 in 4 overs), and spinner Shiwang Kumar (1/18 in 3 overs) were bang on target.

"It is lovely when you have a bunch of young bowlers who are coming up with their own plans and executing the team plans as well. As a captain, it makes my job easier to set fields,"



Kishan said after the end of the match. With Pat Cummins not available during the first half, Kishan was happy to trust the young bunch.

"Looking at them at practice, seeing them get better day by day, they are keen on doing well, so you give them the ball and let them do

what they want to," he said.

While he was happy with bowling, Kishan conceded that on this batting track, SRH were at least 20 runs short, but the bowlers covered for the batters.

CSK skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad said that not having big overs at the start of the back-10 dented their chances. "It was just about 80 runs needed in 10 overs (with the bat). From there, it was just about building a couple of partnerships. We scored just 4 runs in the next 2 overs after the 10-over mark. Chasing 12-13 at the death is going to be difficult," said Gaikwad. He lauded the bowlers for keeping SRH below 200.

"Looking at how their powerplay went, I was looking at a score around 220-230. To pull it back by 30 runs, I would have taken it any day under 200. It's been three successive games that the bowling unit has been doing really well." Even the powerplay today, I thought Abhishek played brilliantly. I think everyone did a good job (with the ball)," he added.

Big big loss: CSK hit by Mhatre injury

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Chennai Super Kings have been dealt a major blow with young batter Ayush Mhatre sustaining a hamstring tear which "looks pretty bad", during their IPL match against Sunrisers Hyderabad.

The 18-year-old, who came in as an impact substitute, appeared in visible discomfort and clutched his hamstring while attempting a run, requiring on-field treatment during CSK's 10-run loss to SRH here on Saturday. "Obviously, a hamstring tear. I don't know how bad it is. I'm sure we'll scan him probably tomorrow or the next day," batting



coach Mike Hussey said at the post-match press conference. The Australian added that Mhatre will undergo scans to assess the extent of the injury, with the recovery timeline remaining uncertain, although a hamstring tear can take up to six months to heal, depending on its severity.

We made 175 feel like 190 but fell short: Dinesh Karthik

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

Royal Challengers Bengaluru batting coach Dinesh Karthik praised his side's bowling effort for making a modest 175-run target feel competitive, before David Miller's late onslaught secured a last-over win for Delhi Capitals in their IPL match.

DC won the match with a ball to spare here on Saturday. "At no point did we feel that we were a few runs short. We also had some lovely catches, great spots, we made 175 feel like 190, which is all you can do," Karthik was quoted as saying in a press release.

RCB posted a decent total on a challenging surface, with Phil Salt (63 off 38) leading the charge through a composed half-century, his second of the season and sixth overall



for the franchise. "It was a tough pitch to bat, and we played quite well for about 75 per cent of the innings. But yes, in the last five overs, we probably didn't get as many runs as we wanted, but we bowled so well. We fielded our skin out," Karthik said. "We did everything possible

and showed the kind of commitment that players have toward the team. But towards the end, we got two great batters who came in and absolutely smashed it. And that happens in a T20 game." Bhuvneshwar Kumar was once again the standout performer, delivering his best figures for the franchise with 3/26, surpassing his effort in the previous match. It also marked his third three-wicket haul of the season, underlining his consistency with the ball. "Bhuvni and Hoffs' (Josh Hazlewood) overs were so good, and Rasikh as well. The 19th over was on point, and obviously we tried to take it as deep as possible." "Then (Romario) Shepherd had a couple of good balls and a couple of rubbly shots from David Miller as well. So overall, happy with the bowling effort. Could we have done a little better? Definitely.

"In a game like this, that's what you're always thinking, where could we have done a little better 10 per cent here and there. Credit to Delhi Capitals as well, I thought they played very nicely," Karthik highlighted the execution in key moments with

the ball. Karthik further underlined the team's mindset. "Understanding where we could have done a little better is number one, and you want them to have that fighting spirit, the belief that we can take the game deep," said the former India stumper.

"And probably towards the back end, if it got a little lucky for a couple more balls, you never know. But overall, the fighting spirit and the attitude shown by the 12 that took the field were very fulfilling in terms of heart and the mindset they went in with. That's encouraging for us as a team." The match also marked a historic milestone, becoming the 100th IPL game hosted at the M Chinnaswamy Stadium, the most for any venue in the tournament, with RCB the only team to have played all 100 matches at a single venue.

Boost for struggling KKR as Pathirana arrives in city

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

Sri Lankan pacer Matheesha Pathirana has finally arrived in the city to join Kolkata Knight Riders, giving a much-needed boost to the side that is currently languishing at the bottom of the IPL table. The franchise confirmed the development on Sunday.

Having recovered from a calf strain sustained in the T20 World Cup, Pathirana cleared the mandatory fitness test by Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC) before receiving a no-objection certificate.

He has linked up with the squad ahead of their match against the Rajasthan Royals on Sunday. However, he is unlikely to be named in the playing XI straightaway, as



the team's medical team will first assess his match fitness over a couple of training sessions. The slinger pacer, who was bought by KKR for '18 crore at the last IPL auction, was always expected to miss the initial matches after suffering a calf strain during the T20 World Cup earlier this

year. Pathirana was initially expected to join before their game against the Gujarat Titans in Ahmedabad on Friday. The development comes as a big relief for KKR, who are still searching for their first win after six matches and remain at the bottom of the points table.

Serie A: Napoli booed after losing to Lazio

DANIELLA MATAR ■ Milan

Napoli was jeered off the field after it lost 2-0 at home to Lazio – a result that saw Inter Milan take a huge step toward winning the Serie A title next week.

Matteo Cancellieri and Toma Basic scored for Lazio, which could have

won by a greater margin on Saturday had it not been for a saved penalty and several other missed opportunities. Inter can now claim the league crown if it wins at Torino next Sunday and Napoli fails to beat lowly Cremonese two days earlier. (AP)

This could be turning point for SRH: Steyn after win against CSK

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Pace great Dale Steyn on Sunday reckoned the victory over Chennai Super Kings could be a "turning point" for Sunrisers Hyderabad, propelling them into the top four of the IPL standings.

SRH are in good form currently, having secured back-to-back wins, including a

10-run victory over CSK at Chepauk on Saturday.

Speaking about the win against CSK on Star Sports, Steyn said, "This victory of SRH against CSK shows that they are back to their best after a slow start to the season." Abhishek Sharma and Heinrich Klaasen fired with the bat to guide SRH to 194/9, and the bowlers then responded brilliantly to



restrict CSK to 184/8, with Eshan Malinga picking 3/29 in four overs.

"At the mid-innings break, I was having a chat with Heinrich Klaasen, and he told me he felt Sunrisers were probably 10 or 15 runs short of where they needed to be. He said a huge bowling effort would be required to secure the win. That is what Sunrisers went

out and did," Steyn said. "You could see they fielded extremely hard. They took tough catches. They were committed to the cause. When they finally won, I was watching Heinrich Klaasen fielding at long-off. He turned to the crowd, pumped his chest, and held the SRH badge to say, 'Thank you for backing us, we're back in this.'